



Advanced Mathematics A

Lecture Notes, Volume I

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知之者不如好之者，好之者不如乐之者 — 《论语·雍也》

Preface

These lecture notes were prepared for the course *Advanced Mathematics A* at Peking University. They are intended primarily for students taking the course, but they may also serve as a companion for review and independent study. The aim is to present the main ideas of calculus as a coherent mathematical subject, with careful definitions, meaningful examples, and enough detail to support work beyond what can be covered in lectures.

Relationship to the Peking University Textbook

The notes stand in continuity with the third edition of Peking University's *Advanced Mathematics* (《高等数学 (第三版) 上册》, 李忠周建莹编著) textbook. They inherit its central subject matter, its commitment to a substantial calculus course, and many of the standard concepts and methods that generations of students have learned from it. The textbook remains an essential course resource and should be read alongside these notes.

At the same time, this text is not a line-by-line rewriting of the textbook. Some topics are reorganized to make their logical dependencies more visible; some proofs are expanded to clarify their central ideas; and additional examples, counterexamples, questions, and method summaries are included when they may improve understanding. Certain optional extensions are also added to connect elementary calculus with ideas that students will encounter later. The choice and emphasis of material therefore reflect the needs of this particular course as well as the author's own teaching experience.

A Work in Progress

Although considerable care has been taken in the preparation of these notes, their mathematical accuracy, exposition, and pedagogical design remain open to improvement. Errors, unclear arguments, infelicitous examples, and uneven choices of emphasis may still be present. Readers are warmly invited to send the author corrections, suggestions, and comments. Such feedback is valuable not only for improving later versions of the notes but also for improving the course itself.

Use and Circulation

These notes are provided for teaching and personal study in connection with the course. They may not be reproduced, redistributed, uploaded to public or shared platforms, or otherwise circulated without the prior permission of the author. All rights are reserved.

The author acknowledges the `ElegantLaTeX` template (<https://github.com/ElegantLaTeX/>), upon which the typesetting of these lecture notes is based.

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Introduction

Course Objectives

This course is designed to provide students with a solid foundation in the fundamental concepts, theories, and methods of calculus, while developing the ability to understand and use mathematical ideas rigorously and effectively. Students should learn not only how to carry out calculations, but also why the definitions, theorems, and methods of calculus take the forms that they do.

Throughout the course, students are expected to understand the principal ideas and concepts, master essential methods and techniques, recognize the logical structure underlying the theory, and apply mathematical knowledge to a range of problems. Computational fluency is important, but it should be supported by conceptual understanding: a correct calculation is most useful when one also knows its hypotheses, its meaning, and its limitations.

Through systematic study and practice, students should gradually develop mathematical intuition, rigorous logical reasoning, and the ability to think abstractly. They should also strengthen their capacity to formulate, analyze, and solve problems using appropriate mathematical language and tools. Ultimately, the course aims to build the mathematical foundation and analytical habits needed for further study in mathematics, science, engineering, and related disciplines.

Advice for Beginning Students

University mathematics asks for a more active kind of learning than simply following a worked calculation. The following habits will make the course more productive.

- **Be an independent learner.** Take responsibility for your own learning and do not rely solely on what is presented in class. Learn to identify what you do not yet understand, consult appropriate resources, and return to a difficult point more than once.
- **Read the textbook and the notes actively.** The textbook is an essential course resource. Assigned readings and materials remain part of the course whether or not every detail is discussed in lectures. When reading, pause to reconstruct arguments, check examples, and write down questions.
- **Do not treat lectures as an examination checklist.** Lectures and examinations are guided by the same syllabus and learning objectives, but they need not contain exactly the same material. Some ideas discussed in class may not appear on an examination, and a problem may require course material that was not worked out explicitly in class.
- **Prepare from the whole course, not from predictions.** When reviewing, pay attention to the syllabus, textbook, lecture notes, assigned work, and stated learning objectives. Trying to infer an examination solely from a list of lecture examples gives a narrow and unreliable picture of the subject.
- **Study consistently throughout the semester.** Mathematical understanding is cumulative. Regular reading, review, problem solving, and independent reflection are more effective than a short period of intensive preparation immediately before an assessment.
- **Interrogate the basic concepts.** Ask how a definition arises, what problem it resolves, why each condition

is present, and what the concept is really designed to capture. Being able to repeat a definition is not the same as understanding it.

- **Learn from examples and counterexamples.** A good example shows how a concept works; a counterexample shows where an apparently plausible statement fails. Use both positive and negative examples to test your understanding and to distinguish hypotheses from conclusions.
- **Practise with purpose.** Technique requires training, and solving exercises is indispensable. Nevertheless, indiscriminately accumulating difficult, unusual, or highly specialized problems is not the goal. After solving a problem, ask which idea made the solution possible, what alternatives were available, and how the method might apply elsewhere. Mathematical ideas and habits of thought are more fundamental than the number of problems completed.
- **Write mathematics precisely.** A solution should communicate its assumptions, reasoning, and conclusion. Practise stating definitions accurately, citing hypotheses when a theorem is used, and explaining the decisive step rather than presenting only a chain of formulas.

A Common Path to Mathematics

It is normal for serious mathematics to feel difficult. A definition may seem artificial on first reading, and a proof may remain opaque until one has examined several examples or attempted to reconstruct it independently. Temporary confusion is not evidence that one is incapable of learning the subject; it is often the stage at which deeper understanding begins.

Do not measure progress only by speed. Learn to remain with a question, to break it into smaller parts, to test simple cases, and to seek help after a genuine attempt. Over time, ideas that initially appeared isolated will begin to support one another. The goal is not to avoid ever becoming stuck, but to develop the patience, judgment, and mathematical tools needed to move forward.

Calculus rewards sustained attention. If you read thoughtfully, practise regularly, and keep asking why the theory works, you will gain more than a collection of techniques: you will acquire a language and a way of thinking that will remain useful far beyond this course.

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Chapter 1 Functions and Limits

Calculus studies change, but change can be discussed precisely only after its basic objects and limiting processes have been fixed. We therefore begin with the real number system, pass to functions as rules relating variable quantities, and then develop the limit of a sequence as our first rigorous limiting notion. Function limits lead to continuity, whose local definition yields global conclusions on closed bounded intervals.

1.1 Real Numbers and Basic Inequalities

知识点概要

- Review rational and irrational numbers and understand why calculus needs the full real number system.
- Interpret completeness as the property that prevents gaps in the number line.
- Use intervals and neighbourhoods to describe location and distance on the real line.
- Use the Archimedean property and density to choose integers and rational approximations.
- Control errors using absolute values, AM–GM, Bernoulli's inequality, and square-root estimates.

Calculus repeatedly asks what happens after an approximation is refined without end. For example, the decimal approximations

$$1.4, \quad 1.41, \quad 1.414, \quad 1.4142, \quad \dots$$

approach the length of the diagonal of a unit square. If our number system contained only rational numbers, that limiting length would be missing. The real numbers provide a number system in which such limiting processes can be carried out without falling into a gap.

1.1.1 From rational numbers to real numbers

Throughout these notes, the natural numbers (自然数) are

$$\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, 3, \dots\},$$

and the positive integers are denoted by $\mathbb{N}_{>0} = \{1, 2, 3, \dots\}$. We also use $\mathbb{Z}$ for the integers (整数) and $\mathbb{R}$ for the real numbers (实数).

Definition 1.1

A real number x is rational (有理数) if

$$x = \frac{p}{q}$$

for some $p \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $q \in \mathbb{Z} \setminus \{0\}$. The set of all rational numbers is $\mathbb{Q}$. A real number that is not rational is irrational (无理数); the set of irrational numbers is $\mathbb{R} \setminus \mathbb{Q}$.



A rational number has a terminating or eventually periodic decimal expansion, and conversely every terminating or eventually periodic decimal represents a rational number. Irrational numbers have nonperiodic infinite decimal expansions. This decimal description is useful for intuition, but the decisive distinction is whether the number can be represented as a ratio of integers.

Proposition 1.1

If p is a prime number, then $\sqrt{p}$ is irrational.



Proof Strategy. We take *Euclid's lemma* (欧几里得引理) as known prerequisite knowledge: if p is prime and $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$, then

$$p \mid ab \implies p \mid a \text{ or } p \mid b.$$

Assume that $\sqrt{p} = m/n$ is a fraction in lowest terms. After squaring, apply the lemma twice to force p to divide both m and n , contradicting the lowest-terms assumption.

Proof Suppose, to the contrary, that

$$\sqrt{p} = \frac{m}{n},$$

where $m, n \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ and m, n have no common factor greater than 1. Then

$$m^2 = pn^2.$$

Thus $p \mid m^2$. By Euclid's lemma applied to $m^2 = m \cdot m$, we have $p \mid m$, so $m = pk$ for some $k \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$. Substitution gives

$$p^2 k^2 = pn^2,$$

hence $n^2 = pk^2$. By Euclid's lemma again, applied to $n^2 = n \cdot n$, we obtain $p \mid n$. This contradicts the assumption that m and n have no common factor greater than 1. Consequently, $\sqrt{p}$ is irrational. $\square$

In particular, $\sqrt{2}$ and $\sqrt{3}$ are irrational. The essential step is the contradiction with coprimality, not the particular prime chosen.

Example 1.1 A sum of two irrational numbers may require a new argument Prove that $\sqrt{2} + \sqrt{3}$ is irrational.

Idea. The sum of two irrational numbers need not be irrational, so their irrationality alone is insufficient. Assume the sum is rational, square it, and isolate $\sqrt{6}$.

Proof Suppose that $r = \sqrt{2} + \sqrt{3}$ is rational. Then

$$r^2 = 5 + 2\sqrt{6},$$

so

$$\sqrt{6} = \frac{r^2 - 5}{2}$$

would also be rational. But $\sqrt{6}$ is irrational by the same lowest-terms argument: if $\sqrt{6} = m/n$ in lowest terms, then $m^2 = 6n^2$ forces both 2 and 3 to divide m , hence $6 \mid m$; substitution then forces $6 \mid n$, a contradiction. Therefore $\sqrt{2} + \sqrt{3}$ is irrational. $\square$

The rational numbers are closed under addition, subtraction, multiplication, and division by a nonzero number. The real numbers have the same algebraic closure and, in addition, carry an order compatible with these operations. What distinguishes $\mathbb{R}$ from $\mathbb{Q}$ for calculus is a further property: completeness.

1.1.2 Order and completeness

The real numbers form an *ordered field* (有序域). In particular, the usual algebraic laws hold, exactly one of $a < b$, $a = b$, and $a > b$ holds for any $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$, and inequalities are compatible with addition and multiplication by positive numbers.

Completeness is best understood through bounded sets.

Definition 1.2

Let $E \subseteq \mathbb{R}$ be nonempty. A number $M \in \mathbb{R}$ is an upper bound (上界) of E if

$$x \leq M$$

for every $x \in E$. The set E is bounded above (有上界) if it has an upper bound. A number $s \in \mathbb{R}$ is the supremum (上确界) or least upper bound of E if

- (i) s is an upper bound of E ;
- (ii) every upper bound M of E satisfies $s \leq M$.

It is denoted by $s = \sup E$. A lower bound (下界) is a number m satisfying $m \leq x$ for every $x \in E$. The set is bounded below (有下界) if such an m exists. Its infimum (下确界), denoted by $\inf E$, is its greatest lower bound. A set is bounded (有界) if it is bounded both above and below. 

Example 1.2 A supremum need not be attained The set $E = (0, 1)$ has $\inf E = 0$ and $\sup E = 1$, but neither boundary belongs to E . In contrast, $F = (0, 1]$ has the same infimum and supremum, and 1 is also its maximum (最大值). A maximum is an upper bound that belongs to the set; a supremum need not belong to it. The corresponding distinction holds between an infimum and a minimum (最小值).

Proposition 1.2

Let E be nonempty and bounded above. A number s equals $\sup E$ if and only if it is an upper bound and, for every $\varepsilon > 0$, some $x \in E$ satisfies

$$s - \varepsilon < x \leq s.$$



Proof If $s = \sup E$, then $s - \varepsilon$ cannot be an upper bound, so such an x exists. Conversely, suppose the stated approximation property holds. Any $M < s$ fails to be an upper bound: take $\varepsilon = s - M$ to obtain $x > M$. Thus no upper bound is smaller than s , which is the definition of $\sup E$. $\square$

Axiom 1.1 (Least-Upper-Bound Property)

Every nonempty subset of $\mathbb{R}$ that is bounded above has a supremum in $\mathbb{R}$. 

We regard the least-upper-bound property (确界原理) as a fundamental property of $\mathbb{R}$, not as a theorem to be proved from algebra alone. It is one precise formulation of the *completeness* (完备性) of $\mathbb{R}$. It rules out gaps: whenever a nonempty set has points only up to some finite height, there is a real number marking its least possible upper boundary. Other completeness principles, such as the convergence of bounded monotone sequences and the Cauchy criterion, are equivalent to it. We shall derive the monotone sequence theorem in Section 1.3.

Comment. The rational numbers do not satisfy this property when they are considered by themselves. For example,

$$E = \{q \in \mathbb{Q} \mid q^2 < 2\}$$

is nonempty and bounded above in $\mathbb{Q}$, but it has no rational least upper bound. Its missing boundary is $\sqrt{2}$.

Completeness also implies the Archimedean property (阿基米德性质): the positive integers eventually exceed every prescribed real number.

Proposition 1.3 (Archimedean Property)

For every $x \in \mathbb{R}$, there exists $n \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ such that $n > x$. Equivalently, for every $\varepsilon > 0$, there exists $n \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ such that $1/n < \varepsilon$.

Idea. If the positive integers had a real upper bound, completeness would provide a least one. But moving one integer step forward would cross that boundary.

Proof Suppose that $\mathbb{N}_{>0}$ were bounded above, and let $s = \sup \mathbb{N}_{>0}$. The number $s - 1$ is not an upper bound, so there exists $n \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ with $n > s - 1$. Then $n + 1 \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ and $n + 1 > s$, contradicting the fact that s is an upper bound. Thus $\mathbb{N}_{>0}$ is not bounded above.

For the equivalent formulation, apply the first statement to $x = 1/\varepsilon$. Then $n > 1/\varepsilon$, and hence $1/n < \varepsilon$. $\square$

The following density property (稠密性) says that the real line contains rational and irrational numbers at every scale.

Proposition 1.4 (Density of Rational and Irrational Numbers)

If $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ and $a < b$, then there exist $r \in \mathbb{Q}$ and $u \in \mathbb{R} \setminus \mathbb{Q}$ such that

$$a < r < b, \quad a < u < b.$$

Proof By Proposition 1.3, choose $n \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ such that

$$n(b - a) > 1.$$

Let

$$m = \lfloor na \rfloor + 1.$$

Here $\lfloor t \rfloor$ denotes the greatest integer not exceeding t . Such an integer exists by the Archimedean property and the well-ordering of the positive integers. Then $na < m \leq na + 1 < nb$, so

$$a < \frac{m}{n} < b.$$

Thus $r = m/n$ is a rational number in (a, b) .

Apply the rational-density statement to a nonempty open subinterval of

$$\left(\frac{a}{\sqrt{2}}, \frac{b}{\sqrt{2}} \right)$$

that does not contain 0. It contains a nonzero rational number q . Then $u = q\sqrt{2}$ lies in (a, b) and is irrational, because $q \neq 0$ and $\sqrt{2}$ is irrational. $\square$

Comment. Density and completeness express different facts. The rational numbers are dense in $\mathbb{R}$, yet $\mathbb{Q}$ is not complete. Having points arbitrarily close to every location does not mean that all limiting boundary points belong to the set.

1.1.3 The real line, intervals, and neighbourhoods

After choosing an origin, a positive direction, and a unit length, every real number corresponds to one point on a line and every point corresponds to one real number. We therefore identify $\mathbb{R}$ with the *real line* (数轴). The inequality $a < b$ means that the point a lies to the left of the point b .

For $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ with $a < b$, the open interval (开区间), closed interval (闭区间), and two half-open intervals

(半开半闭区间)are

$$(a, b) = \{x \in \mathbb{R} \mid a < x < b\},$$

$$[a, b] = \{x \in \mathbb{R} \mid a \leq x \leq b\},$$

$$[a, b) = \{x \in \mathbb{R} \mid a \leq x < b\},$$

$$(a, b] = \{x \in \mathbb{R} \mid a < x \leq b\}.$$

Infinite intervals include

$$(-\infty, a), \quad (-\infty, a], \quad (a, +\infty), \quad [a, +\infty),$$

and the whole real line is $(-\infty, +\infty)$. The symbols $+\infty$ and $-\infty$ are not real numbers and are never included as endpoints.

Definition 1.3

Let $a \in \mathbb{R}$ and $r > 0$. The r -neighbourhood (邻域) of a is

$$U_r(a) = (a - r, a + r) = \{x \in \mathbb{R} \mid |x - a| < r\}.$$

The corresponding punctured r -neighbourhood (去心邻域) is

$$U_r(a) \setminus \{a\} = \{x \in \mathbb{R} \mid 0 < |x - a| < r\}.$$



Neighbourhood notation translates a geometric statement into an inequality. The condition $x \in U_r(a)$ says exactly that the distance from x to a is less than r . Punctured neighbourhoods will become essential for function limits, where the behaviour near a may be independent of the value at a itself.

1.1.4 Absolute value and distance estimates

Definition 1.4

For $x \in \mathbb{R}$, its absolute value (绝对值) is

$$|x| = \begin{cases} x, & x \geq 0, \\ -x, & x < 0. \end{cases}$$



Geometrically, $|x|$ is the distance from x to 0, while $|x - y|$ is the distance between x and y . The following elementary equivalences should become automatic: for $r > 0$,

$$|x| < r \iff -r < x < r,$$

$$|x| \leq r \iff -r \leq x \leq r,$$

$$|x - a| < r \iff a - r < x < a + r.$$

Theorem 1.1

For all $x, y \in \mathbb{R}$, the triangle inequality (三角不等式) and reverse triangle inequality (反三角不等式) state that

$$|x + y| \leq |x| + |y|, \tag{1.1}$$

$$||x| - |y|| \leq |x - y|. \tag{1.2}$$

More generally, for all $a, b, c \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$|a - c| \leq |a - b| + |b - c|.$$



Idea. The first inequality says that travelling from 0 to $x + y$ directly cannot be longer than travelling first from 0 to x and then by the displacement y . The reverse inequality is obtained by applying the same principle in both directions.

Proof Since $-|x| \leq x \leq |x|$ and $-|y| \leq y \leq |y|$, addition gives

$$-(|x| + |y|) \leq x + y \leq |x| + |y|.$$

This is equivalent to (1.1).

Applying the triangle inequality to $x = (x - y) + y$ gives

$$|x| \leq |x - y| + |y|,$$

so $|x| - |y| \leq |x - y|$. Interchanging x and y gives $|y| - |x| \leq |x - y|$. Together these inequalities yield (1.2).

Finally, set $x = a - b$ and $y = b - c$ in the triangle inequality. $\square$

Example 1.3 Turning a distance condition into an interval Solve

$$|2x - 3| < 5.$$

Solution The inequality is equivalent to

$$-5 < 2x - 3 < 5,$$

and hence to

$$-1 < x < 4.$$

Thus the solution set is $(-1, 4)$.

Geometric Interpretation. Equivalently,

$$|2x - 3| = 2 \left| x - \frac{3}{2} \right| < 5$$

says that x lies within distance $5/2$ of $3/2$.

Example 1.4 A reusable estimate Prove that $|x| < b + |a|$ whenever $|x - a| < b$.

Proof Then

$$|x| = |x - a + a| \leq |x - a| + |a| < b + |a|.$$

$\square$

Technique. This simple observation is repeatedly used in limit proofs: first restrict x or a sequence term to a convenient neighbourhood, then replace a variable factor by a constant bound.

Question. Why is the estimate $|x - y| \geq ||x| - |y||$ called a reverse triangle inequality?

1.1.5 Selected inequalities for later use

The following estimates will reappear in sequence limits. Their value is that they replace nonlinear expressions by quantities that are easier to control.

Proposition 1.5 (Arithmetic–Geometric Mean Inequality)

For $u, v \geq 0$,

$$\sqrt{uv} \leq \frac{u + v}{2},$$

with equality if and only if $u = v$. This is the two-variable arithmetic–geometric mean inequality (算术平均数与几何平均数不等式), or AM–GM.



Proof The inequality $(\sqrt{u} - \sqrt{v})^2 \geq 0$ gives $u + v \geq 2\sqrt{uv}$. Equality holds exactly when $\sqrt{u} = \sqrt{v}$. $\square$

Example 1.5 A bound for an iteration Let $a > 0$. Show that the map

$$T(x) = \frac{1}{2} \left(x + \frac{a}{x} \right)$$

sends $[\sqrt{a}, +\infty)$ into itself and satisfies $T(x) \leq x$ there.

Proof If $x > 0$, AM–GM gives

$$\frac{1}{2} \left(x + \frac{a}{x} \right) \geq \sqrt{a}.$$

Furthermore, when $x \geq \sqrt{a}$,

$$\frac{1}{2} \left(x + \frac{a}{x} \right) \leq x.$$

$\square$

Looking Ahead. Thus the averaging operation sends $[\sqrt{a}, +\infty)$ into itself and does not increase its input. These two observations will prove boundedness and monotonicity of a recursive sequence.

Proposition 1.6 (Bernoulli's Inequality)

For $t \geq -1$ and $n \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$, Bernoulli's inequality (伯努利不等式) is

$$(1 + t)^n \geq 1 + nt.$$



Proof The assertion is an equality for $n = 1$. If it holds for n , multiplying by $1 + t \geq 0$ gives

$$(1 + t)^{n+1} \geq (1 + nt)(1 + t) = 1 + (n + 1)t + nt^2 \geq 1 + (n + 1)t.$$

Induction completes the proof. $\square$

Example 1.6 Control square roots by rationalizing For $u, v \geq 0$ with $u + v > 0$, prove that

$$|\sqrt{u} - \sqrt{v}| = \frac{|u - v|}{\sqrt{u} + \sqrt{v}}.$$

If $u, v \geq c > 0$, then

$$|\sqrt{u} - \sqrt{v}| \leq \frac{|u - v|}{2\sqrt{c}}.$$

Even without a positive lower bound, we still have

$$|\sqrt{u} - \sqrt{v}| \leq \sqrt{|u - v|}.$$

Proof Multiplying by the conjugate gives

$$|\sqrt{u} - \sqrt{v}| = \frac{|(\sqrt{u} - \sqrt{v})(\sqrt{u} + \sqrt{v})|}{\sqrt{u} + \sqrt{v}} = \frac{|u - v|}{\sqrt{u} + \sqrt{v}}.$$

If $u, v \geq c > 0$, then $\sqrt{u} + \sqrt{v} \geq 2\sqrt{c}$, which yields the first estimate.

For the last estimate, assume $u \geq v$. Then $\sqrt{u} + \sqrt{v} \geq \sqrt{u - v}$; rationalization gives the result when $u > v$, and the case $u = v$ is immediate. $\square$

Technique. The useful estimate depends on whether the denominator can be kept away from zero.

1.1.6 Key Concepts, Methods, and Further Remarks

This section has two complementary layers. Absolute values and inequalities provide quantitative control, while completeness and the Archimedean property provide existence. Keeping these layers distinct helps identify which part of an argument is computational and which part depends on the structure of the real numbers.

1. *Find the structural contradiction.* In an irrationality proof, put a hypothetical fraction in lowest terms before using divisibility.

2. *Translate geometry into inequalities.* Distances on the real line are absolute values, and neighbourhoods are interval conditions.
3. *Control a complicated expression by a simpler one.* Split sums by the triangle inequality, rationalize square-root differences, and use AM–GM or Bernoulli when their hypotheses fit. For a homogeneous expression with positive variables, normalization can reduce the number of variables: dividing $u + v \geq 2\sqrt{uv}$ by $v > 0$ reduces it to $t + 1 \geq 2\sqrt{t}$ with $t = u/v$.
4. *Choose an integer backward from the desired error.* To make $C/n < \varepsilon$ with $C > 0$, choose an integer $N > C/\varepsilon$. Then the estimate holds for every $n \geq N$, not just one index.
5. *Identify where completeness is used.* Algebra and order alone are shared by $\mathbb{Q}$ and $\mathbb{R}$. Existence theorems involving limits or least upper bounds require the additional completeness of $\mathbb{R}$.

Caution. Do not treat $\pm\infty$ as real numbers. Expressions such as $a < +\infty$ are useful notation, but ordinary field operations with ∞ are not defined in $\mathbb{R}$.

Looking Ahead. Suprema need not be attained, but they can be approached from below. This approximation property is the decisive step in proving that a bounded nondecreasing sequence converges.

Exercise 1.1

1. Prove that $\sqrt{6}$ is irrational.
2. Let $r \in \mathbb{Q}$ and $u \in \mathbb{R} \setminus \mathbb{Q}$. Prove that $r + u$ is irrational, and prove that ru is irrational when $r \neq 0$.
3. Generalize Proposition 1.1 by proving that $\sqrt{p}$ is irrational whenever p is a positive integer that is not a perfect square.

Hint. Use uniqueness of prime factorization: what can be said about the exponents in the prime factorization of a perfect square? If $\sqrt{p} = m/n$ with $m, n \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$, compare prime exponents on the two sides of $m^2 = pn^2$.

4. Prove that every nonempty open interval contains infinitely many rational numbers and infinitely many irrational numbers.
5. Write each set in interval notation:

$$\{x \in \mathbb{R} \mid |x - 2| \leq 3\}, \quad \{x \in \mathbb{R} \mid 0 < |x + 1| < 2\}.$$

6. Solve the inequalities

$$|3x + 1| \geq 2, \quad |x - 1| < |x + 2|.$$

7. Prove that

$$|x + y + z| \leq |x| + |y| + |z|$$

for all $x, y, z \in \mathbb{R}$.

8. If $|x - a| < r$ and $|y - b| < s$, prove that

$$|(x + y) - (a + b)| < r + s.$$

Give a geometric interpretation.

9. Let $E \subseteq \mathbb{R}$ be nonempty and bounded above. Prove directly from the definition that $\sup E$ is unique.
10. Explain why the density of $\mathbb{Q}$ in $\mathbb{R}$ does not imply the completeness of $\mathbb{Q}$.
11. Let

$$A = \{x > 0 \mid x^2 < 5\}.$$

Determine $\sup A$, $\inf A$, and whether either extremum is attained. Justify every assertion from the definitions.

12. Let $E \subseteq \mathbb{R}$ be nonempty and bounded, let $c \in \mathbb{R}$, and let $\lambda > 0$. Prove that

$$\sup(c + E) = c + \sup E, \quad \sup(\lambda E) = \lambda \sup E,$$

where $c + E = \{c + x : x \in E\}$ and $\lambda E = \{\lambda x : x \in E\}$. State the corresponding formulas for infima.

13. Let $a < b$. Find the minimum value of $|x - a| + |x - b|$ for $x \in \mathbb{R}$, and determine all points at which it is attained. Give both an algebraic and a geometric explanation.

14. Prove that

$$x(1 - x) \leq \frac{1}{4}$$

for every $x \in [0, 1]$, and determine the equality case.

15. Prove by rationalization that, for $t \geq 0$,

$$0 \leq \sqrt{1+t} - 1 \leq \frac{t}{2}.$$

Explain why the constant $1/2$ cannot be replaced by a smaller positive constant valid for every sufficiently small $t > 0$.

Supplement Exercises

- S1. Let $E, F \subseteq \mathbb{R}$ be nonempty and bounded above, and define $E + F = \{x + y : x \in E, y \in F\}$. Prove directly from the least-upper-bound property that

$$\sup(E + F) = \sup E + \sup F.$$

- S2. If E and F are nonempty and bounded, prove that

$$\sup(E \cup F) = \max\{\sup E, \sup F\}, \quad \inf(E \cup F) = \min\{\inf E, \inf F\}.$$

Which analogous formulas for $E \cap F$ fail without additional hypotheses?

- S3. Prove the finite Cauchy–Schwarz inequality

$$\left(\sum_{k=1}^n a_k b_k \right)^2 \leq \left(\sum_{k=1}^n a_k^2 \right) \left(\sum_{k=1}^n b_k^2 \right)$$

by considering $\sum_{k=1}^n (ta_k - b_k)^2$ as a quadratic polynomial in t . Determine the equality condition.

- S4. For $m \in \mathbb{N}$, prove by induction that the arithmetic–geometric mean inequality holds for 2^m positive numbers:

$$\frac{x_1 + \cdots + x_{2^m}}{2^m} \geq (x_1 \cdots x_{2^m})^{1/2^m}.$$

- S5. Find the best constant C such that

$$(x + y + z)^2 \leq C(x^2 + y^2 + z^2)$$

for all $x, y, z \in \mathbb{R}$, and prove that your constant is optimal.

- S6. Let

$$B = \{q \in \mathbb{Q} : q \geq 0 \text{ and } q^2 < 2\}.$$

Prove that B has a supremum as a subset of $\mathbb{R}$, but has no supremum as a subset of the ordered field $\mathbb{Q}$.

1.2 Variables and Functions

核心概念与图像方法

- ❑ Understand a function as a mapping with a specified domain, codomain, and assignment rule.
- ❑ Move between formulas, tables, verbal rules, piecewise definitions, and graphs.
- ❑ Combine functions by arithmetic operations and composition while tracking every domain restriction.
- ❑ Review elementary and non-elementary functions without confusing an expression with a function.
- ❑ Describe monotonicity, parity, periodicity, boundedness, and graph transformations.
- ❑ Test injectivity before constructing an inverse and interpret inverse graphs geometrically.

Many quantities vary, and one quantity often depends on another. The distance travelled at constant speed depends on time, the area of a circle depends on its radius, and the length of a metal rod depends on temperature. Calculus studies such dependence, so its basic object is the function.

The essential point is not that a function has a formula. The essential point is that every allowed input has one, and only one, output.

1.2.1 Functions as mappings

Definition 1.5

Let $X, Y \subseteq \mathbb{R}$. A function (函数) f from X to Y , written

$$f: X \rightarrow Y,$$

is a rule that assigns to every $x \in X$ a unique number $f(x) \in Y$. The set X is the domain (定义域), and Y is the codomain (陪域). The range (值域), or image (像), of f is

$$f(X) = \{f(x) \mid x \in X\}.$$

Thus $f(X) \subseteq Y$, and equality need not hold.



A function is also called a *mapping* (映射).

The input x is often called the *independent variable* (自变量).

The value $f(x)$ is the *dependent variable* (因变量). These names emphasize variation, but the definition itself is set-theoretic: a function consists of a domain together with an assignment rule.

Important Distinction. The domain is part of the function. The formulas

$$f(x) = x^2 \quad (x \in \mathbb{R}) \quad \text{and} \quad g(x) = x^2 \quad (x \in [0, +\infty))$$

define different functions, even though the displayed expressions are identical. Their ranges are also different if the first domain is changed further.

Definition 1.6

Two functions $f: X \rightarrow Y$ and $g: X' \rightarrow Y'$ are equal if $X = X'$, $Y = Y'$, and

$$f(x) = g(x)$$

for every $x \in X$.



A function may be represented by a formula, a table, a graph, an algorithm, or a verbal rule. For example, a timetable assigning a departure time to each train is a function even if no useful algebraic formula describes it.

The *graph* (图像) of $f: X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is the set

$$\{(x, f(x)) \in \mathbb{R}^2 \mid x \in X\}.$$

A plane curve is the graph of a function of x precisely when every vertical line meets it in at most one point. This vertical-line test is simply the uniqueness condition in Definition 1.5 expressed geometrically. The horizontal projection of the graph gives the domain, and the vertical projection gives the range. Zeros are the points where the graph meets the x -axis, while the portions above and below that axis show the sign of the function.

1.2.2 Domains, ranges, and piecewise definitions

When a function is given by a formula and no domain is stated, its *natural domain* (自然定义域) is the largest subset of $\mathbb{R}$ on which the formula gives a real value. This convention must be replaced by the actual physical or mathematical domain when context imposes additional restrictions.

Example 1.7 Determining a natural domain Find the natural domain of

$$f(x) = \sqrt{\frac{1+x}{1-x}}.$$

Solution We need $x \neq 1$ and

$$\frac{1+x}{1-x} \geq 0.$$

The critical points are -1 and 1 . A sign analysis gives

$$-1 \leq x < 1.$$

Thus the natural domain is $[-1, 1)$.

Check. Notice that solving only $1+x \geq 0$ would miss the sign of the denominator.

Definition 1.7

A piecewise-defined function (分段函数) is a single function whose values are specified by different formulas on different parts of its domain.



For instance,

$$T(x) = \begin{cases} 0, & 0 \leq x \leq 5000, \\ 0.03(x - 5000), & 5000 < x \leq 8000, \end{cases}$$

defines one function on $[0, 8000]$. At an endpoint where two pieces might meet, the inequalities must make clear which formula applies.

Example 1.8 Range depends on the domain Let $f(x) = x^2$. Determine its range when the domain is respectively $\mathbb{R}$, $[-2, 1]$, and $(2, +\infty)$.

Solution On $\mathbb{R}$, the range is $[0, +\infty)$. On $[-2, 1]$, the range is $[0, 4]$. On $(2, +\infty)$, the range is $(4, +\infty)$.

Interpretation. The formula alone does not determine the range; the domain matters.

1.2.3 Operations and composition

Let $f: X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ and $g: Z \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. Their sum, difference, and product are defined on $X \cap Z$ by

$$(f + g)(x) = f(x) + g(x),$$

$$(f - g)(x) = f(x) - g(x),$$

$$(fg)(x) = f(x)g(x).$$

The quotient is defined by

$$\left(\frac{f}{g}\right)(x) = \frac{f(x)}{g(x)}$$

on

$$\{x \in X \cap Z \mid g(x) \neq 0\}.$$

Definition 1.8

Let $g: X \rightarrow Y$ and $f: Y_0 \rightarrow Z$. The composition (复合函数) of f after g is

$$(f \circ g)(x) = f(g(x)).$$

Its domain is

$$\{x \in X \mid g(x) \in Y_0\}.$$



Composition is performed from right to left: first apply g , then apply f . It is associative whenever the compositions are defined, but it is generally not commutative.

Example 1.9 Composition changes the domain Let

$$f(t) = \sqrt{t}, \quad g(x) = x^2 - 1.$$

Determine both compositions and their domains.

Solution Then

$$(f \circ g)(x) = \sqrt{x^2 - 1}$$

has domain

$$(-\infty, -1] \cup [1, +\infty).$$

In the other order,

$$(g \circ f)(x) = x - 1$$

has domain $[0, +\infty)$, not all of $\mathbb{R}$.

Domain Check. Although the final formula $x - 1$ makes sense for every real x , the composition remembers that $\sqrt{x}$ was evaluated first.

Important Distinction. Algebraic simplification does not automatically enlarge the domain of a function. For example,

$$\frac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1} = x + 1$$

only for $x \neq 1$. The expression on the left and the function $x \mapsto x + 1$ on $\mathbb{R}$ are not the same function.

1.2.4 Basic elementary functions

The standard building blocks of one-variable calculus are the basic elementary functions. Their domains must always be kept in view.

Table 1.1: Basic elementary functions and their standard real domains.

Type	Typical function	Standard domain
Constant	$f(x) = c$	$\mathbb{R}$
Power	$f(x) = x^\alpha$	depends on α
Exponential	$f(x) = a^x, a > 0, a \neq 1$	$\mathbb{R}$
Logarithmic	$f(x) = \log_a x, a > 0, a \neq 1$	$(0, +\infty)$
Trigonometric	$\sin x, \cos x$	$\mathbb{R}$
Trigonometric	$\tan x$	$\mathbb{R} \setminus \{\frac{\pi}{2} + k\pi \mid k \in \mathbb{Z}\}$
Inverse trigonometric	$\arcsin x, \arccos x$	$[-1, 1]$
Inverse trigonometric	$\arctan x$	$\mathbb{R}$

For real powers, x^α is always defined for $x > 0$ by

$$x^\alpha = \exp(\alpha \ln x).$$

The maximal real domain may be larger for special exponents. For example, $x^{1/3}$ is defined on $\mathbb{R}$, $x^{1/2}$ on $[0, +\infty)$, and x^{-2} on $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$. When $\alpha = m/n$ is in lowest terms, the parity of n and the sign of m determine whether negative inputs and the input 0 are allowed.

The natural logarithm is denoted by $\ln x$. The constant e and its construction from a sequence are developed in Section 1.3. Angles in trigonometric functions are measured in radians.

Definition 1.9

An elementary function (初等函数) is a function obtained from basic elementary functions by finitely many arithmetic operations and compositions, on the domain where the resulting expression is defined. 

Two useful functions built from exponentials are the hyperbolic sine and cosine:

$$\sinh x = \frac{e^x - e^{-x}}{2}, \quad \cosh x = \frac{e^x + e^{-x}}{2}.$$

Direct calculation gives

$$\cosh^2 x - \sinh^2 x = 1.$$

These functions will later appear naturally in differential equations and integration.

Not every function is elementary, and not every function is represented by a smooth curve. The following examples are especially useful.

Example 1.10 Floor and fractional-part functions The floor function (取整函数) is

$$x \mapsto \lfloor x \rfloor,$$

where $\lfloor x \rfloor$ is the greatest integer not exceeding x . Its defining property is

$$\lfloor x \rfloor \leq x < \lfloor x \rfloor + 1.$$

The fractional part (小数部分) of x is

$$\{x\} = x - \lfloor x \rfloor \in [0, 1).$$

For negative inputs, this differs from simply retaining the digits after the decimal point; for example, $\{-3.14\} = 0.86$.

Example 1.11 Sign and Dirichlet functions The *sign function* (符号函数) is

$$\operatorname{sgn} x = \begin{cases} 1, & x > 0, \\ 0, & x = 0, \\ -1, & x < 0. \end{cases}$$

The *Dirichlet function* (狄利克雷函数) is

$$D(x) = \begin{cases} 1, & x \in \mathbb{Q}, \\ 0, & x \in \mathbb{R} \setminus \mathbb{Q}. \end{cases}$$

By Proposition 1.4, every open interval contains both rational and irrational numbers. Thus the graph of D consists of dense points on the two horizontal lines $y = 0$ and $y = 1$; it is not a curve in the usual visual sense. This example shows why a function must be defined as a rule rather than as a formula or a drawn curve.

1.2.5 Qualitative properties and graph transformations

Formulas give exact values, but calculus also studies the overall behaviour of a function. The following properties describe that behaviour without requiring us to calculate every value.

Definition 1.10

Let $f: X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$.

(i) On an interval $I \subseteq X$, the function is nondecreasing if

$$x_1 < x_2 \implies f(x_1) \leq f(x_2),$$

and nonincreasing if the final inequality is reversed. A function of either type is a monotone function (单调函数) on I . Replacing $\leq$ or $\geq$ by a strict inequality defines strictly increasing and strictly decreasing functions.

(ii) Suppose X is symmetric about 0. The function is an even function (偶函数) if $f(-x) = f(x)$ for every $x \in X$, and an odd function (奇函数) if $f(-x) = -f(x)$ for every $x \in X$.

(iii) A number $T > 0$ is a period of f if

$$x \in X \iff x + T \in X, \quad f(x + T) = f(x) \quad (x \in X).$$

A function having a period is a periodic function (周期函数).



Even functions have graphs symmetric about the y -axis, while odd functions have graphs symmetric about the origin. The function $x \mapsto |x|$ is even, nonincreasing on $(-\infty, 0]$, and nondecreasing on $[0, +\infty)$. The sine function is odd and 2π -periodic; the cosine function is even and 2π -periodic.

These properties are logically independent. For example, $\tan x$ is periodic but unbounded on its domain. The function

$$g(x) = \frac{1}{1 + x^2}$$

is bounded but not periodic: if $T > 0$, then $g(T) < g(0)$, so T cannot be a period.

Graph transformations can be read by tracking what happens to a typical point $(u, f(u))$. If the domain of f is D , then the following table records both the geometry and the new domain.

When $a < 0$, the third transformation also reflects the graph across the x -axis, and the fourth reflects it across the y -axis. The domain must be transformed together with the graph; a visually correct shift with an unchanged domain may define the wrong function.

Table 1.2: Basic transformations of the graph $y = f(x)$.

New function	Effect on the graph	Domain
$f(x) + c$	vertical shift by c	D
$f(x - c)$	horizontal shift by c	$\{u + c \mid u \in D\}$
$af(x)$	vertical scale by $ a $	D
$f(ax), a \neq 0$	horizontal scale by $1/ a $	$\{x \mid ax \in D\}$

Question. Does either implication hold: periodic $\Rightarrow$ bounded or bounded $\Rightarrow$ periodic? Can one implication be repaired by adding a natural hypothesis?

1.2.6 Injectivity, surjectivity, and inverse functions

Definition 1.11

Let $f: X \rightarrow Y$.

(i) The function is injective (单射) if

$$f(x_1) = f(x_2) \implies x_1 = x_2.$$

(ii) It is surjective (满射) if $f(X) = Y$.

(iii) It is bijective (双射) if it is both injective and surjective.



Injectivity says that distinct inputs never merge into the same output. Surjectivity depends on the chosen codomain: the function $x \mapsto x^2$ is surjective from $\mathbb{R}$ to $[0, +\infty)$ but not from $\mathbb{R}$ to $\mathbb{R}$.

Theorem 1.2

A function $f: X \rightarrow Y$ has an inverse function (反函数) $f^{-1}: Y \rightarrow X$ if and only if f is bijective. In that case,

$$f^{-1}(f(x)) = x \quad (x \in X), \quad f(f^{-1}(y)) = y \quad (y \in Y).$$



Idea. Surjectivity guarantees that each proposed inverse input has a preimage, while injectivity guarantees that this preimage is unique. Together they make the inverse assignment a function.

Proof Suppose first that f is bijective. For every $y \in Y$, surjectivity gives at least one $x \in X$ with $f(x) = y$, and injectivity makes this x unique. Define $f^{-1}(y)$ to be that unique x . The two displayed identities follow directly.

Conversely, suppose that an inverse $f^{-1}: Y \rightarrow X$ exists. For every $y \in Y$, the element $x = f^{-1}(y)$ satisfies $f(x) = y$, so f is surjective. If $f(x_1) = f(x_2)$, applying f^{-1} gives $x_1 = x_2$, so f is injective. Thus f is bijective. $\square$

An injective function $f: X \rightarrow Y$ is automatically a bijection from X onto its range $f(X)$, and hence has an inverse

$$f^{-1}: f(X) \rightarrow X.$$

For example, $x \mapsto x^2$ is not injective on $\mathbb{R}$, but its restriction to $[0, +\infty)$ is injective and has inverse $x \mapsto \sqrt{x}$. Likewise, $\sin x$ is not injective on $\mathbb{R}$. Its restriction to $[-\pi/2, \pi/2]$ is bijective onto $[-1, 1]$, and the inverse of this restricted function is $\arcsin x$.

Example 1.12 Constructing an inverse while tracking its domain Let

$$f: (0, +\infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, \quad f(x) = \frac{2}{x} - \frac{x}{2}.$$

Prove that f is bijective and find f^{-1} .

Proof If $0 < x_1 < x_2$, then

$$\frac{2}{x_1} > \frac{2}{x_2} \quad \text{and} \quad -\frac{x_1}{2} > -\frac{x_2}{2},$$

so $f(x_1) > f(x_2)$. Thus f is injective.

For any $y \in \mathbb{R}$, the equation $y = f(x)$ is equivalent to

$$x^2 + 2yx - 4 = 0.$$

Its roots are $-y \pm \sqrt{y^2 + 4}$. Exactly one is positive, namely

$$x = -y + \sqrt{y^2 + 4},$$

because $\sqrt{y^2 + 4} > |y|$. Hence every $y \in \mathbb{R}$ has exactly one preimage in $(0, +\infty)$, and

$$f^{-1}(y) = -y + \sqrt{y^2 + 4} \quad (y \in \mathbb{R}).$$

□

The graph of an inverse is obtained by interchanging the coordinates in every ordered pair. It is therefore the reflection of the original graph across the line $y = x$.

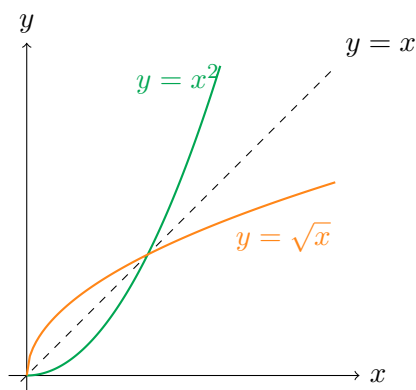


Figure 1.1: The graphs of $x \mapsto x^2$ on $[0, +\infty)$ and its inverse $x \mapsto \sqrt{x}$ are reflections across $y = x$.

Comment. The notation f^{-1} denotes an inverse function, not a reciprocal. In general,

$$f^{-1}(x) \neq \frac{1}{f(x)}.$$

1.2.7 Sequences and bounded functions

A sequence

$$a_1, a_2, a_3, \dots$$

is a function whose domain is $\mathbb{N}_{>0}$:

$$a: \mathbb{N}_{>0} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, \quad a(n) = a_n.$$

The order of the terms matters, so a sequence is not merely the set $\{a_n \mid n \geq 1\}$. This viewpoint connects the present section directly with sequence limits in Section 1.3.

Definition 1.12

Let $f: X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. The function f is bounded above on X if there exists $M \in \mathbb{R}$ such that

$$f(x) \leq M$$

for every $x \in X$. It is bounded below on X if there exists $m \in \mathbb{R}$ such that

$$m \leq f(x)$$

for every $x \in X$. It is a bounded function (有界函数) on X if it is bounded both above and below. 

Boundedness always refers to a specified domain. The function $f(x) = 1/x$ is bounded on $[1, +\infty)$ but unbounded on $(0, 1]$. The fact that $f(x)$ is a finite real number for every x in its domain does not supply one common bound valid for all inputs.

Proposition 1.7

A function $f: X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is bounded if and only if there exists $C \geq 0$ such that

$$|f(x)| \leq C$$

for every $x \in X$. 

Proof If f is bounded, choose $m, M \in \mathbb{R}$ such that

$$m \leq f(x) \leq M$$

for every $x \in X$. With $C = \max\{|m|, |M|\}$, we have $|f(x)| \leq C$.

Conversely, if $|f(x)| \leq C$, then

$$-C \leq f(x) \leq C$$

for every $x \in X$, so f is bounded. □

1.2.8 Section Summary and Problem-solving Strategies

The essential data of a function are its domain, codomain, and assignment rule. Formulas, graphs, and tables are representations of that data, not replacements for it. When working with a function, use the following order.

1. Identify the domain before simplifying or calculating.
2. Distinguish the codomain from the actual range.
3. For a composition, work from the inside out and impose every intermediate domain condition.
4. For an inverse, first check injectivity and determine the range that will become the inverse domain.
5. For qualitative properties, combine algebraic tests with graph symmetry, but verify conclusions on the stated domain.
6. For a graph transformation, transform the domain together with the points of the graph.
7. For boundedness, search for one constant valid for every input in the stated domain.

A compact trigonometric and hyperbolic toolkit

The formulas below are most useful when they are organized by their source rather than memorized as unrelated identities. The addition formulas generate the product-to-sum and sum-to-product formulas by addition, subtraction, and a change of variables.

For real u, v (and with nonzero denominators where tangent occurs),

Example 1.13 Derive a transformation instead of memorizing it Derive one product-to-sum formula and its corresponding sum-to-product formula.

Table 1.3: Trigonometric addition and subtraction formulas.

Function	Formula
Sine	$\sin(u \pm v) = \sin u \cos v \pm \cos u \sin v$
Cosine	$\cos(u \pm v) = \cos u \cos v \mp \sin u \sin v$
Tangent	$\tan(u \pm v) = \frac{\tan u \pm \tan v}{1 \mp \tan u \tan v}$

Table 1.4: Trigonometric product-to-sum and sum-to-product formulas.

Product to sum	Sum to product
$\sin u \sin v = \frac{\cos(u - v) - \cos(u + v)}{2}$	$\sin u + \sin v = 2 \sin \frac{u + v}{2} \cos \frac{u - v}{2}$
$\cos u \cos v = \frac{\cos(u - v) + \cos(u + v)}{2}$	$\sin u - \sin v = 2 \cos \frac{u + v}{2} \sin \frac{u - v}{2}$
$\sin u \cos v = \frac{\sin(u + v) + \sin(u - v)}{2}$	$\cos u + \cos v = 2 \cos \frac{u + v}{2} \cos \frac{u - v}{2}$
$\cos u \sin v = \frac{\sin(u + v) - \sin(u - v)}{2}$	$\cos u - \cos v = -2 \sin \frac{u + v}{2} \sin \frac{u - v}{2}$

Proof Adding the two sine addition formulas gives

$$\begin{aligned}
 \sin(u + v) + \sin(u - v) &= (\sin u \cos v + \cos u \sin v) \\
 &\quad + (\sin u \cos v - \cos u \sin v) \\
 &= 2 \sin u \cos v.
 \end{aligned}$$

Therefore

$$\sin u \cos v = \frac{\sin(u + v) + \sin(u - v)}{2}.$$

Now put $u = (x + y)/2$ and $v = (x - y)/2$. Then $u + v = x$ and $u - v = y$, so the same identity becomes

$$\sin x + \sin y = 2 \sin \frac{x + y}{2} \cos \frac{x - y}{2}.$$

□

Technique. The other entries in Table 1.4 follow from the same two operations: add or subtract a pair of angle-sum identities, then make a half-sum and half-difference substitution.

Inverse trigonometric functions require attention to their principal ranges. For example,

$$\arcsin x \in \left[-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}\right], \quad \arccos x \in [0, \pi], \quad \arctan x \in \left(-\frac{\pi}{2}, \frac{\pi}{2}\right).$$

Consequently,

$$\begin{aligned}
 \arcsin x + \arccos x &= \frac{\pi}{2} & (-1 \leq x \leq 1), \\
 \arctan x + \arctan(1/x) &= \begin{cases} \pi/2, & x > 0, \\ -\pi/2, & x < 0. \end{cases}
 \end{aligned}$$

Although

$$\tan(\arctan x + \arctan y) = \frac{x + y}{1 - xy}$$

when $xy \neq 1$, replacing the left side by a single arctan may require adding or subtracting π . This branch issue is why inverse trigonometric formulas should not be manipulated as if the inverse functions were globally periodic. There are no literal product-to-sum formulas for arcsin, arccos, or arctan; those transformations belong to the direct trigonometric functions.

The hyperbolic functions are defined by

$$\sinh x = \frac{e^x - e^{-x}}{2}, \quad \cosh x = \frac{e^x + e^{-x}}{2}, \quad \tanh x = \frac{\sinh x}{\cosh x}.$$

Their addition formulas have the same algebraic pattern as the trigonometric ones, with the decisive sign change in the cosine analogue:

$$\begin{aligned}\sinh(u \pm v) &= \sinh u \cosh v \pm \cosh u \sinh v, \\ \cosh(u \pm v) &= \cosh u \cosh v \pm \sinh u \sinh v, \\ \tanh(u \pm v) &= \frac{\tanh u \pm \tanh v}{1 \pm \tanh u \tanh v}.\end{aligned}$$

Table 1.5: Hyperbolic product-to-sum and sum-to-product formulas.

Product to sum	Sum to product
$\sinh u \sinh v = \frac{\cosh(u+v) - \cosh(u-v)}{2}$	$\sinh u + \sinh v = 2 \sinh \frac{u+v}{2} \cosh \frac{u-v}{2}$
$\cosh u \cosh v = \frac{\cosh(u+v) + \cosh(u-v)}{2}$	$\sinh u - \sinh v = 2 \cosh \frac{u+v}{2} \sinh \frac{u-v}{2}$
$\sinh u \cosh v = \frac{\sinh(u+v) + \sinh(u-v)}{2}$	$\cosh u + \cosh v = 2 \cosh \frac{u+v}{2} \cosh \frac{u-v}{2}$
$\cosh u \sinh v = \frac{\sinh(u+v) - \sinh(u-v)}{2}$	$\cosh u - \cosh v = 2 \sinh \frac{u+v}{2} \sinh \frac{u-v}{2}$

The principal inverse hyperbolic functions have especially useful logarithmic forms:

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{arsinh} x &= \ln \left(x + \sqrt{x^2 + 1} \right) & (x \in \mathbb{R}), \\ \operatorname{arcosh} x &= \ln \left(x + \sqrt{x^2 - 1} \right) & (x \geq 1), \\ \operatorname{artanh} x &= \frac{1}{2} \ln \left(\frac{1+x}{1-x} \right) & (|x| < 1).\end{aligned}$$

As with inverse trigonometric functions, these identities include domain and branch information; they are not obtained by formally placing “arc” in front of a direct-function identity.

Example 1.14 Why the functions are called hyperbolic Show that $(\cosh t, \sinh t)$ lies on the unit hyperbola and derive a hyperbolic addition formula directly from exponentials.

Proof From the definitions,

$$\begin{aligned}\cosh^2 t - \sinh^2 t &= \frac{(e^t + e^{-t})^2 - (e^t - e^{-t})^2}{4} \\ &= 1.\end{aligned}$$

Thus the point $(x, y) = (\cosh t, \sinh t)$ parametrizes the right-hand branch of

$$x^2 - y^2 = 1,$$

just as $(\cos t, \sin t)$ parametrizes the unit circle $x^2 + y^2 = 1$. Moreover,

$$\begin{aligned}\sinh(u+v) &= \frac{e^{u+v} - e^{-(u+v)}}{2} \\ &= \frac{(e^u - e^{-u})(e^v + e^{-v}) + (e^u + e^{-u})(e^v - e^{-v})}{4} \\ &= \sinh u \cosh v + \cosh u \sinh v.\end{aligned}$$

Adding and subtracting the formulas for $u+v$ and $u-v$ then produces Table 1.5. □

Geometric and Complex Viewpoints. The word “hyperbolic” therefore reflects geometry, not merely notation. There is also a complex-variable viewpoint: Euler’s formulas give

$$\cos(ix) = \cosh x, \quad \sin(ix) = i \sinh x.$$

Thus the circle and hyperbola identities are connected by the imaginary substitution $x \mapsto ix$; this is a useful structural explanation, although complex exponentials are not needed to use the real formulas above.

Common Pitfall. An expression and a function are not the same thing. The expression describes an assignment rule, but the function also includes its domain. Many apparent contradictions about ranges, inverses, and compositions disappear once the domain is written explicitly.

Looking Ahead. A function limit will ask what $f(x)$ does when x is near a point, possibly without using the value at that point. The distinction between formula and function remains essential because a limit can depend on which domain points are available near the point of approach.

Exercise 1.2

1. Find the natural domains of

$$\ln(x^2 - 1), \quad \frac{\sqrt{2x+1}}{x-3}, \quad \arccos(2 \sin x).$$

2. For $f(x) = x^2 - 2x$ on each of the domains $\mathbb{R}$, $[0, 3]$, and $(2, +\infty)$, determine the range.
 3. Let $f(x) = 1/(x-1)$ and $g(x) = \sqrt{x+2}$. Find formulas and domains for $f+g$, fg , f/g , $f \circ g$, and $g \circ f$.
 4. Give two functions represented by the same formula but having different ranges. Explain why they are not equal as functions.
 5. Prove that composition of functions is associative whenever all compositions involved are defined. Give an example showing that composition need not be commutative.
 6. Determine $\lfloor x \rfloor$ and $\{x\}$ for

$$x = 3.7, \quad x = -0.2, \quad x = -4.$$

Prove that $\{x+1\} = \{x\}$ for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$.

7. Determine the parity, periods, and intervals of monotonicity that apply to

$$f(x) = x^2, \quad g(x) = \cos(2x), \quad h(x) = \frac{1}{1+x^2}.$$

Give a bounded nonperiodic function and a periodic unbounded function.

8. Starting from the graph of $y = f(x)$, describe the transformations and domains of

$$y = 2f(x-1) - 3, \quad y = f(-2x).$$

9. Determine whether each map is injective, surjective, or bijective:

$$x \mapsto x^2: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow [0, +\infty), \quad x \mapsto x^3: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, \quad x \mapsto e^x: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow (0, +\infty).$$

10. Find the inverse of

$$f(x) = \frac{x-1}{x+2}$$

after specifying a domain and codomain for which f is bijective.

11. Prove directly from the definitions that if f and g are bounded on the same nonempty set X , then $f+g$ and fg are bounded on X .

12. Give an example of a function that is bounded above but not bounded below, and another that is bounded on one interval but unbounded on a smaller-looking interval with a missing endpoint.
13. Explain why the Dirichlet function cannot be represented by a continuous curve, using Proposition 1.4.
14. Determine the natural domains, ranges, parity, and monotonicity of

$$\sinh x, \quad \cosh x, \quad \tanh x.$$

Use only their exponential definitions and elementary inequalities.

15. Starting with $y = \sinh x$ and $y = \tanh x$, solve algebraically for x and thereby verify

$$\operatorname{arsinh} y = \ln\left(y + \sqrt{y^2 + 1}\right), \quad \operatorname{artanh} y = \frac{1}{2} \ln\left(\frac{1+y}{1-y}\right).$$

State the domain of each inverse function.

16. Derive the product-to-sum formulas for $\sin u \sin v$ and $\sinh u \sinh v$ from the corresponding addition formulas. Then use them to rewrite

$$\sin(3x) \sin x, \quad \sinh(3x) \sinh x$$

as differences of two cosine-type functions.

17. Sketch the graph of

$$f(x) = |x - 1| + |x + 1|$$

by first writing a piecewise formula. Determine its range, parity, and intervals of monotonicity, and find all x for which $f(x) = 3$.

18. Consider $f(x) = x + 1/x$. Show that its restrictions to $(0, 1]$ and $[1, +\infty)$ are one-to-one, determine their ranges, and find an inverse formula for each restriction.

19. Solve on the stated domains:

$$\arcsin(2x - 1) = \frac{\pi}{6}, \quad \arctan x + \arctan \frac{1}{x} = \frac{\pi}{2} \quad (x > 0).$$

Explain why branch information is essential in the second equation.

20. Let $f(x) = \lfloor x \rfloor$ and $g(x) = \{x\}$. Determine formulas and ranges for $f \circ g$, $g \circ f$, and $g \circ g$. Which of these functions are periodic, and what are their periods?

Supplement Exercises

- S1. For $x \notin 2\pi\mathbb{Z}$, prove the finite-sum identity

$$\sum_{k=1}^n \cos(kx) = \frac{\sin((2n+1)x/2) - \sin(x/2)}{2 \sin(x/2)}.$$

Obtain it by converting each cosine into a difference of two sines so that the sum telescopes.

- S2. Prove that, for $x \geq 0$,

$$2 \arctan \sqrt{x} - \arcsin \frac{x-1}{x+1} = \frac{\pi}{2}.$$

Your proof must justify the ranges of all inverse trigonometric functions involved.

- S3. Derive the tangent half-angle identities

$$\sin \theta = \frac{2t}{1+t^2}, \quad \cos \theta = \frac{1-t^2}{1+t^2}, \quad t = \tan \frac{\theta}{2},$$

and describe precisely which values of θ require separate treatment.

- S4. Let D be the Dirichlet function, equal to 1 on $\mathbb{Q}$ and 0 on $\mathbb{R} \setminus \mathbb{Q}$. Determine the ranges of $xD(x)$, $D(x^2)$, and $D(D(x))$. Decide which of these functions are even, odd, periodic, or bounded.

S5. Let

$$f(x) = \frac{ax + b}{cx - a}, \quad a^2 + bc \neq 0.$$

Choose the natural domain and codomain so that f is a bijection, and prove that $f^{-1} = f$.

Optional Hint. Associate f with the matrix $\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & -a \end{pmatrix}$ and square the matrix.

S6. Determine all real constants a, b for which

$$f(x) = \ln(a + be^x)$$

is well-defined on a nondegenerate interval I , maps I onto itself, and satisfies $f(f(x)) = x$ for every $x \in I$.

State the maximal interval in each case.

1.3 Limits of Sequences

重点内容与证明方法

- Understand a sequence as an ordered function on the positive integers.
- Read the quantifiers in the ε - N definition and construct direct proofs in the correct order.
- Establish uniqueness, boundedness, order properties, and arithmetic laws for limits.
- Use domination, squeeze arguments, normalization, and subsequences to prove convergence or divergence.
- Apply completeness through the monotone sequence theorem and define the constant e .
- Explore the Cauchy criterion and the Bolzano–Weierstrass theorem as completeness-based extensions.

Limits turn approximation into an exact mathematical method. The area of a circle may be approached by areas of inscribed polygons, an irrational number by rational decimals, and a solution of an equation by repeated numerical approximations. In each case we obtain an ordered list of numbers and ask whether the terms settle near one fixed real number.

1.3.1 Sequences and the meaning of convergence

Definition 1.13

A real sequence (数列) is a function

$$a: \mathbb{N}_{>0} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}.$$

Its value at n is denoted by a_n , and the sequence is written $(a_n)_{n \geq 1}$ or simply (a_n) .



The index records order. For example, $(1, -1, 1, -1, \dots)$ and $(-1, 1, -1, 1, \dots)$ have the same set of values but are different sequences. Some sequences are given by an explicit formula, while others are defined recursively from earlier terms.

Consider three examples:

$$a_n = \frac{1}{n}, \quad b_n = 2 + \frac{(-1)^n}{n}, \quad c_n = (-1)^n.$$

The first approaches 0 from one side. The second approaches 2 while alternating around it. The third continues to jump between -1 and 1 and does not approach any single number. Monotonicity is therefore not part of convergence; eventual closeness is.

Definition 1.14

Let $(a_n)_{n \geq 1}$ be a sequence and let $L \in \mathbb{R}$. We say that (a_n) converges (收敛) to L if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists $N \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ such that

$$n \geq N \implies |a_n - L| < \varepsilon.$$

In this case we write

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} a_n = L \quad \text{or} \quad a_n \rightarrow L.$$

The number L is the limit (极限) of the sequence. A sequence that has no real limit is called divergent (发散).



The definition has the logical form

$$\forall \varepsilon > 0 \quad \exists N \in \mathbb{N}_{>0} \quad \forall n \geq N : |a_n - L| < \varepsilon.$$

The number N may depend on ε , but it must not depend on the later index n . We only need to find a suitable N ; it need not be the smallest possible one.

The exact negation of the proposed limit $a_n \rightarrow L$ is

$$\exists \varepsilon_0 > 0 \quad \forall N \in \mathbb{N}_{>0} \quad \exists n \geq N : |a_n - L| \geq \varepsilon_0.$$

Thus a divergence proof may fix one positive tolerance and find bad terms arbitrarily far out in the sequence. The tolerance must be independent of N ; choosing a new tolerance for each tail would not negate convergence.

Disproof Pattern. To show that a_n does not converge to a proposed value L , look for one number $\varepsilon_0 > 0$ and infinitely late indices whose terms remain at least ε_0 away from L . Two subsequences with different limits are a particularly efficient way to obtain such terms.

Geometrically, $|a_n - L| < \varepsilon$ means

$$L - \varepsilon < a_n < L + \varepsilon.$$

No matter how narrow the horizontal band around L is chosen, all sufficiently late terms must lie inside it.

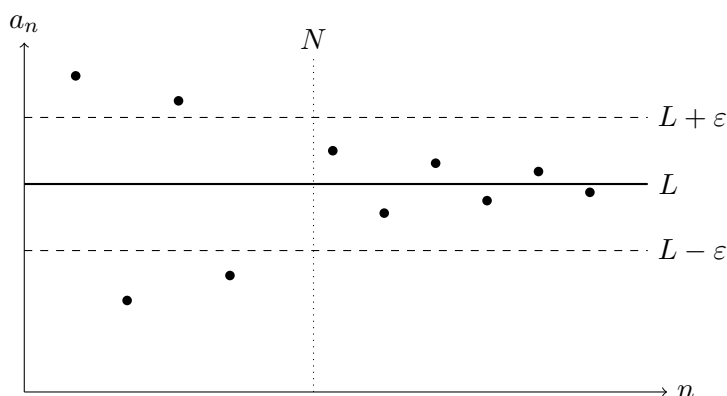


Figure 1.2: After a suitable index N , every term lies in the ε -band around L ; the finitely many earlier terms are irrelevant to convergence.

Question. Why does the definition require all $n \geq N$, rather than merely infinitely many values of n ?

1.3.2 Direct proofs from the definition

An ε - N proof is usually discovered backward and written forward. We first ask what condition on n would guarantee $|a_n - L| < \varepsilon$. After determining N from this condition, the formal proof starts with an arbitrary $\varepsilon > 0$, chooses that N , and verifies the implication.

Example 1.15 A direct ε - N proof Prove that

$$a_n = 2 + \frac{(-1)^n}{n} \longrightarrow 2.$$

Idea. The oscillation causes no difficulty because its magnitude is controlled by $1/n$:

$$|a_n - 2| = \frac{1}{n}.$$

Thus it is enough to make $n > 1/\varepsilon$.

Proof Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Choose

$$N = \left\lceil \frac{1}{\varepsilon} \right\rceil + 1.$$

If $n \geq N$, then $n > 1/\varepsilon$, and therefore

$$|a_n - 2| = \frac{|(-1)^n|}{n} = \frac{1}{n} < \varepsilon.$$

Hence $a_n \rightarrow 2$. □

Exact solution of the target inequality is often unnecessary. A simpler upper bound may reveal a workable N .

Example 1.16 Estimate first, choose N second Prove that

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n+2}{n^2+1} = 0.$$

Proof For $n \geq 2$, we have $n+2 \leq 2n$ and $n^2+1 \geq n^2$, so

$$0 \leq \frac{n+2}{n^2+1} \leq \frac{2}{n}.$$

Given $\varepsilon > 0$, choose

$$N = \max \left\{ 2, \left\lceil \frac{2}{\varepsilon} \right\rceil + 1 \right\}.$$

Then, for $n \geq N$,

$$0 \leq \frac{n+2}{n^2+1} \leq \frac{2}{n} < \varepsilon.$$

This proves the limit directly from the definition. □

The following basic limits will be used repeatedly.

Proposition 1.8

Let $p > 0$, let $q \in \mathbb{R}$ satisfy $|q| < 1$, and let $a > 0$. Then

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1}{n^p} = 0,$$

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} q^n = 0,$$

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} a^{1/n} = 1.$$



Proof Given $\varepsilon > 0$, the Archimedean property provides N such that

$$N > \varepsilon^{-1/p}.$$

Then $n \geq N$ implies $1/n^p < \varepsilon$, proving the first limit.

The second limit is immediate when $q = 0$. If $0 < |q| < 1$, write

$$\frac{1}{|q|} = 1 + h$$

with $h > 0$. Bernoulli's inequality gives $(1+h)^n \geq 1 + nh$, so

$$0 < |q|^n = \frac{1}{(1+h)^n} \leq \frac{1}{1+nh} < \frac{1}{nh}.$$

The first limit, with $p = 1$, now proves $q^n \rightarrow 0$.

Suppose first that $a \geq 1$, and set $h_n = a^{1/n} - 1 \geq 0$. Since

$$a = (1 + h_n)^n \geq 1 + nh_n,$$

we obtain

$$0 \leq h_n \leq \frac{a-1}{n} \rightarrow 0.$$

Thus $a^{1/n} = 1 + h_n \rightarrow 1$. If $0 < a < 1$, put $b = 1/a > 1$. The proved case gives $b^{1/n} \rightarrow 1$, and

$$0 \leq 1 - a^{1/n} = \frac{b^{1/n} - 1}{b^{1/n}} \leq b^{1/n} - 1 \rightarrow 0.$$

Hence $a^{1/n} \rightarrow 1$ without using the quotient law, which will be proved later. $\square$

1.3.3 First structural consequences

Theorem 1.3

A convergent sequence has exactly one limit.



Idea. Two distinct candidate limits have disjoint sufficiently small neighbourhoods. A late term of the sequence cannot belong to both neighbourhoods at once.

Proof Suppose that $a_n \rightarrow L$ and $a_n \rightarrow M$. If $L \neq M$, set

$$\varepsilon = \frac{|L - M|}{3} > 0.$$

There exist $N_1, N_2 \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ such that

$$n \geq N_1 \implies |a_n - L| < \varepsilon, \quad n \geq N_2 \implies |a_n - M| < \varepsilon.$$

For $n \geq \max\{N_1, N_2\}$, the triangle inequality gives

$$|L - M| \leq |L - a_n| + |a_n - M| < 2\varepsilon = \frac{2}{3}|L - M|,$$

a contradiction. Therefore $L = M$. $\square$

Proposition 1.9

Changing, adding, or deleting finitely many initial terms does not affect whether a sequence converges or what its limit is. In particular, if $a_n \rightarrow L$ and $k \in \mathbb{N}$ is fixed, then

$$a_{n+k} \rightarrow L.$$



Proof Suppose two sequences agree for every $n \geq n_0$. For a given $\varepsilon > 0$, choose N for the convergent sequence and replace it by $\max\{N, n_0\}$. The same ε -estimate then holds for the other sequence. The statement about shifts follows by taking a tail and reindexing it. $\square$

Definition 1.15

A sequence (a_n) is a bounded sequence (有界数列) if there exists $M \geq 0$ such that

$$|a_n| \leq M$$

for every $n \geq 1$.



Theorem 1.4

Every convergent sequence is bounded.



Proof Suppose $a_n \rightarrow L$. Taking $\varepsilon = 1$, choose N such that

$$n \geq N \implies |a_n - L| < 1.$$

For such n ,

$$|a_n| \leq |a_n - L| + |L| < 1 + |L|.$$

Now choose

$$M = \max\{|a_1|, \dots, |a_{N-1}|, 1 + |L|\},$$

with the finite list omitted if $N = 1$. Then $|a_n| \leq M$ for every $n \geq 1$. $\square$

The converse is false. The sequence $((-1)^n)$ is bounded but divergent. Boundedness prevents escape to infinity, but it does not prevent persistent oscillation.

1.3.4 Arithmetic laws and squeeze arguments

Theorem 1.5

Suppose that $a_n \rightarrow A$ and $b_n \rightarrow B$, and let $c \in \mathbb{R}$. Then

$$a_n + b_n \rightarrow A + B,$$

$$a_n - b_n \rightarrow A - B,$$

$$ca_n \rightarrow cA,$$

$$a_nb_n \rightarrow AB.$$

If $B \neq 0$, then $b_n \neq 0$ for all sufficiently large n and

$$\frac{a_n}{b_n} \rightarrow \frac{A}{B}.$$



Proof Strategy. For sums, split the final error into two errors. For products, add and subtract a convenient intermediate term and use boundedness of a convergent sequence. For quotients, first prove that a denominator converging to a nonzero number stays away from zero.

Proof Given $\varepsilon > 0$, choose N so that for $n \geq N$,

$$|a_n - A| < \frac{\varepsilon}{2}, \quad |b_n - B| < \frac{\varepsilon}{2}.$$

Then

$$|(a_n + b_n) - (A + B)| \leq |a_n - A| + |b_n - B| < \varepsilon.$$

The difference and constant-multiple laws follow by the same estimate.

By Theorem 1.4, choose $M \geq 0$ such that $|a_n| \leq M$ for all n . Let

$$C = M + |B| + 1.$$

Choose N so that, for $n \geq N$,

$$|a_n - A| < \frac{\varepsilon}{C}, \quad |b_n - B| < \frac{\varepsilon}{C}.$$

Then

$$\begin{aligned} |a_nb_n - AB| &= |a_n(b_n - B) + B(a_n - A)| \\ &\leq M|b_n - B| + |B||a_n - A| \\ &< \frac{M + |B|}{C}\varepsilon < \varepsilon. \end{aligned}$$

Thus $a_nb_n \rightarrow AB$.

Finally suppose $B \neq 0$. For all sufficiently large n ,

$$|b_n - B| < \frac{|B|}{2},$$

so the reverse triangle inequality gives

$$|b_n| > \frac{|B|}{2} > 0.$$

For these indices,

$$\left| \frac{1}{b_n} - \frac{1}{B} \right| = \frac{|b_n - B|}{|b_n||B|} \leq \frac{2}{|B|^2} |b_n - B| \rightarrow 0.$$

Therefore $1/b_n \rightarrow 1/B$, and the quotient law follows from the product law. $\square$

Example 1.17 An infinite repeating decimal Prove that $0.999\dots = 1$ by interpreting the infinite decimal as the limit of its finite truncations

$$s_n = \underbrace{0.99\dots 9}_{n \text{ digits}} = \frac{9}{10} + \frac{9}{10^2} + \cdots + \frac{9}{10^n}.$$

Idea. An infinite decimal has no last digit at which to perform a final subtraction. Instead, first ask how far the finite decimal s_n is from 1. Its digits form a finite geometric sum, so we can calculate this error exactly before taking a limit.

Proof 1: finite sums and limit laws For each positive integer n , the finite geometric-sum identity gives

$$s_n = \frac{9}{10} \frac{1 - 10^{-n}}{1 - 1/10} = 1 - 10^{-n}.$$

Since $(1/10)^n \rightarrow 0$ by Proposition 1.8, Theorem 1.5 yields

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} s_n = 1 - 0 = 1.$$

The notation $0.999\dots$ denotes this limit, whose existence has now been established. Thus $0.999\dots = 1$. $\square$

Proof 2: direct control of the error The same finite identity gives $|s_n - 1| = 10^{-n}$. Bernoulli's inequality gives $10^n = (1 + 9)^n \geq 1 + 9n$. Given $\varepsilon > 0$, choose a positive integer $N > 1/(9\varepsilon)$. For every $n \geq N$,

$$|s_n - 1| = 10^{-n} \leq \frac{1}{1 + 9n} < \frac{1}{9n} \leq \frac{1}{9N} < \varepsilon.$$

This proves $s_n \rightarrow 1$ directly from the definition. $\square$

The first proof uses the arithmetic theorem to keep the calculation short. The second gives an explicit, though not optimal, choice of N and displays the error estimate behind the limit. Both use only finite sums; neither assumes a rule for manipulating infinitely many summands. Every finite truncation is strictly less than 1, but its positive gap 10^{-n} becomes smaller than any prescribed positive number. There is no fixed positive gap left in the limit. The equality therefore identifies two decimal representations of the same real number, rather than saying that a finite truncation ever reaches 1.

A third route: first identify a possible limit. Multiplying a finite truncation by 10 exposes its first digit and a shorter truncation. This suggests an equation for a possible limit, but taking limits requires convergence first.

Candidate proof 3: assuming convergence Assume that (s_n) converges to a finite real number L . For every $n \geq 2$, finite decimal arithmetic gives

$$10s_n = 9 + \frac{9}{10} + \cdots + \frac{9}{10^{n-1}} = 9 + s_{n-1}.$$

The shifted sequence $(s_{n-1})_{n \geq 2}$ also tends to L by Proposition 1.9. Thus the arithmetic laws allow us to take limits on both sides:

$$10L = 9 + L, \quad L = 1.$$

Under the stated convergence assumption, this proves $0.999\dots = 1$. $\square$

Convergence is assumed, not proved here. The later Example 1.24 supplies existence, completing a third route that separates existence from evaluation without a closed form for s_n .

Example 1.18 A rational expression Evaluate

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n^2 + 3n + 10}{3n^2 - n + 2}.$$

Proof Using the arithmetic laws,

$$\begin{aligned} \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n^2 + 3n + 10}{3n^2 - n + 2} &= \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{1 + 3/n + 10/n^2}{3 - 1/n + 2/n^2} \\ &= \frac{1}{3}. \end{aligned}$$

□

Technique. Dividing by the highest power of n turns the expression into combinations of sequences with known limits.

Example 1.19 Rationalization reveals the dominant scale Evaluate

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left(\sqrt{n^2 + n} - n \right).$$

Idea. The two terms both have size n , so their leading parts cancel. Multiplying by the conjugate turns this hidden cancellation into a quotient with a nonzero limiting denominator.

Proof Rationalization gives

$$\begin{aligned} \sqrt{n^2 + n} - n &= \frac{n}{\sqrt{n^2 + n} + n} \\ &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{1 + 1/n} + 1}. \end{aligned}$$

Moreover,

$$0 \leq \sqrt{1 + \frac{1}{n}} - 1 = \frac{1/n}{\sqrt{1 + 1/n} + 1} \leq \frac{1}{2n}.$$

Hence $\sqrt{1 + 1/n} \rightarrow 1$ by choosing N with $\frac{1}{2N} < \epsilon$ for a fixed $\epsilon > 0$. The quotient law now yields

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left(\sqrt{n^2 + n} - n \right) = \frac{1}{2}.$$

□

Caution. The hypotheses in Theorem 1.5 matter. From convergence of $(a_n + b_n)$ one cannot conclude that (a_n) and (b_n) converge. For example, $a_n = n$ and $b_n = -n$ both diverge, while $a_n + b_n = 0$. Likewise, the theorem concerns finitely many arithmetic operations; it does not justify termwise limiting of sums whose number of terms grows with n .

The following squeeze theorem (夹逼定理) turns a useful two-sided estimate into a limit.

Theorem 1.6 (Squeeze Theorem)

Suppose that for all sufficiently large n ,

$$p_n \leq q_n \leq r_n.$$

If $p_n \rightarrow L$ and $r_n \rightarrow L$, then $q_n \rightarrow L$.



Proof Let $\epsilon > 0$. For all sufficiently large n ,

$$L - \epsilon < p_n \leq q_n \leq r_n < L + \epsilon.$$

Therefore $|q_n - L| < \varepsilon$ for all sufficiently large n , which is exactly $q_n \rightarrow L$. □

Example 1.20 An oscillating sequence controlled by its size Prove that

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{\sin n}{n} = 0.$$

Proof Since

$$-\frac{1}{n} \leq \frac{\sin n}{n} \leq \frac{1}{n}$$

and both bounding sequences converge to 0, Theorem 1.6 gives

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{\sin n}{n} = 0.$$

□

Interpretation. The numerator itself does not converge; the shrinking factor $1/n$ controls the oscillation.

Example 1.21 Dominate an oscillating term Prove that the sequence

$$a_n = \frac{n^{2/3} \sin n}{n + 1}$$

converges to 0.

Idea. Do not try to track the oscillation of $\sin n$; replace it by the uniform bound $|\sin n| \leq 1$.

Proof

$$|a_n| \leq \frac{n^{2/3}}{n + 1} \leq \frac{1}{n^{1/3}}.$$

The right-hand side tends to 0, so Theorem 1.6 gives $a_n \rightarrow 0$. □

Technique. The reusable step is to replace a complicated factor by a majorant that has a known limit.

Example 1.22 Normalize a root of a sum Let $m \geq 2$ be a fixed integer and set

$$s_n = (2^n + 3^n + \cdots + m^n)^{1/n}.$$

Find $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} s_n$.

Proof The largest exponential supplies the natural scale:

$$m^n \leq 2^n + 3^n + \cdots + m^n \leq (m - 1)m^n.$$

Taking positive n th roots gives

$$m \leq s_n \leq m(m - 1)^{1/n}.$$

Since $(m - 1)^{1/n} \rightarrow 1$, the squeeze theorem yields $s_n \rightarrow m$. □

Technique. This is a typical instance of normalizing by the dominant term before estimating.

Proposition 1.10

Let $a > 1$ and let $k \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$. Then

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n^k}{a^n} = 0, \quad \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{a^n}{n!} = 0.$$

Thus exponentials eventually dominate fixed powers, while factorials eventually dominate fixed exponentials.



Proof Write $a = 1 + h$ with $h > 0$. For sufficiently large n , the binomial theorem gives

$$\begin{aligned} a^n &\geq \binom{n}{k+1} h^{k+1} \\ &= \frac{n(n-1) \cdots (n-k)}{(k+1)!} h^{k+1} \\ &\geq \frac{(n/2)^{k+1}}{(k+1)!} h^{k+1}. \end{aligned}$$

Consequently,

$$0 \leq \frac{n^k}{a^n} \leq \frac{2^{k+1}(k+1)!}{h^{k+1}} \frac{1}{n} \rightarrow 0.$$

Choose $N_0 \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ with $N_0 > 2a$. For $n > N_0$,

$$0 \leq \frac{a^n}{n!} = \frac{a^{N_0}}{N_0!} \prod_{j=N_0+1}^n \frac{a}{j} \leq \frac{a^{N_0}}{N_0!} \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^{n-N_0}.$$

The right-hand side tends to 0 by Proposition 1.8, so the squeeze theorem completes the proof. $\square$

Corollary 1.1 (A hierarchy of dominant scales)

Let $\alpha > 0$ and $a > 1$. As $n \rightarrow \infty$,

$$\ln n = o(n^\alpha), \quad n^\alpha = o(a^n), \quad a^n = o(n!), \quad n! = o(n^n),$$

where $u_n = o(v_n)$ means $u_n/v_n \rightarrow 0$. Equivalently, one may remember the scale ordering

$$\ln n \ll n^\alpha \ll a^n \ll n! \ll n^n.$$

Proof For the first comparison, let $m = \lfloor \log_2 n \rfloor$. Then $2^m \leq n < 2^{m+1}$, and hence

$$0 \leq \frac{\ln n}{n^\alpha} \leq \frac{(m+1) \ln 2}{2^{\alpha m}} \rightarrow 0$$

by Proposition 1.10, applied to the base $2^\alpha > 1$. Choose an integer $k > \alpha$. For $n \geq 1$, $n^\alpha \leq n^k$, so

$$0 \leq \frac{n^\alpha}{a^n} \leq \frac{n^k}{a^n} \rightarrow 0.$$

The third comparison is already contained in Proposition 1.10. Finally,

$$0 \leq \frac{n!}{n^n} = \prod_{j=1}^n \frac{j}{n} \leq \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor} \rightarrow 0,$$

because the first $\lfloor n/2 \rfloor$ factors are at most $1/2$ and all remaining factors are at most 1. $\square$

How to use the hierarchy. In a sum of positive quantities with different scales, divide by the largest plausible scale. If every other normalized term tends to 0, the dominant term determines the asymptotic behaviour. The parameter restrictions matter: the displayed hierarchy assumes $\alpha > 0$ and $a > 1$.

Example 1.23 The slowly varying sequence $n^{1/n}$ Prove that $n^{1/n} \rightarrow 1$.

Proof Put $h_n = n^{1/n} - 1 \geq 0$. For $n \geq 2$, the binomial theorem gives

$$n = (1 + h_n)^n \geq \binom{n}{2} h_n^2 = \frac{n(n-1)}{2} h_n^2.$$

Hence

$$0 \leq h_n \leq \sqrt{\frac{2}{n-1}} \rightarrow 0.$$

Therefore

$$n^{1/n} \rightarrow 1, \quad n^{1/n} - 1 \rightarrow 0.$$

□

Why a new estimate is needed. The exponent and the base both vary, so this conclusion does not follow from the fixed-base limit in Proposition 1.8; the binomial estimate supplies the missing control.

Proposition 1.11 (Cesàro means)

If $a_n \rightarrow L$, then the arithmetic means satisfy

$$\frac{a_1 + a_2 + \cdots + a_n}{n} \rightarrow L.$$



Proof Strategy. The sum contains a number of terms that grows with n , so the finite-sum limit law does not apply directly. Separate a fixed initial block from a tail on which every error is uniformly small.

Proof Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Choose N such that $|a_k - L| < \varepsilon/2$ whenever $k \geq N$, and set

$$C = \sum_{k=1}^{N-1} |a_k - L|,$$

with $C = 0$ when $N = 1$. For all sufficiently large $n \geq N$, one has $C/n < \varepsilon/2$, and then

$$\begin{aligned} \left| \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n a_k - L \right| &\leq \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n |a_k - L| \\ &\leq \frac{C}{n} + \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=N}^n \frac{\varepsilon}{2} < \varepsilon. \end{aligned}$$

Thus the means converge to L . □

1.3.5 Order and subsequences

Theorem 1.7

Suppose that $a_n \rightarrow A$ and $b_n \rightarrow B$.

(i) If $A < B$, then $a_n < b_n$ for all sufficiently large n .

(ii) If $a_n \leq b_n$ for all sufficiently large n , then $A \leq B$.

In particular, if $A > 0$, then $a_n > 0$ for all sufficiently large n . □



Proof For (i), let $\varepsilon = (B - A)/3$. For all sufficiently large n ,

$$a_n < A + \varepsilon < B - \varepsilon < b_n.$$

For (ii), suppose instead that $A > B$. Part (i), with the two sequences interchanged, would give $a_n > b_n$ for all sufficiently large n , contradicting the hypothesis. Thus $A \leq B$. The final statement follows by comparing (a_n) with the constant zero sequence. □

Strict inequalities need not survive in the limit. Although $1/n < 2/n$ for every n , both sequences have limit 0.

Definition 1.16

Let (a_n) be a sequence, and let

$$n_1 < n_2 < n_3 < \cdots$$

be positive integers. The sequence $(a_{n_j})_{j \geq 1}$ is called a subsequence (子列) of (a_n) . □



Theorem 1.8

If $a_n \rightarrow L$, then every subsequence (a_{n_j}) also converges to L .



Proof Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Choose N such that $n \geq N$ implies $|a_n - L| < \varepsilon$. Since $n_j \geq j$, every $j \geq N$ satisfies $n_j \geq N$, and hence

$$|a_{n_j} - L| < \varepsilon.$$

Thus $a_{n_j} \rightarrow L$. □

The contrapositive is a powerful divergence test: if a sequence has two subsequences converging to different limits, then the original sequence diverges. For $a_n = (-1)^n$, the even subsequence is constantly 1 and the odd subsequence is constantly -1 .

Comment. Finding one convergent subsequence does not prove that the original sequence converges. The sequence $((-1)^n)$ already has two convergent subsequences. What convergence requires is that every sufficiently late term, not merely a selected infinite collection, lie close to one common limit.

1.3.6 Monotone sequences and completeness

Definition 1.17

A sequence (a_n) is nondecreasing (单调不减) if $a_n \leq a_{n+1}$ for every n , and nonincreasing (单调不减) if $a_n \geq a_{n+1}$ for every n . A sequence of either type is called a monotone sequence (单调数列).

**Theorem 1.9 (Monotone Sequence Theorem)**

Every nondecreasing sequence that is bounded above converges. Its limit is the supremum of its set of values. Every nonincreasing sequence that is bounded below converges, with limit equal to the corresponding infimum.



Idea. Monotonicity prevents endless oscillation, while boundedness prevents escape to infinity. Completeness supplies the boundary value toward which the sequence is forced to move.

Proof Suppose that (a_n) is nondecreasing and bounded above. Let

$$S = \{a_n \mid n \geq 1\}, \quad L = \sup S.$$

The number L exists by the least-upper-bound property.

Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Since $L - \varepsilon$ is not an upper bound of S , there exists $N \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ such that

$$a_N > L - \varepsilon.$$

For every $n \geq N$, monotonicity and the fact that L is an upper bound give

$$L - \varepsilon < a_N \leq a_n \leq L < L + \varepsilon.$$

Hence $|a_n - L| < \varepsilon$, so $a_n \rightarrow L$.

The nonincreasing case follows by applying the proved result to $(-a_n)$, or directly by using the infimum. □

Example 1.24 Convergence of the repeating-nine truncations For

$$s_n = \frac{9}{10} + \frac{9}{10^2} + \cdots + \frac{9}{10^n}, \quad n \geq 1,$$

prove that (s_n) is increasing and bounded, and hence convergent. Then complete Candidate proof 3 in Example 1.17.

Idea. Each new digit adds a positive term, suggesting monotonicity. For an upper bound, the digit-shift relation writes the next term as $(9 + s_n)/10$: if the current term lies between 0 and 1, so does the next. Induction can therefore establish a bound without assuming a limit value or using the earlier formula for s_n .

Proof For every $n \geq 1$,

$$s_{n+1} - s_n = \frac{9}{10^{n+1}} > 0,$$

so (s_n) is strictly increasing. We next prove $0 < s_n < 1$ for all $n \geq 1$ by induction. The assertion holds for $s_1 = 9/10$. If $0 < s_n < 1$, then finite decimal arithmetic gives

$$0 < s_{n+1} = \frac{9 + s_n}{10} < \frac{9 + 1}{10} = 1.$$

This completes the induction and proves boundedness.

The sequence is nondecreasing and bounded above by 1, so Theorem 1.9 now guarantees that $s_n \rightarrow L$ for some $L \in \mathbb{R}$. Only at this point do we use the conditional calculation in Example 1.17: taking limits in $10s_n = 9 + s_{n-1}$ gives $10L = 9 + L$, hence $L = 1$. This supplies the missing existence step and completes the third proof of $0.999\ldots = 1$. $\square$

Example 1.25 A recursively defined sequence Let

$$x_1 = 1, \quad x_{n+1} = \sqrt{2 + x_n}.$$

Prove that (x_n) converges and determine its limit.

Idea. Establish convergence from monotonicity and boundedness before solving the fixed-point equation for a possible limit.

Proof First, induction gives $1 \leq x_n < 2$ for every n . Indeed, the assertion holds for $x_1 = 1$; if $1 \leq x_n < 2$, then

$$1 < \sqrt{3} \leq x_{n+1} = \sqrt{2 + x_n} < 2.$$

For $1 \leq x_n < 2$,

$$x_{n+1}^2 - x_n^2 = 2 + x_n - x_n^2 = (2 - x_n)(x_n + 1) > 0.$$

Since both terms are positive, $x_{n+1} > x_n$. Thus (x_n) is increasing and bounded above by 2, so Theorem 1.9 gives a limit $L \in [1, 2]$.

The shifted sequence (x_{n+1}) has the same limit by Proposition 1.9. Taking limits in

$$x_{n+1}^2 = 2 + x_n$$

and using Theorem 1.5, we obtain

$$L^2 = 2 + L.$$

Hence $L = 2$ or $L = -1$. Because $L \in [1, 2]$, the limit is $L = 2$. $\square$

Common Pitfall. For a recursive sequence, solving the fixed-point equation gives only possible limits. It does not prove that the sequence converges. One must first establish convergence, often by monotonicity and boundedness, and only then pass to the limit in the recurrence.

1.3.7 The natural constant e

The monotone sequence theorem produces the *natural constant* (自然常数) e , one of the central constants of mathematics.

Theorem 1.10 (The Fundamental Sequence Defining e)

The sequence

$$e_n = \left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right)^n$$

is strictly increasing and bounded above. Consequently, it converges. Its limit is denoted by

$$e = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right)^n. \quad (1.3)$$

Moreover, $2 < e < 3$. 

Proof Strategy. The binomial expansion separates e_n into positive terms. For each fixed position in the expansion, increasing n enlarges the corresponding factor, which proves monotonicity. Replacing all those factors by 1 gives a convergent geometric upper estimate.

Proof By the binomial theorem,

$$\begin{aligned} e_n &= \sum_{k=0}^n \binom{n}{k} \frac{1}{n^k} \\ &= \sum_{k=0}^n \frac{1}{k!} \prod_{j=0}^{k-1} \left(1 - \frac{j}{n}\right), \end{aligned}$$

where the empty product for $k = 0$ equals 1. For every fixed $k \leq n$, replacing n by $n + 1$ increases each nonconstant factor in the product, and the expansion of e_{n+1} also has one additional positive term. Thus $e_{n+1} > e_n$.

Every factor in each product lies in $[0, 1]$, so

$$e_n \leq \sum_{k=0}^n \frac{1}{k!}.$$

For $k \geq 3$, we have $k! \geq 6 \cdot 2^{k-3}$. Therefore

$$\begin{aligned} e_n &\leq 1 + 1 + \frac{1}{2} + \sum_{k=3}^{\infty} \frac{1}{6 \cdot 2^{k-3}} \\ &= \frac{5}{2} + \frac{1}{6} \sum_{j=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{2^j} \\ &= \frac{17}{6} < 3. \end{aligned}$$

Hence (e_n) is increasing and bounded above, so it converges by Theorem 1.9. Since $e_n > e_1 = 2$ for $n > 1$, its limit satisfies $2 < e < 3$. $\square$

The constant e is the base of the natural logarithm. It first arose in the study of continuously compounded interest, but it now appears throughout calculus, differential equations, probability, and complex analysis.

Example 1.26 A companion limit Evaluate

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left(1 - \frac{1}{n}\right)^n.$$

Proof For $n \geq 2$, put $m = n - 1$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \left(1 - \frac{1}{n}\right)^n &= \left(\frac{m}{m+1}\right)^{m+1} \\ &= \frac{1}{(1 + 1/m)^m} \cdot \frac{1}{1 + 1/m}. \end{aligned}$$

By (1.3), the shift property, and the quotient law,

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left(1 - \frac{1}{n}\right)^n = e^{-1}.$$

□

1.3.8 Completeness extensions: monotone subsequences and Cauchy sequences

The next two results are not needed for the definition of e , but they reveal further consequences of completeness and will be useful when continuous functions on closed intervals are studied.

Lemma 1.1 (Monotone Subsequence Lemma)

Every real sequence has a monotone subsequence.



Proof Call an index n a *peak* if

$$a_n \geq a_m \quad \text{for every } m > n.$$

If there are infinitely many peaks, list them as

$$n_1 < n_2 < n_3 < \cdots.$$

Since each n_j is a peak, $a_{n_j} \geq a_{n_{j+1}}$, so (a_{n_j}) is nonincreasing.

If there are only finitely many peaks, choose n_1 larger than all of them. Then n_1 is not a peak, so some $n_2 > n_1$ satisfies $a_{n_2} > a_{n_1}$. The same argument can be repeated after n_2 , producing

$$n_1 < n_2 < n_3 < \cdots, \quad a_{n_1} < a_{n_2} < a_{n_3} < \cdots.$$

Thus the selected subsequence is strictly increasing. □

Theorem 1.11 (Bolzano–Weierstrass Theorem)

Every bounded real sequence has a convergent subsequence.



Idea. The preceding lemma supplies a monotone subsequence. Boundedness is inherited by subsequences, so completeness can be applied through the monotone sequence theorem.

Proof Let (a_n) be bounded. By Lemma 1.1, it has a monotone subsequence (a_{n_j}) . This subsequence is still bounded. If it is nondecreasing, it is bounded above; if it is nonincreasing, it is bounded below. In either case, Theorem 1.9 shows that (a_{n_j}) converges. □

Definition 1.18

A sequence (a_n) is a **Cauchy sequence** (柯西数列) if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists $N \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$ such that

$$m, n \geq N \implies |a_m - a_n| < \varepsilon.$$



The definition compares late terms with one another and does not require a candidate limit. The following Cauchy convergence criterion (柯西收敛准则) says that, over $\mathbb{R}$, this internal closeness is exactly convergence.

Theorem 1.12 (Cauchy Convergence Criterion)

A real sequence converges if and only if it is a Cauchy sequence.



Proof Strategy. A convergent sequence has late terms close to the same limit, so they are close to one another. Conversely, a Cauchy sequence is bounded; Bolzano–Weierstrass then gives one convergent subsequence, and the Cauchy condition pulls every late term toward that subsequential limit.

Proof Suppose first that $a_n \rightarrow L$. Given $\varepsilon > 0$, choose N such that

$$n \geq N \implies |a_n - L| < \frac{\varepsilon}{2}.$$

If $m, n \geq N$, then

$$|a_m - a_n| \leq |a_m - L| + |a_n - L| < \varepsilon.$$

Thus (a_n) is Cauchy.

Conversely, suppose that (a_n) is Cauchy. Taking $\varepsilon = 1$, choose N_0 such that

$$m, n \geq N_0 \implies |a_m - a_n| < 1.$$

For $n \geq N_0$, comparison with a_{N_0} gives

$$|a_n| \leq |a_{N_0}| + 1.$$

Together with the finitely many preceding terms, this proves that (a_n) is bounded.

By Theorem 1.11, some subsequence (a_{n_j}) converges to a number L . Given $\varepsilon > 0$, choose N_1 so that

$$m, n \geq N_1 \implies |a_m - a_n| < \frac{\varepsilon}{2}.$$

Choose j large enough that $n_j \geq N_1$ and

$$|a_{n_j} - L| < \frac{\varepsilon}{2}.$$

Then every $n \geq N_1$ satisfies

$$|a_n - L| \leq |a_n - a_{n_j}| + |a_{n_j} - L| < \varepsilon.$$

Hence $a_n \rightarrow L$. □

Question. Where does completeness of $\mathbb{R}$ enter the proof of the Cauchy criterion, and why can the corresponding statement fail for a sequence considered only inside $\mathbb{Q}$?

1.3.9 Key Concepts, Strategies, and Common Pitfalls

The core concepts are convergence, boundedness, subsequences, monotonicity, and completeness. The extension through Cauchy sequences shows that convergence can also be detected without knowing the limit in advance. For a proposed sequence limit, ask the following questions in order.

1. Can the target error $|a_n - L|$ be simplified or bounded by a familiar quantity?
2. Do the arithmetic laws apply, or are some component sequences divergent?
3. Can an oscillating or complicated term be squeezed by its absolute value?
4. Would two subsequences expose different limiting behaviours?
5. For a recursive sequence, can monotonicity and boundedness be proved before solving the fixed-point equation?
6. For a sum or an n th root, what is the dominant scale, and what happens after normalization by it?
7. If the number of summands grows with n , can the expression be split into a fixed head and a uniformly controlled tail?

Keep the following logical points explicit.

- In an ε - N proof, N may depend on ε but not on n .
- Finitely many exceptional terms do not affect a limit.
- Boundedness is necessary for convergence but not sufficient.
- An eventual strict inequality may become equality after taking limits.
- Limit laws for a finite number of operations do not justify an increasing number of additions or multipli-

cations.

Looking Ahead. The definition of a function limit has the same logical architecture as sequence convergence. The discrete tail condition $n \geq N$ will be replaced by the geometric condition $0 < |x - a| < \delta$, while estimation and backward choice of parameters remain the central proof methods.

Exercise 1.3

1. Use the definition to prove

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{3n+1}{2n-3} = \frac{3}{2}.$$

Give an explicit valid choice of N in terms of ε .

2. Use the definition to prove that $n^{-p} \rightarrow 0$ for $p > 0$ without citing Proposition 1.8.
 3. Prove directly from the definition that if $a_n \rightarrow L$, then $|a_n| \rightarrow |L|$. Is the converse true?
 4. Prove that every convergent sequence is eventually contained in the interval $(L-1, L+1)$, but explain why this alone does not establish boundedness of the entire sequence.
 5. Evaluate

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{4n^3 - n + 7}{2n^3 + 5n^2 - 1}, \quad \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} (\sqrt{n+1} - \sqrt{n}).$$

State which limit law or estimate is used at each step.

6. Use the squeeze theorem to find

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{\cos(n^2)}{\sqrt{n}}, \quad \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} (2^{2n} + 3^n)^{1/n}.$$

7. Show that $a_n = (-1)^n + 1/n$ diverges by finding two subsequences with different limits.
 8. Prove that a sequence converges to L if and only if its even and odd subsequences both converge to L .
 9. Let $x_1 = 2$ and

$$x_{n+1} = \frac{1}{2} \left(x_n + \frac{3}{x_n} \right).$$

Prove that (x_n) converges and determine its limit.

10. Prove that

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{n^{10}}{2^n} = 0$$

by the method of Proposition 1.10.

11. Prove that

$$\left(1 + \frac{1}{n} \right)^{n+1}$$

is decreasing and bounded below by e .

12. Explain precisely why the calculation

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \left(\frac{1}{n+1} + \frac{1}{n+2} + \cdots + \frac{1}{2n} \right) = 0$$

cannot be justified by saying that each summand tends to 0. Find a positive lower bound for the displayed sequence.

13. Suppose that (a_n) and (b_n) are Cauchy sequences. Prove directly from the definition that $(a_n + b_n)$ is Cauchy, and explain where completeness is used when one concludes that the sum sequence converges.
 14. If $a_n \rightarrow L$ and $m \in \mathbb{N}$ is fixed, prove directly from the definition that $a_{n+m} \rightarrow L$. Explain why the conclusion need not hold when the shift m is replaced by an integer sequence m_n satisfying $n + m_n \geq 1$

but for which $n + m_n$ does not tend to $+\infty$.

15. Suppose that (a_n) is bounded and $b_n \rightarrow 0$. Prove, without invoking the product law for limits, that $a_n b_n \rightarrow 0$.

16. For $a, b > 0$, prove that

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} (a^n + b^n)^{1/n} = \max\{a, b\}.$$

17. Evaluate

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \sqrt[n]{n^2 + n}.$$

Give upper and lower bounds that make the squeeze theorem applicable.

18. Let $H_n = 1 + 1/2 + \cdots + 1/n$. Prove that

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \sqrt[n]{H_n} = 1$$

using only the elementary bounds $1 \leq H_n \leq n$ and previously established basic limits.

19. If $a_n \rightarrow a$ and $b_n \rightarrow b$, prove that

$$\max\{a_n, b_n\} \rightarrow \max\{a, b\}, \quad \min\{a_n, b_n\} \rightarrow \min\{a, b\}.$$

You may use formulas involving $|a_n - b_n|$.

20. If $a_n \rightarrow L$, prove the weighted Cesàro conclusion

$$\frac{a_1 + 2a_2 + \cdots + na_n}{1 + 2 + \cdots + n} \rightarrow L.$$

Hint. Apply the fixed-head/small-tail idea from Proposition 1.11 to the errors $a_k - L$. The weighted contribution of the fixed head is divided by $1 + 2 + \cdots + n$, while every tail error is bounded by the same prescribed tolerance.

Supplement Exercises

- S1. For each $n \geq 2$, let $x_n \in (0, 1)$ be the unique solution of

$$x + x^2 + \cdots + x^n = 1.$$

Prove that (x_n) is monotone and bounded, and determine its limit.

- S2. Define

$$r_n = \sqrt{1 + \sqrt{2 + \sqrt{3 + \cdots + \sqrt{n}}}}.$$

Prove that (r_n) is increasing and bounded above, and hence convergent. Can the simple bound used in your proof determine the limit exactly?

- S3. Let $a > 0$ and choose $x_1 > \sqrt{a}$. Define

$$x_{n+1} = \frac{1}{2} \left(x_n + \frac{a}{x_n} \right).$$

Prove that $x_n \rightarrow \sqrt{a}$ and obtain an identity relating $x_{n+1} - \sqrt{a}$ to $(x_n - \sqrt{a})^2$. What does this identity say about the speed of convergence?

- S4. Let $F_1 = F_2 = 1$ and $F_{n+1} = F_n + F_{n-1}$. By studying the even and odd subsequences of F_{n+1}/F_n , prove that

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{F_{n+1}}{F_n} = \frac{1 + \sqrt{5}}{2}.$$

- S5. Prove the following subsequence criterion: a sequence (a_n) converges to L if and only if every subsequence of (a_n) has a further subsequence that converges to L .

Hint. For the nontrivial direction, negate the ε - N definition and construct a subsequence that stays a fixed positive distance from L .

S6. Let

$$s_n = \sum_{k=1}^n \frac{1}{k^2}.$$

Prove directly that (s_n) is a Cauchy sequence by comparing $1/k^2$ with $1/(k(k-1))$ for $k \geq 2$. Explain exactly where completeness is used to conclude convergence.

S7. Let $a_1, \dots, a_m > 0$ be fixed. Prove that

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} (a_1^n + \dots + a_m^n)^{1/n} = \max_{1 \leq k \leq m} a_k.$$

1.4 Limits of Functions

重点内容与证明方法

- Interpret the quantifiers in a function limit.
- Distinguish one-sided, two-sided, and infinite approaches.
- Prove limits using local estimates, limit laws, and sequences.
- Establish the fundamental trigonometric and exponential limits.
- Compare infinitesimals and recognize when cancellation needs finer estimates.
- Choose methods for direct proofs, calculations, and counterexamples.

A sequence is already a special kind of function. Given any real sequence (a_n) , define

$$f: \mathbb{N}_{>0} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, \quad f(n) = a_n.$$

The terms of the sequence are the values of this function at the positive integers. No values at noninteger inputs are needed, and the sequence alone does not specify them. In sequence convergence, the inputs follow the discrete approach $n \rightarrow \infty$. For a function on a general domain $D \subseteq \mathbb{R}$, an input may instead approach a finite point through the admissible points of D . We must control all such approaches, while respecting the domain.

Before asking what the output approaches, we must check that the proposed input approach is possible at arbitrarily small distances. For example, $f(x) = \arcsin x$ is a real-valued function on $[-1, 1]$. Every input in this domain satisfies $|x - 2| \geq 1$. In particular, there is no admissible input within distance $1/2$ of 2. Thus asking for $\lim_{x \rightarrow 2} \arcsin x$ has no meaning under the limit convention we will adopt: inputs in the domain cannot approach 2. This is a failure of the proposed approach, not an oscillation or an unbounded output near 2. By contrast, inputs in $[-1, 1]$ can approach 1 from below, so a limit question there is meaningful. We have not yet determined its value.

The limiting point need not itself be an input. For example,

$$f(x) = \frac{x^2 - 1}{x - 1} \quad (x \neq 1)$$

has no value at 1, but its values approach 2 as x approaches 1. The equality $f(x) = x + 1$ for $x \neq 1$ explains the limiting behaviour without filling the hole in the domain.

1.4.1 Punctured neighbourhoods and the definition of a limit

Recall that $U_r(a) = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : |x - a| < r\}$. In a limit at a , the input belongs to a punctured neighbourhood: $0 < |x - a| < r$. The exclusion of a is essential. Changing the value of a function at a , or leaving that value undefined, does not affect its limit at a .

To include endpoints and restricted domains, let $f: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, where $D \subseteq \mathbb{R}$. We call a an *accumulation point* (聚点) of D if every punctured neighbourhood of a contains a point of D . The point a need not belong to D . This condition guarantees that there are inputs that can approach a ; it prevents a limit statement from becoming vacuously true. For the arcsine domain, 1 is an accumulation point but 2 is not. If we allowed $a = 2$, choosing $\delta = 1/2$ would leave no inputs to test, so the implication in the definition below would hold for every proposed L . The accumulation-point assumption rules out this empty test; it does not by itself guarantee that a limit exists. Most examples below have a domain containing a whole punctured neighbourhood of the limiting point.

Definition 1.19

Let a be an accumulation point of D and let $L \in \mathbb{R}$. We say that f has limit (函数极限) L as $x \rightarrow a$ through D , and write

$$\lim_{\substack{x \rightarrow a \\ x \in D}} f(x) = L$$

if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists $\delta > 0$ such that, for every $x \in D$,

$$0 < |x - a| < \delta \implies |f(x) - L| < \varepsilon.$$

We usually abbreviate this to $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f(x) = L$, with the domain understood.



The tolerance ε is prescribed first. We must then find one δ that works for *every* admissible input in the punctured δ -neighbourhood. The number δ may depend on ε , the function, and the fixed point a , but it may not depend on the input x subsequently chosen. The exact negation of the proposed limit is

$$\exists \varepsilon_0 > 0 \quad \forall \delta > 0 \quad \exists x \in D : \quad 0 < |x - a| < \delta, \quad |f(x) - L| \geq \varepsilon_0.$$

Thus failure means that one fixed output error recurs at inputs arbitrarily close to a . This quantifier pattern is the source of the bad sequence constructed in Heine's criterion below. Geometrically, the graph over a sufficiently narrow punctured vertical strip must lie inside the prescribed horizontal band, as in **Figure 1.3**.

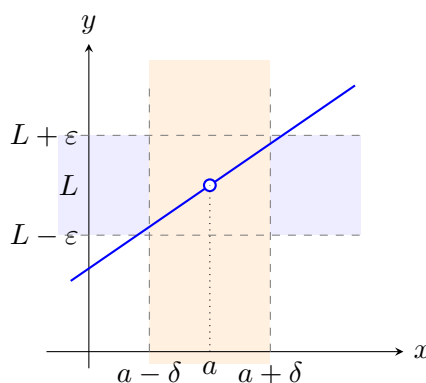


Figure 1.3: A horizontal tolerance band and a corresponding punctured input neighbourhood. The open circle does not affect the limit.

Example 1.27 Why remove the central point? Consider the function on $\mathbb{R}$ given by

$$g(x) = \begin{cases} x + 1, & x \neq 1, \\ 7, & x = 1. \end{cases}$$

Show that $\lim_{x \rightarrow 1} g(x) = 2$, and explain what would change if the definition tested all $|x - 1| < \delta$, including $x = 1$.

Idea. There are two rules in the definition of g . The condition $0 < |x - 1|$ selects the nearby rule $g(x) = x + 1$ and excludes the single exceptional value. To test whether removing this condition matters, inspect the one input it adds: $x = 1$.

Solution Given $\varepsilon > 0$, choose $\delta = \varepsilon$. Whenever $0 < |x - 1| < \delta$, we have $x \neq 1$, and hence

$$|g(x) - 2| = |x + 1 - 2| = |x - 1| < \delta = \varepsilon.$$

This proves the stated limit, even though $g(1) = 7$.

If we replaced the punctured condition by $|x - 1| < \delta$, the input $x = 1$ would satisfy it for every $\delta > 0$. But for $\varepsilon = 1$ the required output estimate would fail, since $|g(1) - 2| = 5$. More generally, when $g(a)$ is defined,

including $x = a$ would require $|g(a) - L| < \varepsilon$ for every $\varepsilon > 0$, which forces $g(a) = L$. This extra equality is not part of the question about nearby values.

Changing $g(1)$ to any other real number, or deleting that value altogether, leaves the same punctured-neighbourhood proof valid. The open circle in **Figure 1.3** illustrates the nearby rule independently of any assigned value at the centre. In the next section, continuity will require the nearby limit to agree with the assigned value. That is why a full neighbourhood can be used in a definition of continuity, whereas the limit definition keeps the two questions separate.

Example 1.28 Designing a neighbourhood Prove directly that $\lim_{x \rightarrow 1} (3x - 2) = 1$.

Idea. Start with the desired conclusion and simplify its left side: $|(3x - 2) - 1| = 3|x - 1|$. The output error is exactly three times the input error.

Proof Let $\varepsilon > 0$ and choose $\delta = \varepsilon/3$. If $0 < |x - 1| < \delta$, then

$$|(3x - 2) - 1| = 3|x - 1| < 3\delta = \varepsilon.$$

This proves the limit. □

Example 1.29 A temporary local bound Prove directly that $\lim_{x \rightarrow 2} x^2 = 4$.

Idea. The factorization $|x^2 - 4| = |x - 2||x + 2|$ exposes the small quantity $|x - 2|$. The remaining factor still depends on x . First restrict $|x - 2| < 1$; then $|x + 2| < 5$.

Proof Given $\varepsilon > 0$, set $\delta = \min\{1, \varepsilon/5\}$. If $0 < |x - 2| < \delta$, then $|x + 2| \leq |x - 2| + 4 < 5$, and therefore

$$|x^2 - 4| < 5|x - 2| < 5\delta \leq \varepsilon.$$

□

The preliminary restriction $\delta \leq 1$ is not part of the definition. It is a reusable proof device: first place all nonsmall factors under control, then choose a smaller neighbourhood to meet the requested error. The limit definition also shows that functions agreeing throughout some punctured neighbourhood have the same limit there. Unlike sequences, however, changing a function at infinitely many inputs approaching a may change its limit, even when those inputs form a very sparse set.

1.4.2 One-sided limits and different approaches

Definition 1.20

Suppose D has points arbitrarily close to a from the right. The right-hand limit (右极限) $\lim_{x \rightarrow a^+} f(x) = L$ means that for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is $\delta > 0$ such that

$$x \in D, \quad 0 < x - a < \delta \implies |f(x) - L| < \varepsilon.$$

The left-hand limit (左极限) $\lim_{x \rightarrow a^-} f(x) = L$ is defined by replacing $0 < x - a < \delta$ with $0 < a - x < \delta$, assuming approach from the left is possible. ♣

Proposition 1.12

If D has points arbitrarily close to a from both sides, then

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f(x) = L \iff \lim_{x \rightarrow a^-} f(x) = \lim_{x \rightarrow a^+} f(x) = L.$$

♠

Proof A two-sided δ works on each side separately. Conversely, for a given $\varepsilon > 0$, choose suitable left and right radii δ_- and δ_+ . With $\delta = \min\{\delta_-, \delta_+\}$, every admissible x satisfying $0 < |x - a| < \delta$ lies on one of the two controlled sides. □

For $f(x) = |x|/x$ on $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$, the left-hand limit at 0 is -1 and the right-hand limit is 1 . The two-sided limit does not exist. The value assigned at 0 cannot repair this disagreement. By contrast, for $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ on $[0, +\infty)$, the limit at 0 relative to the domain is a right-hand limit. There is no left-hand approach in the domain, so Proposition 1.12 does not require a left-hand limit in this example.

Definition 1.21

If D is unbounded above, then $\lim_{x \rightarrow +\infty} f(x) = L$ means

for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is $A > 0$ such that $x \in D$, $x > A \implies |f(x) - L| < \varepsilon$.

For $x \rightarrow -\infty$, assume D is unbounded below and use $x < -A$. For $|x| \rightarrow \infty$, assume D is unbounded and use $|x| > A$. When both tails of D are unbounded, the last limit exists exactly when the two tail limits exist and agree.



For example, $1/x \rightarrow 0$ as $|x| \rightarrow \infty$, since $|x| > 1/\varepsilon$ implies $|1/x| < \varepsilon$. The notation $x \rightarrow \infty$ is sometimes used for $x \rightarrow +\infty$; we keep the sign explicit whenever the direction matters. In particular,

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow +\infty} \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2 + 1}} = 1, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow -\infty} \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2 + 1}} = -1.$$

The sign difference comes from $\sqrt{x^2} = |x|$, not from x . These two computations will follow from the limit laws below.

Definition 1.22

Let a be an accumulation point of D . We write $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f(x) = +\infty$ if for every $M > 0$ there is $\delta > 0$ such that

$$x \in D, \quad 0 < |x - a| < \delta \implies f(x) > M.$$

The statement $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f(x) = -\infty$ uses $f(x) < -M$ instead. One-sided infinite limits use the corresponding one-sided neighbourhoods. Infinite limits as $x \rightarrow +\infty$ or $x \rightarrow -\infty$ use a tail condition in place of $0 < |x - a| < \delta$.



An *infinite limit* (无穷极限) describes eventual growth beyond every bound; it is not a finite real limit. For instance,

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{1}{x^2} = +\infty, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0^+} \frac{1}{x} = +\infty, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0^-} \frac{1}{x} = -\infty.$$

For the first statement choose $\delta = 1/\sqrt{M}$. The last two statements do not combine into a signed two-sided infinite limit for $1/x$, although $|1/x| \rightarrow +\infty$. Nor does unboundedness near a point alone imply an infinite limit: a function may repeatedly return to 0 while also taking arbitrarily large values.

Proposition 1.13 (Basic rules for infinite limits)

The following assertions hold along any one fixed approach.

- (i) If $g \rightarrow +\infty$ and $f \geq g$ eventually, then $f \rightarrow +\infty$. If $g \rightarrow -\infty$ and $f \leq g$ eventually, then $f \rightarrow -\infty$.
- (ii) If $f \rightarrow +\infty$ and g is bounded below eventually, then $f + g \rightarrow +\infty$. If $f \rightarrow -\infty$ and g is bounded above eventually, then $f + g \rightarrow -\infty$.
- (iii) If $f \rightarrow +\infty$ and $g \rightarrow c \neq 0$, then $fg \rightarrow +\infty$ when $c > 0$ and $fg \rightarrow -\infty$ when $c < 0$. Replacing $f \rightarrow +\infty$ by $f \rightarrow -\infty$ reverses these signs.
- (iv) If $|f| \rightarrow +\infty$ and g is bounded eventually, then $g/f \rightarrow 0$.

(v) If $f \rightarrow 0$ and $f > 0$ eventually, then $1/f \rightarrow +\infty$; if $f < 0$ eventually, then $1/f \rightarrow -\infty$.
 Conversely, $f \rightarrow +\infty$ or $f \rightarrow -\infty$ implies $1/f \rightarrow 0$, with the corresponding eventual sign.



Proof The comparison statements follow immediately by applying the defining threshold M to the smaller function in the positive case and to the larger function in the negative case. For (ii), if $g \geq C$ eventually and $M > 0$, take $f > \max\{M - C, 1\}$ sufficiently far along the approach; the other sign is analogous. For (iii), when $c > 0$ one eventually has $g > c/2$, and $f > 2M/c$ then gives $fg > M$. The remaining signs follow by applying this argument to $-f$ or $-g$. For (iv), choose an eventual bound $|g| \leq C$ and then require $|f| > C/\varepsilon$; the case $C = 0$ is immediate. Finally, the inequalities

$$0 < f < \frac{1}{M} \iff \frac{1}{f} > M, \quad f > \frac{1}{\varepsilon} \implies 0 < \frac{1}{f} < \varepsilon$$

prove (v), and the negative cases follow after changing signs. $\square$

Use sign information, not symbol pushing. The rules above apply only after eventual signs or one-sided bounds have been established. For example, $f \rightarrow +\infty$ and $g \rightarrow -\infty$ do not determine $f + g$; competing terms must first be compared or transformed.

In graph language, $x = a$ is a *vertical asymptote* (铅直渐近线) if at least one of the one-sided limits of f at a is $+\infty$ or $-\infty$. The line $y = L$ is a *horizontal asymptote* (水平渐近线) at a specified tail if the corresponding limit at infinity equals L . The function $1/x$ has both types of asymptote. A graph can cross a horizontal asymptote; an asymptote describes a limiting relation, not a barrier. The two graphs in **Figure 1.4** contrast finite side limits with infinite side limits.

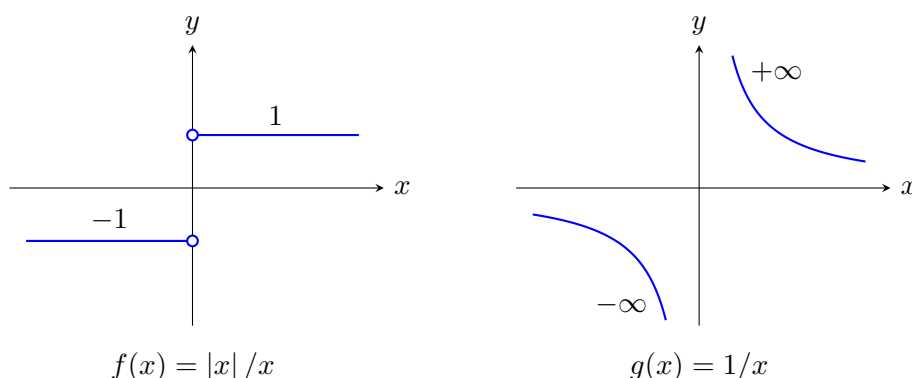


Figure 1.4: The two sides approach different finite levels on the left and grow with opposite signs on the right. Neither graph has a finite two-sided limit at 0.

1.4.3 Local properties and the sequential criterion

Theorem 1.13

Suppose $f(x) \rightarrow L \in \mathbb{R}$ as $x \rightarrow a$ through D . Then the following statements hold.

1. The limit is unique.
2. The function is bounded on some punctured neighbourhood of a relative to D .
3. If $L > 0$, then $f(x) > 0$ throughout some such neighbourhood; if $L < 0$, then $f(x) < 0$ there.
4. If also $g(x) \rightarrow K$ on the same approach and $f(x) \leq g(x)$ for all sufficiently close admissible $x \neq a$, then $L \leq K$.



Proof Strategy. Choose an output tolerance adapted to the desired conclusion: a fraction of the gap between alleged limits, the fixed tolerance 1, or a fraction of the distance from L to 0. The input neighbourhood then follows from the definition.

Proof If $L \neq K$ were two limits of f , use $\varepsilon = |L - K|/3$ in both limit definitions. There is an admissible $x \neq a$ in the intersection of the resulting neighbourhoods, because a is an accumulation point. Then

$$|L - K| \leq |L - f(x)| + |f(x) - K| < \frac{2}{3}|L - K|,$$

a contradiction. For boundedness, use $\varepsilon = 1$ to obtain $|f(x)| < |L| + 1$ near a . If $L > 0$, use $\varepsilon = L/2$ to obtain $f(x) > L/2 > 0$. Apply this result to $-f$ when $L < 0$. Finally, if $L > K$, use $\varepsilon = (L - K)/3$ for both f and g and restrict further to the neighbourhood where $f \leq g$. An admissible point there would satisfy

$$f(x) > L - \varepsilon > K + \varepsilon > g(x),$$

which is impossible. $\square$

The second assertion is *local boundedness* (局部有界性): its bound need not be valid on all of D . The third is *local sign preservation* (局部保号性) when the limit is nonzero. Also, a strict inequality need not stay strict in the limit: $x^2 > 0$ for $x \neq 0$, but its limit at 0 is 0. All four arguments work on a one-sided neighbourhood or on a tail after the input condition is changed accordingly.

Theorem 1.14 (Heine's sequential criterion)

Let a be an accumulation point of D . Then $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f(x) = L$ if and only if, for every sequence (x_n) in $D \setminus \{a\}$ satisfying $x_n \rightarrow a$, one has $f(x_n) \rightarrow L$.



Idea. A function limit controls every sufficiently close input, hence every sufficiently late term of any approaching sequence. For the converse, negate the function-limit definition and choose one bad input within distance $1/n$ for each n .

Proof Suppose first that $f(x) \rightarrow L$ and let $x_n \rightarrow a$ with $x_n \in D \setminus \{a\}$. For a prescribed $\varepsilon > 0$, choose $\delta > 0$ from the function-limit definition. For all sufficiently large n , $0 < |x_n - a| < \delta$, so $|f(x_n) - L| < \varepsilon$. Thus $f(x_n) \rightarrow L$.

Conversely, if f does not tend to L , there exists $\varepsilon_0 > 0$ such that for every $\delta > 0$ one can find $x \in D$ with

$$0 < |x - a| < \delta, \quad |f(x) - L| \geq \varepsilon_0.$$

Choose such a point x_n with $\delta = 1/n$. Then $x_n \rightarrow a$, but $|f(x_n) - L| \geq \varepsilon_0$ for every n , contradicting the assumed sequential property. $\square$

The criterion has one-sided and infinite-approach versions. For example, $f(x) \rightarrow L$ as $x \rightarrow +\infty$ exactly when $f(x_n) \rightarrow L$ for every sequence $x_n \in D$ tending to $+\infty$. In the converse proof, a failure supplies a bad point $x_n > n$ instead of a bad point within $1/n$ of a . For a right-hand limit use $0 < x_n - a < 1/n$, and for a negative tail use $x_n < -n$. The same selection argument gives the $|x| \rightarrow \infty$ version using $|x_n| > n$.

Example 1.30 Two ways to approach the same point Determine whether $\sin(1/x)$ and $x \sin(1/x)$ have limits as $x \rightarrow 0$.

Solution For $n \geq 1$, set

$$x_n = \frac{1}{2\pi n + \pi/2}, \quad y_n = \frac{1}{2\pi n + 3\pi/2}.$$

Both sequences tend to 0, but $\sin(1/x_n) = 1$ and $\sin(1/y_n) = -1$. By Theorem 1.14, $\sin(1/x)$ has no limit at 0, even from the right. For the second function,

$$|x \sin(1/x)| \leq |x|.$$

Given $\varepsilon > 0$, the choice $\delta = \varepsilon$ proves that its limit is 0. Oscillation may persist while its amplitude tends to zero.

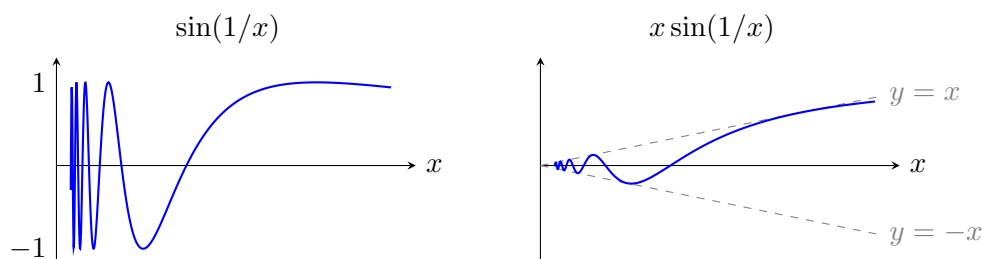


Figure 1.5: Right-hand portions of two oscillatory graphs. In the second graph, a shrinking envelope forces a limit.

The graph in **Figure 1.5** suggests the distinction, but a finite drawing cannot display all oscillations near 0. The sequences and the estimate provide the proof. Similarly, the Dirichlet function $D(x)$ from Section 1.2 has no limit at any $a \in \mathbb{R}$. By density, choose a rational r_n and an irrational s_n in $(a, a + 1/n)$. Then both input sequences tend to a , whereas $D(r_n) = 1$ and $D(s_n) = 0$ for all n .

1.4.4 Limit laws and composition

Theorem 1.15

Suppose $f(x) \rightarrow A$ and $g(x) \rightarrow B$ along the same approach, with finite limits. For every $c \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$f(x) + g(x) \rightarrow A + B, \quad cf(x) \rightarrow cA, \quad f(x)g(x) \rightarrow AB.$$

If $B \neq 0$, then g is nonzero sufficiently far along the approach and

$$\frac{f(x)}{g(x)} \rightarrow \frac{A}{B}.$$



Proof For every admissible approaching sequence (x_n) , the sequences $f(x_n)$ and $g(x_n)$ tend to A and B by Theorem 1.14 and its corresponding approach version. The sequence arithmetic laws, Theorem 1.5, give the asserted limits along this arbitrary sequence. The converse sequential criterion gives the function limits. If $B \neq 0$, the estimate $|g(x) - B| < |B|/2$ holds eventually and implies $|g(x)| > |B|/2$. Thus the quotient is defined on the required final part of the approach. $\square$

Theorem 1.16 (Squeeze theorem)

Suppose $u(x) \leq f(x) \leq v(x)$ eventually along an approach, and both $u(x)$ and $v(x)$ tend to the same finite limit L . Then $f(x) \rightarrow L$ along that approach.



Proof Given $\varepsilon > 0$, restrict the inputs so that the two comparisons hold and

$$|u(x) - L| < \varepsilon, \quad |v(x) - L| < \varepsilon.$$

Then $L - \varepsilon < u(x) \leq f(x) \leq v(x) < L + \varepsilon$. $\square$

In particular, if $h(x) \rightarrow 0$ and k is bounded near the approach, then $h(x)k(x) \rightarrow 0$. Indeed, an eventual bound $|k(x)| \leq C$ yields $|h(x)k(x)| \leq C|h(x)|$. The bounded factor need not have a limit.

Example 1.31 Cancellation and rationalization Evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 2} \frac{x^2 - 4}{x - 2}, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sqrt{1+x} - 1}{x}, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow -\infty} (\sqrt{x^2 + x} + x).$$

Solution In the first limit, the quotient equals $x + 2$ on the punctured domain, so the answer is 4. For the second,

rationalization gives

$$\frac{\sqrt{1+x}-1}{x} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1+x}+1} \quad (x \neq 0).$$

Here $|\sqrt{1+x}-1| = |x|/(\sqrt{1+x}+1) \leq |x|$ for $x \geq -1$. Thus $\sqrt{1+x} \rightarrow 1$, and the answer is $1/2$. For sufficiently negative x , the third expression is defined and

$$\sqrt{x^2+x}+x = \frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2+x}-x} = \frac{-1}{\sqrt{1+1/x}+1} \rightarrow -\frac{1}{2}.$$

The last equality uses $\sqrt{x^2} = |x| = -x$ on this tail.

The same idea applies to higher roots without searching for a special trick. If $p = \sqrt[m]{A}$ and $q = \sqrt[m]{B}$ are real, then

$$A - B = p^m - q^m = (p - q)(p^{m-1} + p^{m-2}q + \cdots + pq^{m-2} + q^{m-1}).$$

Whenever the second factor has a nonzero limit, this identity replaces the difference of two m th roots by a quotient whose small factor is $A - B$.

Generalized rationalization. For a difference of roots, set the roots equal to new symbols and factor a difference of powers. The familiar conjugate is exactly the case $m = 2$. Before dividing, check that the resulting sum in the denominator stays away from zero.

Example 1.32 Rationalizing two fifth roots Evaluate, using only algebraic identities and limit laws,

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sqrt[5]{1+3x} - \sqrt[5]{1-2x}}{x}.$$

Idea. The two roots both approach the same candidate value 1, so their difference hides the small factor we need to cancel. Their fifth powers have the much simpler difference $(1+3x) - (1-2x) = 5x$. This suggests the factorization of $p^5 - q^5$. First use the same identity with one root equal to 1 to justify the candidate root limits without appealing to a later continuity theorem.

Put $p = \sqrt[5]{1+3x}$ and $q = \sqrt[5]{1-2x}$. For $|x| < 1/6$, both radicands and both roots are positive. The identities $p^5 - 1 = 3x$ and $q^5 - 1 = -2x$ give

$$\begin{aligned} |p - 1| &= \frac{3|x|}{p^4 + p^3 + p^2 + p + 1} \leq 3|x|, \\ |q - 1| &= \frac{2|x|}{q^4 + q^3 + q^2 + q + 1} \leq 2|x|. \end{aligned}$$

Each denominator is at least 1 because its terms are nonnegative. These estimates prove $p \rightarrow 1$ and $q \rightarrow 1$; for example, $\delta = \min\{1/6, \varepsilon/3\}$ controls the first error, and $\delta = \min\{1/6, \varepsilon/2\}$ controls the second.

Solution Method 1: factor the difference of fifth powers. For $0 < |x| < 1/6$, set

$$S = p^4 + p^3q + p^2q^2 + pq^3 + q^4 > 0.$$

Since $(p - q)S = p^5 - q^5 = 5x$, we obtain the exact cancellation

$$\frac{p - q}{x} = \frac{p^5 - q^5}{xS} = \frac{5x}{xS} = \frac{5}{S}.$$

The already established limits $p, q \rightarrow 1$ and the arithmetic laws give $S \rightarrow 5$. The limiting denominator is nonzero, so the required limit is $5/5 = 1$.

Another route. Both roots are close to 1. Inserting that shared value splits the numerator into two differences of the form “one root minus 1”, each handled by the simpler identity already used in the error estimates.

Solution Method 2: rationalize the two changes separately. For $0 < |x| < 1/6$, the same positive denominators give

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{p-q}{x} &= \frac{p-1}{x} - \frac{q-1}{x} \\ &= \frac{3}{p^4 + p^3 + p^2 + p + 1} + \frac{2}{q^4 + q^3 + q^2 + q + 1}.\end{aligned}$$

Both denominators tend to 5, so the limit is $3/5 + 2/5 = 1$. The plus sign in the last term comes from subtracting $q - 1$, whose rationalized numerator is $-2x$.

Both methods work on a punctured interval where the roots and the denominators are positive. Method 1 is shorter when the difference of the radicands is simple. Method 2 is useful when separate root changes can be reused in a larger expression. For $m = 5$, the rationalizing factor has five terms, not the two terms of a square-root conjugate; the difference-of-powers identity determines the factor systematically.

The quotient law cannot be applied directly when the limiting denominator is 0. The commonly occurring forms

$$\frac{0}{0}, \quad \frac{\infty}{\infty}, \quad \infty - \infty, \quad 0 \cdot \infty, \quad 1^\infty, \quad 0^0, \quad \infty^0$$

are *indeterminate forms* (未定式), not values. The notation records only the separate limiting tendencies of the visible parts; it does not determine how their rates compare. For example, x^2/x , x/x , and x/x^2 have very different limiting behaviours at 0. Likewise, as $x \rightarrow +\infty$, the three differences $x - x$, $(x + 1) - x$, and $2x - x$ tend respectively to 0, 1, and $+\infty$. By contrast, a bounded numerator divided by a denominator whose absolute value tends to infinity is determined by Proposition 1.13: the quotient tends to 0. The correct response to an indeterminate form is therefore to transform or estimate the expression, not to perform arithmetic with the symbols 0 and ∞ .

Theorem 1.17

Suppose $u(x) \rightarrow b$ as $x \rightarrow a$, and $v(t) \rightarrow L$ as $t \rightarrow b$ through the domain of v . Assume the composition is defined for all sufficiently close admissible $x \neq a$. Either of the following additional conditions ensures that $v(u(x)) \rightarrow L$:

1. $u(x) \neq b$ for all sufficiently close admissible $x \neq a$;
2. b is in the domain of v and $v(b) = L$.

The same statement holds for a one-sided or infinite approach of x ; the values $u(x)$ must follow the approach specified for v .



Idea. The outer limit gives control when $0 < |t - b| < \eta$. The inner limit supplies $|u(x) - b| < \eta$. The only possible mismatch is $u(x) = b$, which the punctured outer limit does not control.

Proof Given $\varepsilon > 0$, choose $\eta > 0$ so that every admissible t with $0 < |t - b| < \eta$ satisfies $|v(t) - L| < \varepsilon$. Choose a sufficiently small punctured neighbourhood of a on which the composition is defined and $|u(x) - b| < \eta$. Under the first condition, restrict further so that $u(x) \neq b$; the outer estimate then applies. Under the second condition, the same estimate applies whenever $u(x) \neq b$, and when $u(x) = b$ the output equals $v(b) = L$ exactly. In either case the required error is less than ε . The proof changes only its input neighbourhood condition for other approaches. $\square$

Neither extra condition can simply be discarded. Let $u(x) = 0$ for every x , and let $v(0) = 1$ while $v(t) = 0$

for $t \neq 0$. Then $u(x) \rightarrow 0$ and $\lim_{t \rightarrow 0} v(t) = 0$, but $v(u(x)) = 1$. In the next section, continuity of the outer function will provide precisely the second condition.

Substitution Checklist. When setting $t = \phi(x)$ in a limit, record all four points explicitly.

- (1) Determine the exact approach of t : two-sided, one-sided, or infinite.
- (2) Rewrite the entire expression in terms of t , including restrictions inherited from the original domain.
- (3) Verify that $t = \phi(x)$ follows the domain and approach required by the new limit.
- (4) Check the composition hypothesis at the puncture; in particular, either $\phi(x) \neq b$ eventually or the outer function must be controlled at b itself.

A substitution such as $t = -x$ reverses sides, while $t = 1/x$ turns a tail into a one-sided approach to 0.

1.4.5 The fundamental trigonometric limit

The basic geometric estimate is obtained from the unit circle. Angles are measured in radians throughout. For $0 < t < \pi/2$, compare an inscribed triangle, a circular sector, and a triangle formed with the tangent line in **Figure 1.6**. Their areas are respectively $\frac{1}{2} \sin t$, $\frac{1}{2}t$, and $\frac{1}{2} \tan t$. Elementary circle geometry therefore gives

$$\sin t < t < \tan t, \quad \cos t < \frac{\sin t}{t} < 1.$$

This argument uses the geometric meaning of radian measure and the sector-area formula; it does not use differentiation or integration.

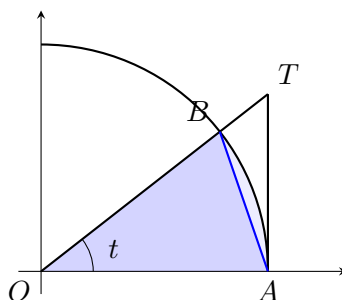


Figure 1.6: The inclusions $\triangle OAB \subset \text{sector } OAB \subset \triangle OAT$ compare the sine, angle, and tangent.

For negative t , oddness of sine gives $|\sin t| \leq |t|$ as well, at least for $|t| < \pi/2$. Consequently,

$$0 \leq 1 - \cos t = 2 \sin^2(t/2) \leq \frac{t^2}{2}$$

for all sufficiently small t . Hence $\cos t \rightarrow 1$ as $t \rightarrow 0$.

Theorem 1.18

With angles measured in radians,

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sin x}{x} = 1. \quad (1.4)$$



Proof For $0 < x < \pi/2$, the geometric inequalities place $\sin x/x$ between $\cos x$ and 1. Both bounds tend to 1, so Theorem 1.16 gives the right-hand limit. Since $\sin(-x)/(-x) = \sin x/x$, the left-hand limit is the same. Apply Proposition 1.12. $\square$

To apply (1.4), match the argument of the sine with the small quantity in the denominator. The addition formulas now give, for every fixed $a \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow a} \sin x = \sin a, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow a} \cos x = \cos a.$$

Indeed, write $x = a + h$, use $\sin h \rightarrow 0$ and $\cos h \rightarrow 1$, and apply the arithmetic laws to the addition formulas. Where the limiting cosine is nonzero, the quotient law also gives the limit of the tangent.

Example 1.33 Matching the small argument Evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sin(3x)}{\tan(2x)}, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{1 - \cos x}{x^2}.$$

Solution For the first limit, separate the two standard ratios:

$$\frac{\sin(3x)}{\tan(2x)} = \frac{3 \sin(3x)}{2 \sin(2x)} \frac{2x}{3x} \cos(2x) \rightarrow \frac{3}{2}.$$

All denominators are nonzero for sufficiently small nonzero x . For the second, the half-angle identity gives

$$\frac{1 - \cos x}{x^2} = \frac{1}{2} \left(\frac{\sin(x/2)}{x/2} \right)^2 \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}.$$

1.4.6 The exponential limit and related limits

In Section 1.3, the sequence $(1 + 1/n)^n$ defined the number e . The next step is to allow a real input. Before applying logarithms to a limit, we record the elementary limit estimates they require. We use the real exponential and logarithmic functions and their order and algebraic properties introduced in Section 1.2.

Lemma 1.2

For $b > 0$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$,

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow c} b^x = b^c.$$

For $b > 0$, $b \neq 1$, and $t > 0$,

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow t} \log_b x = \log_b t.$$



Idea. Near exponent 0, trap a power between $b^{-1/n}$ and $b^{1/n}$ and use the root-sequence limit. For a logarithm, translate the desired output interval back to a positive input interval using monotonicity.

Proof Suppose first $b > 1$. By Proposition 1.8, $b^{1/n} \rightarrow 1$, and its reciprocal also tends to 1. For a prescribed $\varepsilon > 0$, choose a positive integer n with $b^{1/n} - 1 < \varepsilon$ and $1 - b^{-1/n} < \varepsilon$. If $|h| < 1/n$, monotonicity gives

$$b^{-1/n} < b^h < b^{1/n},$$

so $|b^h - 1| < \varepsilon$. Thus $b^h \rightarrow 1$ as $h \rightarrow 0$, and $b^{c+h} = b^c b^h \rightarrow b^c$. The case $b = 1$ is constant, and the case $0 < b < 1$ follows by writing $b^x = 1/(1/b)^x$.

For logarithms with $b > 1$, let $\varepsilon > 0$ and choose

$$\delta = \min\{t - tb^{-\varepsilon}, tb^{\varepsilon} - t\} > 0.$$

If $|x - t| < \delta$, then $tb^{-\varepsilon} < x < tb^{\varepsilon}$, hence $\log_b t - \varepsilon < \log_b x < \log_b t + \varepsilon$. For $0 < b < 1$, use $\log_b x = -\log_{1/b} x$. $\square$

Theorem 1.19

For the real-valued expression with $1 + x > 0$,

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} (1 + x)^{1/x} = e. \quad (1.5)$$

Equivalently, $\lim_{t \rightarrow +\infty} (1 + 1/t)^t = e$.



Proof Strategy. For a positive real t , place t between consecutive integers and trap the whole expression between two sequences already controlled by Theorem 1.10. Then transform the negative side of $x \rightarrow 0$ into a positive-side limit by an exact identity.

Proof Let $t \geq 1$ and $n = \lfloor t \rfloor$, so $n \leq t < n + 1$. Monotonicity in the base and in a positive exponent gives

$$\left(1 + \frac{1}{n+1}\right)^n \leq \left(1 + \frac{1}{t}\right)^t \leq \left(1 + \frac{1}{n}\right)^{n+1}.$$

The left bound equals $(1 + 1/(n+1))^{n+1}/(1 + 1/(n+1))$, and the right bound equals $(1 + 1/n)^n(1 + 1/n)$. Both tend to e as $n \rightarrow \infty$. Since $\lfloor t \rfloor \rightarrow \infty$ as $t \rightarrow +\infty$, their values approach e along the real input t as well: the sequence estimates for every $n \geq N$ apply whenever $t \geq N$. The squeeze theorem proves the limit at $+\infty$. The substitution $t = 1/x$ gives (1.5) from the right.

For $-1 < x < 0$, put $y = -x/(1+x) > 0$. As $x \rightarrow 0^-$, one has $y \rightarrow 0^+$, and

$$1+x = \frac{1}{1+y}, \quad (1+x)^{1/x} = (1+y)^{(1+y)/y} = (1+y)^{1/y}(1+y) \rightarrow e.$$

The one-sided limits agree. □

Corollary 1.2

The following limits hold:

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\ln(1+x)}{x} = 1, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{e^x - 1}{x} = 1. \quad (1.6)$$

More generally, for $b > 0$,

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{b^x - 1}{x} = \ln b.$$



Idea. Taking a logarithm converts the power limit into a quotient limit. Then the inverse relation between the exponential and logarithm transfers the result to $e^x - 1$.

Proof By Lemma 1.2, the logarithm tends to its value at e . The composition theorem therefore allows us to take the logarithm in (1.5):

$$\frac{\ln(1+x)}{x} = \ln((1+x)^{1/x}) \rightarrow \ln e = 1.$$

For the second limit, set $u = e^x - 1$. The same lemma gives $u \rightarrow 0$, and $u \neq 0$ for $x \neq 0$ by strict monotonicity of the exponential. Since $x = \ln(1+u)$,

$$\frac{e^x - 1}{x} = \frac{u}{\ln(1+u)} \rightarrow 1.$$

If $b \neq 1$, substitute $t = x \ln b$ into the second limit and use $b^x = e^{x \ln b}$. If $b = 1$, the numerator is identically zero and the limit is $0 = \ln 1$. □

Example 1.34 Tracking direction under substitution Evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0^-} \frac{\ln(1-x)}{x}, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow +\infty} x(e^{1/x} - 1).$$

Solution For the first limit, set $t = -x$. Then $x \rightarrow 0^-$ means $t \rightarrow 0^+$, not merely $t \rightarrow 0$, and

$$\frac{\ln(1-x)}{x} = -\frac{\ln(1+t)}{t} \rightarrow -1.$$

For the second, set $t = 1/x$. The tail $x \rightarrow +\infty$ becomes $t \rightarrow 0^+$, and

$$x(e^{1/x} - 1) = \frac{e^t - 1}{t} \rightarrow 1.$$

In both cases the direction and the transformed domain agree with the relevant one-sided form of (1.6).

Proposition 1.14 (Logarithmic reduction of a power)

Along a fixed approach, suppose that $F(x) > 0$ eventually and

$$G(x) \ln F(x) \longrightarrow A \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Then

$$F(x)^{G(x)} \longrightarrow e^A.$$

In particular, if $u(x) \rightarrow 0$, $1 + u(x) > 0$ eventually, and $u(x)v(x) \rightarrow c \in \mathbb{R}$, then

$$(1 + u(x))^{v(x)} \longrightarrow e^c.$$

This conclusion remains valid when $u(x) = 0$ at some inputs.



Proof The identity

$$F(x)^{G(x)} = \exp(G(x) \ln F(x))$$

and continuity of the exponential give the first statement. For the special case, define

$$r(t) = \begin{cases} \frac{\ln(1+t)}{t}, & t \neq 0, \\ 1, & t = 0. \end{cases}$$

By (1.6), $r(t) \rightarrow 1$ as $t \rightarrow 0$, and the chosen value makes r continuous there. At every relevant input, including those with $u(x) = 0$,

$$v(x) \ln(1 + u(x)) = u(x)v(x)r(u(x)) \longrightarrow c.$$

Apply the first statement with $F = 1 + u$ and $G = v$. □

Example 1.35 A power with a hidden finite exponent Evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} (1 + x \sin x)^{1/x^2}.$$

Solution For sufficiently small x , one has $x \sin x \geq 0$, so the base is positive. Set $u(x) = x \sin x$ and $v(x) = 1/x^2$. Then $u(x) \rightarrow 0$ and

$$u(x)v(x) = \frac{\sin x}{x} \longrightarrow 1.$$

Therefore Proposition 1.14 gives the limit e .

Power-form decision. For a positive varying base, do not manipulate an apparent form such as 1^∞ , 0^0 , or ∞^0 directly. Take a logarithm and study the single product $G \ln F$. The positivity of F is a domain condition, and the resulting product may still require factoring, substitution, or a rate comparison.

1.4.7 Infinitesimals and their comparison

The words “small” and “large” become meaningful only after an approach has been specified. For example, $1/x$ tends to 0 as $x \rightarrow +\infty$, but its magnitude grows without bound as $x \rightarrow 0$.

Definition 1.23

Along a fixed approach, a function α is an infinitesimal (无穷小量) if $\alpha(x) \rightarrow 0$. It is an infinite quantity (无穷大量) if $|\alpha(x)| \rightarrow +\infty$.



An infinitesimal is a varying quantity with limit zero, not a particular very small positive number. A finite limit $f(x) \rightarrow L$ is equivalent to $f(x) = L + \alpha(x)$ with an infinitesimal α . Finite sums of infinitesimals are infinitesimal, as is the product of an infinitesimal and a bounded function. The quotient of two infinitesimals

requires a separate comparison. If α is eventually nonzero, then

$$\alpha(x) \rightarrow 0 \iff \frac{1}{|\alpha(x)|} \rightarrow +\infty.$$

Indeed, the inequalities $|\alpha(x)| < 1/M$ and $1/|\alpha(x)| > M$ are equivalent. The analogous reciprocal statement holds for an infinite quantity.

Definition 1.24

Let α and β be infinitesimals along the same approach, and assume β is eventually nonzero.

1. If $\alpha/\beta \rightarrow 0$, we write $\alpha = o(\beta)$ and say that α is of higher order (高阶无穷小) than β .
2. If $\alpha/\beta \rightarrow c \neq 0$ with $c \in \mathbb{R}$, they are of the same order (同阶无穷小).
3. If $\alpha/\beta \rightarrow 1$, we write $\alpha \sim \beta$ and call them equivalent infinitesimals (等价无穷小).



For example, as $x \rightarrow 0$, $x^2 = o(x)$, $3x$ and x have the same order, and $\sin x \sim x$. The comparison concerns a ratio, so signs must be retained: $-x$ and x have the same order but are not equivalent. Also, not every pair is comparable by a ratio limit; $x \sin(1/x)$ and x provide an example. The assertion $\alpha \sim \beta$ is equivalent to $\alpha = \beta(1 + \eta)$ with $\eta \rightarrow 0$, or to $\alpha - \beta = o(\beta)$.

Proposition 1.15

Suppose $\alpha \sim \tilde{\alpha}$ and $\beta \sim \tilde{\beta}$, with all four functions nonzero sufficiently far along the approach. Then

$$\frac{\alpha\tilde{\beta}}{\tilde{\alpha}\beta} \rightarrow 1, \quad \frac{\alpha/\tilde{\alpha}}{\beta/\tilde{\beta}} \rightarrow 1.$$

In particular, if $\tilde{\alpha}/\tilde{\beta} \rightarrow L \in \mathbb{R}$, then $\alpha/\beta \rightarrow L$. The same replacement preserves a signed infinite limit of the quotient.



Proof The first ratio is $(\alpha/\tilde{\alpha})(\tilde{\beta}/\beta)$, and the second is $(\alpha/\tilde{\alpha})/(\beta/\tilde{\beta})$. Both tend to 1 by the arithmetic laws. Multiplication by a factor tending to 1 preserves a finite limit. For an infinite limit, this factor lies between $1/2$ and $3/2$ eventually, so the definition of the corresponding infinite limit gives the conclusion. $\square$

The trigonometric estimates and (1.6) yield the useful list, all as $x \rightarrow 0$:

$$\sin x \sim x, \quad \tan x \sim x, \quad 1 - \cos x \sim \frac{x^2}{2}, \quad \ln(1+x) \sim x, \quad e^x - 1 \sim x. \quad (1.7)$$

For a fixed $p \in \mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$, one also has

$$(1+x)^p - 1 \sim px.$$

To verify it, put $t = p \ln(1+x)$ and use

$$\frac{(1+x)^p - 1}{px} = \frac{e^t - 1}{t} \frac{\ln(1+x)}{x} \rightarrow 1.$$

All expressions are taken for sufficiently small x with $1+x > 0$. For $p = 0$, the numerator is zero; the ratio to px is undefined, so the equivalence must not be asserted.

Example 1.36 Replacement in a product Evaluate $\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sin(2x) \ln(1+3x)}{1 - \cos(4x)}$.

Solution By (1.7), the three factors have equivalents $2x$, $3x$, and $8x^2$, respectively. Thus Proposition 1.15 gives

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sin(2x) \ln(1+3x)}{1 - \cos(4x)} = \lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{(2x)(3x)}{8x^2} = \frac{3}{4}.$$

Example 1.37 Cancellation changes the required precision Evaluate $\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sqrt{1+x} - 1 - x/2}{x^2}$.

Idea. The equivalence $\sqrt{1+x} - 1 \sim x/2$ describes the leading term. That term is subtracted in the numerator, so the equivalence alone does not determine the remaining error. Use exact identities before passing to a limit.

Solution For sufficiently small nonzero x , let $s = \sqrt{1+x}$. Then

$$s - 1 - \frac{x}{2} = \frac{x}{s+1} - \frac{x}{2} = \frac{x(1-s)}{2(s+1)} = -\frac{x^2}{2(s+1)^2}.$$

Since $s \rightarrow 1$, the required limit is $-1/8$. Replacing $s - 1$ by $x/2$ inside the difference would have erased the entire nonzero answer.

Equivalence is compatible with multiplication and division in the stated setting; it does not authorize term-by-term substitution in an arbitrary sum or difference. For the elementary counterexample $\alpha = x + x^2 \sim x$, the difference $\alpha - x = x^2$ is not equivalent to the result 0 of such a substitution. Whenever leading terms cancel, return to an identity or prove a sharper error estimate.

1.4.8 Methods, pitfalls, and further questions

A useful order of work is to determine the domain and approach, test whether direct substitution is justified, and only then choose a transformation. At a finite limiting point, first check that the domain has points arbitrarily close to it other than the point itself; the arcsine example at 2 shows why this check comes before calculation. For a direct proof, isolate a small factor and bound the other factors locally. For algebraic indeterminate forms, factor or rationalize. For higher roots, factor a difference of powers and verify the new denominator's nonzero limit, as in Example 1.32. For a bounded oscillation multiplied by a small factor, use an absolute-value estimate and squeeze. For a change of variables, track the transformed domain and the direction of approach before applying the outer limit. For a positive power with varying base and exponent, take a logarithm and study the product of the exponent with the logarithm of the base. For infinite quantities, establish eventual signs and compare rates before using the rules in Proposition 1.13. For a suspected failure of a limit, try to find two admissible approaching sequences with incompatible output limits. For products or quotients of standard small quantities, check the hypotheses of equivalent replacement.

Three distinctions deserve particular attention. The value $f(a)$ and the limit at a answer different questions. Local boundedness is weaker than existence of a limit, and unboundedness is weaker than a signed infinite limit. Finally, a finite collection of numerical samples or approaching sequences can disprove a proposed limit but cannot establish the universal requirement in Theorem 1.14.

Further Questions. Can a function have a limit at every point while being discontinuous at some points? What additional condition makes substitution of the limiting input legitimate? The next section answers these questions by comparing the limit near a point with the value at the point itself.

Exercise 1.4

- Write the full quantified definitions of $\lim_{x \rightarrow a^-} f(x) = L$, $\lim_{x \rightarrow -\infty} f(x) = L$, and $\lim_{x \rightarrow a^+} f(x) = -\infty$. State the corresponding assumptions on the domain.
- Let $m, b, a \in \mathbb{R}$. Prove directly that $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} (mx + b) = ma + b$. For a fixed $\varepsilon > 0$ and $m \neq 0$, find the largest possible δ in the definition; treat $m = 0$ separately.
- Prove directly that $\lim_{x \rightarrow 2} 1/x = 1/2$. Explain why a preliminary restriction such as $|x - 2| < 1$ is useful.
- Determine both one-sided limits at 0 for each function, and decide whether the two-sided limit exists:

$$\frac{\sqrt{1+x}-1}{|x|}, \quad \frac{|\sin x|}{x}, \quad \lfloor x \rfloor, \quad \frac{1}{x^3}.$$

Distinguish finite and infinite limits.

- Evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow a} \frac{x^n - a^n}{x - a} \quad (n \geq 1, a \in \mathbb{R}), \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sqrt{1+2x} - \sqrt{1-x}}{x}.$$

In the first limit, handle $n = 1$ separately so that no convention for 0^0 is needed.

- Evaluate the limits of $\sqrt{x^2 + 3x} - \sqrt{x^2 - x}$ as $x \rightarrow +\infty$ and as $x \rightarrow -\infty$. Identify where the sign of x affects the rationalized expression.
- Find all vertical and horizontal asymptotes of $f(x) = (2x + 1)/(x - 1)$, stating the relevant limits.
- Evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} x \lfloor 1/x \rfloor, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow +\infty} \frac{\sin x}{x + \cos x}.$$

Use an absolute-value estimate in each case, and justify the denominator bound in the second expression.

- Let $h(x) = \sin(\pi/x)$ for $x \neq 0$. Since $h(1/n) = 0$ for all $n \geq 1$, a proposed argument claims that $\lim_{x \rightarrow 0^+} h(x) = 0$. Explain the logical error and construct another positive input sequence that disproves the claimed limit.
- Let $f(x) = xD(x)$, where D is the Dirichlet function. Prove that $f(x) \rightarrow 0$ as $x \rightarrow 0$, and that f has no limit at any $a \neq 0$.
- Evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sin(x^2)}{x \sin x}, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sin(3x) - \sin x}{x}, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{1 - \cos(3x)}{x \sin(2x)}.$$

- Evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} (1 + 2x)^{3/x}, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow +\infty} \left(1 - \frac{2}{x}\right)^x.$$

State where the real powers are defined before transforming them.

- Evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\ln(1 + 4x)}{\sin(3x)}, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{5^x - 1}{\tan(2x)}, \quad \lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{(1 + x)^p - 1}{x} \quad (p \in \mathbb{R}).$$

- Order x^4 , $1 - \cos x$, and $\sin x$ by their relative smallness as $x \rightarrow 0$. Express the comparisons using o and give an equivalent for $1 - \cos x$.
- Decide which statements follow from $f(x) \rightarrow L$ as $x \rightarrow a$, and give a proof or counterexample: f is bounded on its whole domain; f is bounded near a ; $f(x) < L$ eventually; $|f(x)| \rightarrow |L|$. Interpret “near a ” as punctured if $f(a)$ is undefined.
- Prove the squeeze theorem using the sequential criterion and the sequence squeeze theorem. Identify the part of the argument that requires the approaching sequence to be arbitrary.
- Let $u(x) \rightarrow 0$ as $x \rightarrow 0$, and define $v(0) = 2$ and $v(t) = 1$ for $t \neq 0$. Give one u for which $v(u(x)) \rightarrow 1$, one for which it tends to 2, and one for which it has no limit at 0.

18. Evaluate by exact rationalization

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sqrt{1+x} + \sqrt{1-x} - 2}{x^2}.$$

Explain why substituting $\sqrt{1+x} - 1 \sim x/2$ and $\sqrt{1-x} - 1 \sim -x/2$ inside the sum does not give the answer.

19. Determine all real
- c, d
- for which the function

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} (e^{cx} - 1)/x, & x < 0, \\ d, & x = 0, \\ \ln(1+x)/\sin(2x), & x > 0 \end{cases}$$

has a finite limit at 0, on the domain where the displayed formulas are defined. What is that limit, and what role does d play?

20. Suppose $\alpha \sim \beta$ and $\gamma = o(\beta)$, with β eventually nonzero. Prove that $\alpha + \gamma \sim \beta$. Construct $\alpha \sim \beta$ for which $\alpha - \beta$ is not identically zero, and explain why its order cannot be recovered from the equivalence alone.

Supplement Exercises

- S1. Prove the sequential criterion for $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f(x) = +\infty$. Write out the negation of the infinite-limit definition in the converse argument.
- S2. For $p > 0$, study $f_p(x) = |x|^p \sin(1/x)$ as $x \rightarrow 0$. Determine its limit and find all $q > 0$ for which $f_p = o(|x|^q)$.
- S3. Suppose f is defined on a punctured neighbourhood of 0 and $f(x)^2 \rightarrow 1$ as $x \rightarrow 0$. Show that $|f(x)| \rightarrow 1$. Must f have a limit? Give a counterexample and then a sufficient condition involving its eventual sign.
- S4. Suppose $f(x) \rightarrow A$ and $f(x)g(x) \rightarrow B$ as $x \rightarrow a$, with $A \neq 0$. Prove that $g(x) \rightarrow B/A$. Show by examples that no such conclusion follows when $A = 0$, even if g is bounded.
- S5. Let f be increasing and bounded on (a, b) , where $a < b$ are finite. Prove that its one-sided limits at the endpoints exist and equal $\inf f((a, b))$ and $\sup f((a, b))$, respectively. Here “increasing” may be read as nondecreasing.
- S6. Along $x \rightarrow 0^+$, let $v(x) = 1/x$. Construct choices of $u(x) \rightarrow 0$, with $1+u(x) > 0$, for which $(1+u(x))^{v(x)}$ tends respectively to 1, e , and e^2 . Construct one further choice for which the power has no limit.

Hint. Use Proposition 1.14 and design the product $u(x)v(x)$ first. For the nonconvergent case, make that product oscillate between two values along suitable sequences.

- S7. Construct a function on $(0, 1)$ which is unbounded in every right-hand neighbourhood of 0 but has neither limit $+\infty$ nor limit $-\infty$ there. Then construct one whose absolute value tends to $+\infty$ while the function has no signed infinite limit.
- S8. For integers $m, n \geq 1$, evaluate

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sqrt{1 + \sin(mx)} - \sqrt{1 - \sin(mx)}}{\sin(nx)}.$$

Use only identities and limits proved in this section.

- S9. Let $E = \{1/n : n \geq 1\}$ and define $f(x) = 1$ on E and $f(x) = 0$ on $\mathbb{R} \setminus E$. Determine every $a \in \mathbb{R}$ at which $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f(x)$ exists. Distinguish a point of E from the accumulation point 0.
- S10. Prove that $\alpha \sim \beta$ and $\beta \sim \gamma$ imply $\alpha \sim \gamma$, under the eventual nonzero conditions. Is $\alpha + \beta \sim \gamma + \eta$ implied by $\alpha \sim \gamma$ and $\beta \sim \eta$? Give a counterexample with both sums eventually nonzero, and explain how cancellation causes the failure.

1.5 Continuous Functions

重点内容与证明方法

- ❑ Relate continuity to values, nearby limits, and domain endpoints.
- ❑ Classify discontinuities and construct continuous extensions.
- ❑ Apply algebra, composition, and quantitative estimates.
- ❑ Use sequences and dense sets to test continuity.
- ❑ Prove inverse continuity with the domain made explicit.
- ❑ Distinguish continuity from stronger forms of local control.

A limit describes what the values near a point approach. Continuity asks whether that limiting behaviour agrees with the value at the point. For instance, $(x^2 - 1)/(x - 1)$ tends to 2 at 1. Assigning the value 2 fills its hole consistently with the surrounding graph; assigning any other value creates a mismatch. This agreement, rather than any particular formula or way of drawing a graph, is the central idea.

1.5.1 Continuity at a point and on a domain

Definition 1.25

Let $f: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ and $a \in D$. The function is continuous at a (在一点连续) if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists $\delta > 0$ such that

$$x \in D, \quad |x - a| < \delta \implies |f(x) - f(a)| < \varepsilon.$$

The function is continuous on D (在集合上连续) if it is continuous at every point of D .



The exact negation of continuity at a is

$$\exists \varepsilon_0 > 0 \quad \forall \delta > 0 \quad \exists x \in D : \quad |x - a| < \delta, \quad |f(x) - f(a)| \geq \varepsilon_0.$$

Unlike the negation of a punctured function limit, the selected input is allowed to equal a in principle; however, it cannot do so because the output error would then be zero. Choosing one such input for each $\delta = 1/n$ produces the bad sequence used in the sequential criterion for continuity.

This definition includes the input $x = a$. At that input the output error is zero, so no exclusion is needed. When a is an accumulation point of D , continuity is equivalent to

$$\lim_{\substack{x \rightarrow a \\ x \in D}} f(x) = f(a).$$

Thus the familiar limit test checks three things: the value $f(a)$ is defined, the finite limit exists, and that limit equals $f(a)$.

The domain is part of the statement. For example, $1/x$ is continuous at every point of $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$. It is not a function on all of $\mathbb{R}$ with the displayed formula. We may discuss its singular behaviour or possible extension at 0, but continuity at 0 requires a value there. At an isolated point of D , continuity is automatic: choose a neighbourhood containing no other point of D . The accumulation-point assumption in the function-limit definition prevents us from using a vacuous limit test at such a point.

If f is defined on $[a, b]$ with $a < b$, continuity at a means

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow a^+} f(x) = f(a),$$

and continuity at b means the corresponding equality for the left-hand limit. These are *right continuity* (右连续) and *left continuity* (左连续), respectively. Continuity on $[a, b]$ requires continuity at every interior point and these one-sided conditions at the endpoints. For half-open intervals, impose the one-sided condition only at the included endpoint.

Example 1.38 An endpoint estimate Prove that $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ is continuous on $[0, +\infty)$.

Solution For nonnegative x, y , assume first that $x \geq y$. Then

$$x - y = (\sqrt{x} - \sqrt{y})(\sqrt{x} + \sqrt{y}) \geq (\sqrt{x} - \sqrt{y})^2.$$

Interchanging x, y when necessary gives

$$|\sqrt{x} - \sqrt{y}| \leq \sqrt{|x - y|}. \quad (1.8)$$

For any $a \geq 0$ and $\varepsilon > 0$, choose $\delta = \varepsilon^2$. If $x \geq 0$ and $|x - a| < \delta$, then $|\sqrt{x} - \sqrt{a}| < \varepsilon$. This argument also covers the endpoint $a = 0$.

Reading a graph. The informal description “draw the graph without lifting the pencil” can guide intuition on an interval, but it does not specify domains, endpoints, or the required input control. For proofs, use the definition or one of the criteria established below.

1.5.2 Algebra and composition of continuous functions

Theorem 1.20

If $f, g: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ are continuous at $a \in D$, then $f + g$, $f - g$, and fg are continuous at a . Every constant multiple of f is continuous there. If $g(a) \neq 0$, then f/g is defined on a neighbourhood of a relative to D and is continuous at a on its domain.



Proof If a is an accumulation point of D , apply Theorem 1.15 to the limits $f(x) \rightarrow f(a)$ and $g(x) \rightarrow g(a)$. The resulting limits equal the values of the corresponding functions at a . When $g(a) \neq 0$, continuity gives $|g(x) - g(a)| < |g(a)|/2$ near a , so $|g(x)| > |g(a)|/2$ there. If a is isolated in D , every displayed function that is defined at a is continuous there directly from the definition. $\square$

Restricting a continuous function to a smaller domain preserves continuity at every point retained in that domain. Indeed, the same δ controls all inputs in the smaller set. This observation lets us apply the algebraic rules on a common domain even when the original functions have different domains.

Theorem 1.21

Let $f: D \rightarrow E$ and $g: E \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, where $D, E \subseteq \mathbb{R}$. If f is continuous at $a \in D$ and g is continuous at $f(a)$ relative to E , then $g \circ f$ is continuous at a .



Idea. Work backwards from the desired output error. Continuity of g supplies a tolerance for its input, and continuity of f turns that tolerance into a neighbourhood of a . Unlike a punctured outer limit, continuity also controls the case $f(x) = f(a)$.

Proof Let $\varepsilon > 0$. Since g is continuous at $f(a)$, there is $\eta > 0$ such that

$$y \in E, \quad |y - f(a)| < \eta \implies |g(y) - g(f(a))| < \varepsilon.$$

Continuity of f at a gives $\delta > 0$ such that

$$x \in D, \quad |x - a| < \delta \implies |f(x) - f(a)| < \eta.$$

Because $f(x) \in E$, substitution into the first implication proves the required estimate for $g(f(x))$. $\square$

Example 1.39 Continuity without limits of all factors Determine all points of continuity of

$$F(x) = \begin{cases} x \sin(1/x), & x \neq 0, \\ 0, & x = 0. \end{cases}$$

Solution At every nonzero point, continuity follows from arithmetic and composition, using the sine limits

established in Section 1.4. At 0, the inner function $1/x$ has no finite limit, so that composition argument does not apply. Instead, $|F(x) - F(0)| \leq |x|$ proves continuity directly. Thus F is continuous on all of $\mathbb{R}$. Theorems give sufficient conditions; failure of one theorem's hypotheses does not establish discontinuity.

1.5.3 Inverse functions and elementary functions

An inverse function interchanges inputs and outputs. To establish its continuity, an input interval around a must produce a usable interval of output control around $f(a)$. Strict monotonicity provides such control without a formula for the inverse.

Theorem 1.22

Let I be an interval and let $f: I \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be strictly monotone. Then the inverse $f^{-1}: f(I) \rightarrow I$ is continuous relative to its domain $f(I)$ and is strictly monotone in the same direction as f . In particular, this applies when f is continuous and strictly monotone on I .



Proof Strategy. For an increasing function, points to the left and right of a have images strictly below and above $f(a)$. Keep the new output between those images; monotonicity forces its inverse image to remain near a . At an included endpoint, only the available side needs a bracket.

Proof Suppose f is strictly increasing, fix $a \in I$, and write $b = f(a)$. The inverse exists on $f(I)$ by injectivity, and order preservation of the inverse follows directly from strict increase of f . Let $\varepsilon > 0$. If I has a point less than a , the interval property allows us to choose $u \in I$ with $a - \varepsilon < u < a$. Likewise, if I has a point greater than a , choose $v \in I$ with $a < v < a + \varepsilon$. For every available bracket, the numbers $b - f(u)$ and $f(v) - b$ are strictly positive. Choose δ to be the minimum of the available positive numbers; if neither side is available, $I = \{a\}$ and the inverse is continuous automatically.

Let $y \in f(I)$ satisfy $|y - b| < \delta$, and set $x = f^{-1}(y)$. If u was chosen, then $y > f(u)$, so $x > u > a - \varepsilon$. If no left bracket was available, every point of I is at least a , which gives the same required lower bound. Similarly, either $y < f(v)$ forces $x < v < a + \varepsilon$, or every point of I is at most a . Thus $|f^{-1}(y) - a| < \varepsilon$, proving continuity at b . For strictly decreasing f , apply the increasing case to $-f$ and compose the resulting inverse with $y \mapsto -y$. $\square$

The theorem asserts continuity on the *actual range* $f(I)$. It does not assert that this range is an interval when f is discontinuous. For example, the strictly increasing function

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x, & x < 0, \\ x + 1, & x \geq 0 \end{cases}$$

has range $(-\infty, 0) \cup [1, +\infty)$. Its inverse is continuous on that range, including at 1 relative to the range, although f itself jumps at 0. In the next section, the intermediate value theorem will show that the range of a continuous function on an interval is an interval.

Corollary 1.3

Every elementary function is continuous on its natural domain.



Proof Constant functions and the identity are continuous directly from the definition. The arithmetic rules give continuity of polynomials and of rational functions wherever their denominators are nonzero. The trigonometric limits in Section 1.4 give continuity of sine and cosine, and of their quotients wherever defined. The exponential and logarithmic functions are continuous by Lemma 1.2.

For $x > 0$, a real power $x^p = e^{p \ln x}$ is continuous by composition. When $p > 0$ and the value $0^p = 0$ is included, continuity at 0 follows from $0 \leq x < \varepsilon^{1/p} \implies x^p < \varepsilon$. Integer powers already follow from arithmetic. Roots on their real domains are continuous inverses of the corresponding strictly monotone power functions; odd roots include negative inputs, and even roots use the nonnegative interval. The inverse trigonometric functions are continuous by Theorem 1.22, using the standard intervals of strict monotonicity specified in Section 1.2. This also handles their included endpoints. Finally, finitely many arithmetic operations and compositions preserve continuity on the domain where the resulting expression is defined. $\square$

Example 1.40 Determine the domain first Find the natural domain of

$$h(x) = \frac{\ln(1 - x^2)}{\sqrt{x + 2}}$$

and determine where it is continuous.

Solution The logarithm requires $1 - x^2 > 0$, so $-1 < x < 1$. The denominator requires $x + 2 > 0$, which already holds on this interval. Thus the natural domain is $(-1, 1)$, and h is continuous at every point of it by Corollary 1.3. The formula has no values at -1 and 1 . Endpoint extension is a separate question, to be decided by limits rather than by a direct substitution into the formula.

1.5.4 Discontinuities and continuous extensions

When a function is defined on a neighbourhood of a but fails to be continuous there, a is a *point of discontinuity* (间断点). The same terminology is often used when the original formula is defined only on a punctured neighbourhood, in order to discuss whether it can be extended across the missing point. We will explicitly distinguish a missing value from an assigned value that fails the continuity test.

Definition 1.26

Suppose f is defined on a punctured neighbourhood of a .

1. A removable discontinuity (可去间断点) occurs if $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f(x) = L \in \mathbb{R}$, but $f(a)$ is missing or differs from L .
2. A jump discontinuity (跳跃间断点) occurs if both one-sided limits are finite but unequal.
3. An infinite discontinuity (无穷间断点) occurs if at least one one-sided limit is $+\infty$ or $-\infty$.
4. An oscillatory discontinuity (振荡间断点) describes a failure of a one-sided limit caused by persistent oscillation, as for $\sin(1/(x - a))$.



Removable and jump discontinuities are traditionally called discontinuities of the *first kind* (第一类间断点), since both one-sided finite limits exist. If at least one finite one-sided limit does not exist, the discontinuity is of the *second kind* (第二类间断点). The last two descriptions in Definition 1.26 identify common mechanisms of the second kind; a more complicated function can combine different behaviours on its two sides. Neither a jump nor persistent oscillation can be repaired by changing just $f(a)$.

The schematics in **Figure 1.7** separate a mismatched value, unequal side limits, and unbounded growth. The following examples make the distinctions exact.

Example 1.41 Classifying singular behaviour Classify the behaviour at 0 of the following formulas, initially defined for $x \neq 0$:

$$\frac{\sin x}{x}, \quad \frac{|x|}{x}, \quad \frac{1}{x^2}, \quad \sin(1/x).$$

For each, determine whether assigning a value at 0 can make it continuous there.

Solution The first has limit 1, so assigning that value gives continuity; its missing point is removable. The

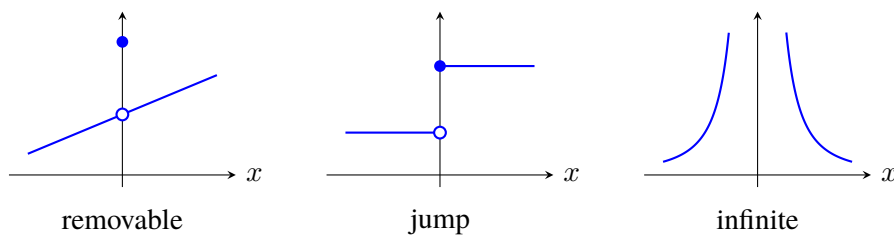


Figure 1.7: Three ways in which nearby values can fail to agree with a value at the origin. Oscillation gives another mechanism, illustrated in **Figure 1.5**.

second has side limits -1 and 1 , hence a jump. The third tends to $+\infty$, so it has an infinite discontinuity under any real-valued assignment at 0 . The fourth has distinct sequential output limits even from one side, hence oscillatory behaviour. Only the first admits a continuous extension.

Proposition 1.16

Let a be an accumulation point of D , with $a \notin D$, and let $f: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. A function $F: D \cup \{a\} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ agreeing with f on D can be continuous at a if and only if $\lim_{x \rightarrow a, x \in D} f(x)$ exists as a finite real number. In that case the unique possible value is

$$F(a) = \lim_{\substack{x \rightarrow a \\ x \in D}} f(x).$$

If f is also continuous on D , this defines a continuous extension (连续延拓) on $D \cup \{a\}$.

Proof Continuity at a requires the limit to equal $F(a)$, so necessity and uniqueness follow from the definition and uniqueness of limits. Conversely, assign the finite limit to $F(a)$. The limit estimate gives continuity at a , including the trivial case $x = a$. At a point $b \in D$, restrict to a neighbourhood of radius less than $|b - a|$; within it the extension agrees with f , so any continuity at b is preserved. $\square$

Example 1.42 Gluing three pieces Find all $A, B \in \mathbb{R}$ for which

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} \sin x/x, & x < 0, \\ A, & x = 0, \\ B + \ln(1+x)/x, & x > 0 \end{cases}$$

is continuous on $\mathbb{R}$.

Solution Each open piece is continuous on its domain, so only 0 needs a special check. The left-hand limit is 1 , and the right-hand limit is $B + 1$. Both must equal $f(0) = A$. Thus $A = 1$ and $B = 0$, and these choices do give continuity everywhere. Matching the two side limits would determine B but would leave the value A unchecked.

Example 1.43 A floor-function composition Determine the discontinuities of $g(x) = \lfloor x^2 \rfloor$.

Solution If x_0^2 is not an integer, then it lies strictly between two consecutive integers. Continuity of x^2 keeps nearby squared values in that same interval, so g is locally constant at x_0 . At 0 , one has $g(x) = 0$ for $|x| < 1$, so g is continuous there as well. For a positive integer n , at $x_0 = \sqrt{n}$ the left and right limits are $n - 1$ and n . At $x_0 = -\sqrt{n}$, their order is reversed: the limits are n and $n - 1$. Thus the discontinuities are exactly $\pm\sqrt{n}$ for $n \geq 1$, and each is a jump. An integer value of the inner function alone does not guarantee a discontinuity of the composition; the way nearby inputs reach that value matters.

1.5.5 Sequential continuity and quantitative control

Theorem 1.23

Let $f: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ and $a \in D$. Then f is continuous at a if and only if every sequence (x_n) in D converging to a satisfies $f(x_n) \rightarrow f(a)$. The sequence is allowed to contain the point a .



Idea. The argument resembles Heine's criterion, but the input neighbourhood is no longer punctured and the proposed output limit is fixed to be $f(a)$. Failure of continuity supplies inputs arbitrarily close to a whose outputs stay a fixed positive distance from $f(a)$.

Proof If f is continuous at a , choose δ for a given $\varepsilon > 0$. Since $x_n \rightarrow a$, eventually $|x_n - a| < \delta$, and hence $|f(x_n) - f(a)| < \varepsilon$. Conversely, if continuity fails, there is $\varepsilon_0 > 0$ such that for every $n \geq 1$ we can choose $x_n \in D$ with

$$|x_n - a| < \frac{1}{n}, \quad |f(x_n) - f(a)| \geq \varepsilon_0.$$

This sequence tends to a but its output sequence does not tend to $f(a)$, contradicting the stated property. $\square$

Example 1.44 A function controlled at just one point Determine all points of continuity of $f(x) = xD(x)$ on $\mathbb{R}$.

Solution Since $|f(x)| \leq |x|$ and $f(0) = 0$, the function is continuous at 0. At $a \neq 0$, choose rational and irrational sequences both tending to a . The rational outputs tend to a , and the irrational outputs equal 0. They cannot both tend to the single value $f(a)$. Thus the only point of continuity is 0. The factor x suppresses the dense-set disagreement exactly where that factor vanishes.

Definition 1.27

A function $f: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is Lipschitz continuous (Lipschitz 连续) on D if there is a constant $K \geq 0$ such that

$$|f(x) - f(y)| \leq K|x - y| \quad (x, y \in D).$$



Every Lipschitz function is continuous: if $K > 0$, choose $\delta = \varepsilon/K$ in the continuity definition at any point; if $K = 0$, the function is constant on a nonempty domain. Even a local estimate $|f(x) - f(a)| \leq C|x - a|$ near one point is enough for continuity at that point. Such estimates give more information than the bare existence of a suitable neighbourhood.

The reverse triangle inequality shows that $|x|$ is Lipschitz on $\mathbb{R}$ with $K = 1$. For $x, y \in [-R, R]$ with $R > 0$,

$$|x^2 - y^2| = |x - y||x + y| \leq 2R|x - y|,$$

so the square function is Lipschitz on each bounded interval of this form. The square-root function is continuous at 0, but it is not Lipschitz on $[0, 1]$. Indeed, a Lipschitz estimate with $y = 0$ and $x > 0$ would require $1/\sqrt{x} \leq K$, which fails as $x \rightarrow 0^+$. The weaker estimate (1.8) still gives continuity.

1.5.6 Further reading: a dense set of discontinuities

The Dirichlet function is discontinuous everywhere because two dense sets retain a fixed output separation. Can the same rational–irrational split produce continuity at irrational inputs? The answer changes when the size of a rational value decreases with its denominator.

Example 1.45 Thomae's function On $[0, 1]$, define

$$T(x) = \begin{cases} 1/q, & x = p/q \text{ in lowest terms, } q \geq 1, \\ 0, & x \notin \mathbb{Q}. \end{cases}$$

Here $0 = 0/1$ and $1 = 1/1$. Prove that T is continuous at every irrational point and discontinuous at every rational point of $[0, 1]$.

Proof Strategy. For a fixed tolerance, only finitely many rationals in $[0, 1]$ have denominators small enough to produce a large output. An irrational input can be separated from that finite exceptional set by a positive distance. At a rational input, an irrational sequence immediately detects the mismatch.

Proof Let $a \in [0, 1]$ be irrational and let $\varepsilon > 0$. Choose a positive integer N with $1/N < \varepsilon$. There are only finitely many reduced rationals in $[0, 1]$ with denominators $q \leq N$, since for each such q the numerator satisfies $0 \leq p \leq q$. Call this finite set E_N . It does not contain a , so the minimum distance from a to E_N is positive. Choose δ smaller than that distance. If $x \in [0, 1]$ and $|x - a| < \delta$, then either x is irrational and $T(x) = 0$, or x has reduced denominator $q > N$ and $T(x) = 1/q < 1/N < \varepsilon$. In either case $|T(x) - T(a)| < \varepsilon$.

Now let $a = p/q$ be rational in lowest terms. By density, choose irrational points $x_n \in [0, 1]$ tending to a , using the available one-sided interval at an endpoint. Then $T(x_n) = 0$ for every n , whereas $T(a) = 1/q > 0$. The sequential criterion proves discontinuity at a . $\square$

In fact, the same finite-set argument proves that the limit of $T(x)$ at every point of $[0, 1]$, through distinct domain points, is 0. At a rational a , omit a itself from E_N when choosing the distance; if no exceptional points remain, any small radius suffices. Thus each rational discontinuity is removable individually. Removing all of them produces the zero function. Continuity is local, and a complicated global pattern of exceptional points does not prevent a precise local proof.

1.5.7 Methods, pitfalls, and the local-to-global question

For a function given by elementary formulas on pieces, first identify the natural domain of each formula and the points where pieces meet. Away from those points, continuity often follows from the algebra and composition rules. At a meeting point, compute the available side limits and compare every one of them with the assigned value. At a missing point, a finite limit supplies the only possible continuous extension. When limits are difficult to compute, an error estimate or a carefully chosen sequence may settle the question directly.

Continuity of the outer function is a sufficient condition for continuity of a composition, not a necessary one. Likewise, Lipschitz control is sufficient but not necessary for continuity. Avoid turning a theorem's hypothesis into an automatic test for the opposite conclusion when that hypothesis fails. At an endpoint, all neighbourhoods are interpreted relative to the domain.

Looking ahead. Continuity at one point controls nearby values, but the radius may depend on that point. What can be concluded when continuity holds at every point of a closed bounded interval? The next section explains why the function must attain its largest and smallest values, take every intermediate value, and admit a single input tolerance valid throughout the interval.

Exercise 1.5

1. State the definition of continuity at a for a function on $[a, b)$ with $a < b$. Explain why a left-hand limit at a is not required and why no continuity condition is imposed at the missing endpoint b .

2. Prove directly that $f(x) = x^2$ is continuous at every $a \in \mathbb{R}$. Give a possible δ in terms of a and ε .
3. Determine the natural domain of each function and justify continuity on that domain:

$$\sqrt{1-x^2}, \quad \ln(x^2-1), \quad \frac{\arcsin x}{1-x}, \quad e^{1/(x-2)}.$$

4. Let $f(0) = c$ and $f(x) = \sin(3x)/x$ for $x \neq 0$. Determine the value of c giving continuity on $\mathbb{R}$. Classify the discontinuity at 0 for every other value of c .
5. Find $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ such that the following function is continuous on $\mathbb{R}$:

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x^2, & x \leq 1, \\ ax + b, & 1 < x < 2, \\ 3x - 1, & x \geq 2. \end{cases}$$

6. Classify every discontinuity of $\lfloor x \rfloor$, $x - \lfloor x \rfloor$, and $1/(x^2 - 1)$. For the last formula, discuss its missing points and their one-sided behaviour.
7. For the formula

$$f(x) = \frac{\sin x}{x(x-1)} \quad (x \in \mathbb{R} \setminus \{0, 1\}),$$

decide which missing points admit continuous extensions and find their values. Determine the largest domain in $\mathbb{R}$ to which this particular function can be continuously extended.

8. Prove that if f is continuous at a and $f(a) > 0$, then f is positive on a neighbourhood of a relative to its domain. Why is a positive value at a alone insufficient?
9. Prove that if f is continuous, then so is $|f|$. Deduce continuity of $\max\{f, g\}$ and $\min\{f, g\}$ whenever f and g are continuous on the same domain.
10. Give an example where $g \circ f$ is continuous at 0 but g is discontinuous at $f(0)$. Give another where $g \circ f$ is continuous at 0 but f is discontinuous at 0.
11. Determine all discontinuities of $f(x) = \lfloor \cos x \rfloor$ and classify each one. Pay particular attention to inputs where $\cos x$ equals 1, 0, or -1 .
12. Use sequences to determine all points of continuity of

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x^2, & x \in \mathbb{Q}, \\ -x, & x \notin \mathbb{Q}. \end{cases}$$

13. Prove that $f(x) = |2x - 1|$ is Lipschitz on $\mathbb{R}$. Prove that $g(x) = 1/x$ is Lipschitz on $[a, +\infty)$ for each fixed $a > 0$, and give a valid constant.
14. Prove that the function $x \mapsto x^{1/3}$ is continuous on $\mathbb{R}$ by applying the inverse-continuity theorem. Show that it is not Lipschitz on any interval containing 0 as an interior point.
15. Let $f: [-1, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous and strictly increasing, and let $b = f(0)$. Given $0 < \varepsilon < 1$, give an explicit positive δ in terms of $f(-\varepsilon)$, $f(0)$, and $f(\varepsilon)$ which proves continuity of f^{-1} at b .
16. Let $D = \{0\} \cup [1, 2]$, define $f(0) = 100$, and set $f(x) = x$ on $[1, 2]$. Prove that f is continuous on D . Explain why continuity at the isolated point 0 should be checked using the neighbourhood definition.
17. Suppose $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is continuous at a and $f(x) = 0$ for every rational x . Prove that $f(a) = 0$. Deduce that a continuous function on $\mathbb{R}$ is determined by its values on $\mathbb{Q}$.
18. Let $f: [-1, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ satisfy $|f(x) - f(0)| \leq C|x|^p$ for some constants $C > 0$ and $p > 0$. Prove continuity at 0 and give an explicit δ for every $\varepsilon > 0$. Does this assumption imply continuity at other points? Construct a counterexample if it does not.

Supplement Exercises

- S1. Let $f, g: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous, and define $h = f$ on $\mathbb{Q}$ and $h = g$ on $\mathbb{R} \setminus \mathbb{Q}$. Prove that h is continuous at a if and only if $f(a) = g(a)$.
- S2. Prove that if both $f + g$ and $f - g$ are continuous at a point, then both f and g are continuous there. Is the analogous claim with $f + g$ and fg true? Give a proof or counterexample.
- S3. Let $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ satisfy $f(x+y) = f(x) + f(y)$ for all real x, y . If f is continuous at 0, prove that $f(x) = cx$ for all x , where $c = f(1)$.
- | **Hint.** First establish the formula on $\mathbb{Q}$ and then pass to real inputs.
- S4. Suppose $f: (0, +\infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is continuous at 1 and satisfies $f(x^2) = f(x)$ for every $x > 0$. Prove that f is constant, using repeated square roots and a sequence converging to 1.
- S5. Prove directly that the limit of Thomae's function from Example 1.45 at each rational $a \in [0, 1]$, through distinct domain points, is 0. Explain how the finite exceptional set must be modified when it contains a .
- S6. Suppose $f: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ satisfies $|f(x) - f(y)| \leq C|x - y|^p$ for all $x, y \in D$, where $C > 0$ and $p > 0$. Prove continuity on D . If D is an interval and $p > 1$, prove that f is constant by dividing a segment into n equal parts.
- S7. Let I be an interval, and suppose $f: I \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is strictly increasing and $f(I)$ is also an interval. Prove that f is continuous. You may apply Theorem 1.22 to f^{-1} ; explain why its hypotheses hold.
- S8. Give a continuous injective function on a domain that is not an interval whose inverse on its range is discontinuous.
- | **Hint.** One possible domain is $[0, 1) \cup \{2\}$; arrange for a sequence approaching the missing point 1 to have images approaching the image of 2.
- S9. Let $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous at a and suppose $|f(a)| < 1$. Prove that some neighbourhood of a admits a constant $q < 1$ with $|f(x)| \leq q$ throughout that neighbourhood. Deduce that for every sequence $x_n \rightarrow a$, one has $f(x_n)^n \rightarrow 0$.
- S10. Define $F(0) = 0$ and $F(x) = x \sin(1/x^2)$ for $x \neq 0$. Prove continuity on $\mathbb{R}$ and prove that F is not Lipschitz on any neighbourhood of 0.

 | **Hint.** For the second assertion, compare inputs $x_n = (2\pi n + \pi/2)^{-1/2}$ and $y_n = (2\pi n + 3\pi/2)^{-1/2}$.

1.6 Continuous Functions on Closed Intervals

重点内容与证明方法

- Use intermediate values to prove existence, and test uniqueness separately.
- Study proofs using bisection and convergent subsequences.
- Distinguish bounds from attained extrema.
- Compare continuity and uniform continuity.
- Verify the hypotheses of closed-interval theorems.
- Prove Heine–Cantor and examine its hypotheses.

Continuity is defined one point at a time. Nevertheless, on a closed bounded interval it forces several properties of the whole function: it takes every intermediate value, attains its extreme values, and admits a single input tolerance that controls all points at once. These conclusions connect the local language of limits with the completeness of the real line. They also make it possible to prove that equations have solutions without first finding a formula for those solutions.

Throughout this section, $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$ and $a < b$ unless stated otherwise. Continuity on $[a, b]$ includes right continuity at a and left continuity at b . We first state the main conclusions and use them in examples. Complete proofs are given in the deeper-reading subsection Section 1.6.3, using results already established in this chapter.

1.6.1 Intermediate values and zeros

Theorem 1.24 (Intermediate value theorem)

Let $f: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous. If y lies between $f(a)$ and $f(b)$, including either endpoint value, then there exists $c \in [a, b]$ such that $f(c) = y$. If y lies strictly between $f(a)$ and $f(b)$, such a point lies in (a, b) .



The *intermediate value property* (介值性) expresses the absence of a gap in the values taken between two inputs. It does not assert monotonicity, and the point c need not be unique. For instance, a continuous oscillating graph may cross one horizontal level many times. The theorem applies to any continuous function on an interval by restricting it to the closed segment joining the two chosen inputs. Thus the interval need not itself be closed or bounded in order for intermediate values between two attained values to be attained.

Corollary 1.4 (Zero theorem)

If $f: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is continuous and $f(a)f(b) < 0$, then $f(c) = 0$ for some $c \in (a, b)$. If instead $f(a)f(b) \leq 0$, then a zero exists in $[a, b]$.



Proof With a strict sign change, 0 lies strictly between the endpoint values, so apply Theorem 1.24 with $y = 0$. If an endpoint value is zero, that endpoint supplies the conclusion in the nonstrict case. $\square$

Conversely, applying the zero theorem to $g(x) = f(x) - y$ proves the intermediate value theorem for a strictly intermediate level y . Endpoint levels are already attained at the endpoints. Thus the two statements contain the same existence mechanism. The strict sign condition is convenient for locating a zero inside an interval, but it is sufficient rather than necessary: x^2 has a zero on $[-1, 1]$ although its endpoint values are both positive.

Example 1.46 Existence and uniqueness of a root Prove that $x = \cos x$ has exactly one solution in $[0, 1]$.

Idea. To prove existence, move both sides to a continuous function with opposite endpoint signs. To prove uniqueness, use order: the left side is strictly increasing and the right side is decreasing on the interval. These are separate arguments.

Solution Set $g(x) = x - \cos x$. It is continuous on $[0, 1]$ by the continuity rules, $g(0) = -1 < 0$, and $g(1) = 1 - \cos 1 > 0$. The last inequality follows from $1 - \cos 1 = 2 \sin^2(1/2) > 0$. The zero theorem gives a solution in $(0, 1)$. If $0 \leq x < y \leq 1$, cosine is decreasing on $[0, 1] \subset [0, \pi]$, so $\cos x \geq \cos y$. The equalities $x = \cos x$ and $y = \cos y$ would therefore imply $x \geq y$, a contradiction. Thus the solution is unique. The elementary order property of cosine here can also be checked from $\cos x - \cos y = 2 \sin((x+y)/2) \sin((y-x)/2) > 0$ for $x < y$ in this interval.

The zero theorem supplies existence even when solving the equation exactly is impractical. It also supports a numerical procedure: once the endpoint signs are opposite, repeatedly halve the interval and keep a half whose endpoint values have opposite signs. The proof below shows why this *bisection method* (二分法) converges and gives its error bound.

1.6.2 Boundedness, extrema, and the range

Theorem 1.25

Every continuous function $f: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is bounded on $[a, b]$. That is, there exists $C \geq 0$ such that $|f(x)| \leq C$ for every $x \in [a, b]$.



Continuity at one point gives boundedness only near that point. The theorem combines the local behaviour over the entire interval. A point-dependent family of local bounds is not yet a proof of one global bound; the deeper-reading proof explains how the closed bounded domain supplies the missing step.

Definition 1.28

A function $f: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ attains its maximum (取得最大值) at $x_M \in D$ if $f(x) \leq f(x_M)$ for every $x \in D$. It attains its minimum (取得最小值) at $x_m \in D$ if $f(x_m) \leq f(x)$ for every $x \in D$. These are absolute extrema on the specified domain.



Theorem 1.26 (Extreme value theorem)

If $f: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is continuous, there exist $x_m, x_M \in [a, b]$ such that

$$f(x_m) \leq f(x) \leq f(x_M) \quad (x \in [a, b]).$$

Thus f attains both a minimum and a maximum. The points of attainment need not be unique and may be endpoints.



A supremum is a bound characterized by order; a maximum must also be a value of the function. For $f(x) = x$ on $(0, 1)$, the supremum is 1 and the infimum is 0, but neither is attained. On $[0, 1]$, both are attained. The distinction in **Figure 1.8** is exactly what boundedness alone leaves unresolved.

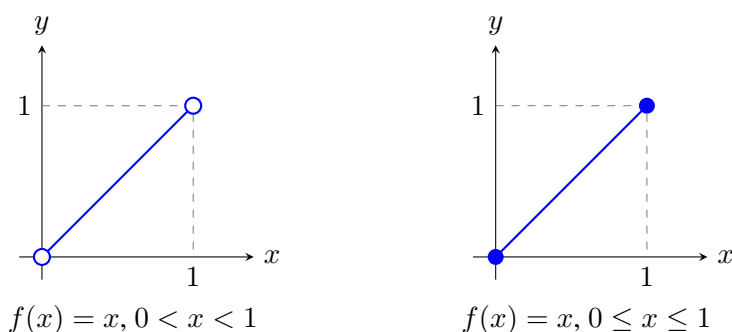


Figure 1.8: The same formula is bounded on both domains. Including the endpoints allows both extreme bounds to be attained.

Corollary 1.5

If $f: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is continuous and its minimum and maximum are m and M , then

$$f([a, b]) = [m, M].$$

In particular, if $f(x) > 0$ for every $x \in [a, b]$, then $f(x) \geq m > 0$ throughout the interval for some m . ♥

Proof Every value belongs to $[m, M]$ by the definitions of the extrema. If $m = M$, the function is constant and the range assertion is immediate. Otherwise, choose points x_m, x_M attaining the extrema and apply the intermediate value theorem on the segment with these two endpoints, placed in increasing order. Every number between m and M is attained there. If f is everywhere positive, its attained minimum $m = f(x_m)$ is positive. □

Pointwise positivity on an open interval gives no such uniform positive lower bound: $f(x) = x$ is positive on $(0, 1)$, but its infimum is zero. On a closed bounded interval, the positive lower bound also shows that the reciprocal of an everywhere positive continuous function is bounded.

Example 1.47 Existence of a fixed point Let $f: [a, b] \rightarrow [a, b]$ be continuous. Prove that there is $c \in [a, b]$ with $f(c) = c$. Such a point is called a *fixed point* (不动点) of f .

Idea. Subtract the input: the map-into-itself assumption gives the signs of $f(x) - x$ at both endpoints, even without knowing the actual endpoint values.

Solution Let $g(x) = f(x) - x$. It is continuous on $[a, b]$, and

$$g(a) = f(a) - a \geq 0, \quad g(b) = f(b) - b \leq 0.$$

If either endpoint value is zero, that endpoint is fixed. Otherwise the zero theorem gives a zero in (a, b) . Uniqueness need not hold: the identity function fixes every point of the interval.

Proposition 1.17

If $f: I \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is continuous and injective on an interval I , then it is strictly monotone. Consequently, its inverse is continuous on the interval $f(I)$. ♠

Proof Strategy. For three ordered inputs, the middle output must lie between the other two outputs. Otherwise an intermediate horizontal level would be attained twice, contradicting injectivity. Once this between-values property is known, the direction of increase or decrease cannot reverse.

Proof If $r < s < t$ are in I , injectivity makes their three outputs distinct. Suppose, for example, $f(s) > \max\{f(r), f(t)\}$. Choose y strictly between that maximum and $f(s)$. The intermediate value theorem on

$[r, s]$ and $[s, t]$ produces one preimage in each open segment, contradicting injectivity. The case $f(s) < \min\{f(r), f(t)\}$ is analogous. Hence $f(s)$ lies strictly between $f(r)$ and $f(t)$ for every ordered triple.

If I has at most one point, the conclusion is vacuous. Otherwise choose $u < v$ in I . Suppose $f(u) < f(v)$. For any $x < y$ in I , arrange the distinct points among u, v, x, y in increasing order. For each three consecutive points, the between-values property shows that the two consecutive output differences have the same sign. Thus all consecutive differences have one common sign. That sign is positive because $f(v) - f(u) > 0$ is a sum of some of those differences. It follows that $f(x) < f(y)$. The case $f(u) > f(v)$ similarly gives strict decrease. The intermediate value theorem shows that $f(I)$ is an interval, and Theorem 1.22 gives continuity of the inverse. $\square$

1.6.3 Further reading: proofs from completeness

The main theorems are useful before one has mastered every detail of their proofs. The complete arguments below explain their common foundations and are intended for deeper study. They use the monotone sequence theorem, the Bolzano–Weierstrass theorem, and sequential continuity; no later calculus results are needed.

Lemma 1.3 (Nested intervals)

Let $I_n = [a_n, b_n]$, $n \geq 0$, be nonempty closed intervals with

$$I_{n+1} \subseteq I_n, \quad b_n - a_n \rightarrow 0.$$

Then there is exactly one point c belonging to every I_n , and both endpoint sequences converge to c . 

Idea. The left endpoints move right, and the right endpoints move left. They remain bounded by the first interval, so monotone convergence gives limits; shrinking lengths force those limits to agree.

Proof The sequence (a_n) is nondecreasing and bounded above by b_0 , while (b_n) is nonincreasing and bounded below by a_0 . By Theorem 1.9, they converge to limits α and β . Since $b_n - a_n \rightarrow 0$, the sequence limit laws give $\beta = \alpha$; write the common value as c . For each fixed n , nesting gives $a_n \leq a_k \leq b_k \leq b_n$ for all $k \geq n$. Passing to the limit yields $a_n \leq c \leq b_n$, so $c \in I_n$ for every n . If d also belongs to every I_n , then $|c - d| \leq b_n - a_n$ for every n , hence $c = d$. $\square$

Proof Strategy for the intermediate value theorem. It is enough to prove the zero theorem. Bisect a sign-changing interval and retain a sign-changing half. The nested intervals locate one common point, and continuity prevents that point's value from being strictly positive or strictly negative.

Proof of Theorem 1.24. First suppose $f(a) < 0 < f(b)$. Set $a_0 = a$ and $b_0 = b$. At stage n , let $m_n = (a_n + b_n)/2$. If $f(m_n) = 0$, a zero has been found. Otherwise retain $[m_n, b_n]$ when $f(m_n) < 0$, and retain $[a_n, m_n]$ when $f(m_n) > 0$. Unless the process has already found a zero, this constructs nested intervals satisfying

$$f(a_n) < 0 < f(b_n), \quad b_n - a_n = \frac{b - a}{2^n}.$$

By Lemma 1.3, both endpoint sequences tend to a common $c \in [a, b]$. By Theorem 1.23, $f(a_n) \rightarrow f(c)$ and $f(b_n) \rightarrow f(c)$. Preservation of nonstrict order in sequence limits gives $f(c) \leq 0$ and $f(c) \geq 0$. Thus $f(c) = 0$, and the strict signs at the original endpoints imply $c \in (a, b)$. If the endpoint signs are reversed, apply the argument to $-f$.

For a level y strictly between $f(a)$ and $f(b)$, apply the established zero result to the continuous function $f - y$. If y equals an endpoint value, that endpoint supplies a preimage. This proves the full theorem. $\square$

The proof also gives an explicit approximation guarantee. After n bisections, the retained interval has

length $(b - a)/2^n$ and contains a zero c . Its midpoint m_n therefore satisfies

$$|m_n - c| \leq \frac{b - a}{2^{n+1}}.$$

This bound concerns the input error, not necessarily the output error $|f(m_n)|$. If a midpoint is already a zero, the procedure may stop early. The intervals in **Figure 1.9** illustrate the nested structure.

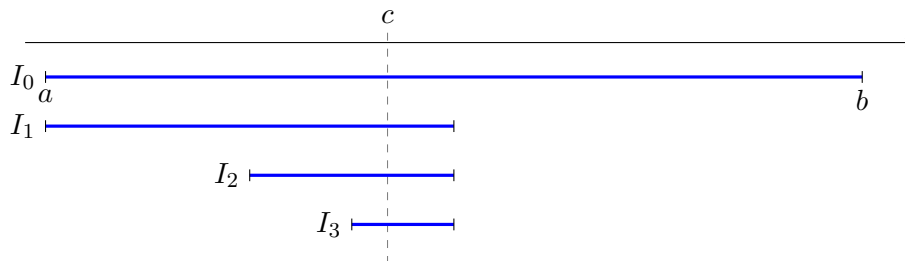


Figure 1.9: Successive sign-changing halves shrink to one point. The particular retained half depends on the sign at its midpoint.

Proof Strategy for boundedness. Failure of a global bound would let us choose points where the outputs exceed $1, 2, 3, \dots$ in magnitude. The inputs lie in a bounded interval, so a subsequence converges; closedness keeps its limit in the domain, where continuity contradicts the diverging outputs.

Proof of Theorem 1.25. Suppose f is not bounded on $[a, b]$. For each integer $n \geq 1$, choose $x_n \in [a, b]$ with $|f(x_n)| > n$. The sequence (x_n) is bounded, so Theorem 1.11 gives a subsequence $x_{n_k} \rightarrow c$. Because $a \leq x_{n_k} \leq b$, preservation of order gives $a \leq c \leq b$. Continuity at c implies $f(x_{n_k}) \rightarrow f(c)$, so this output subsequence is bounded by Theorem 1.4. But $|f(x_{n_k})| > n_k \geq k$, contradicting boundedness. $\square$

Notice the three different roles in this proof. Boundedness of the interval supplies a convergent subsequence. Closedness keeps its limit in the domain. Continuity carries convergence from the inputs to the outputs. Dropping any one of these features may break the argument.

Proof Strategy for attainment of extrema. Boundedness supplies a finite supremum M of the range. Approximate M by actual values $f(x_n)$, then extract a convergent input subsequence. Continuity turns approximation of the bound into exact attainment at the limiting input.

Proof of Theorem 1.26. The nonempty range $f([a, b])$ is bounded by Theorem 1.25. Let $M = \sup f([a, b])$. By Proposition 1.2, for every $n \geq 1$ there is $x_n \in [a, b]$ such that

$$M - \frac{1}{n} < f(x_n) \leq M.$$

Thus $f(x_n) \rightarrow M$ by the squeeze theorem for sequences. By Bolzano–Weierstrass, some subsequence x_{n_k} converges to $x_M \in [a, b]$. Continuity and the subsequence limit property give

$$f(x_M) = \lim_{k \rightarrow \infty} f(x_{n_k}) = M.$$

Hence the supremum is attained. Apply the same argument to the continuous function $-f$ to obtain a point x_m at which f attains its minimum. $\square$

The sequence (x_n) chosen in this proof is a *maximizing sequence* (极大化序列): its function values approach the supremum. The sequence itself need not converge, nor need it be monotone. Only a convergent subsequence is required. This proof pattern will recur in optimization problems beyond calculus.

1.6.4 Why the hypotheses matter

The examples below isolate different failures. On $(0, 1)$, the continuous function $1/x$ is unbounded, and the continuous function x is bounded but attains neither extreme bound. On the closed unbounded interval $[0, +\infty)$, the continuous function x is unbounded, while $1/(1+x)$ is bounded but does not attain its infimum 0. Thus neither closedness alone nor boundedness of the domain alone gives the closed-interval conclusions.

Continuity is also essential. Define $f(0) = 0$ and $f(x) = 1/x$ for $0 < x \leq 1$. This real-valued function has the closed bounded domain $[0, 1]$ but is unbounded because it is discontinuous at 0. For a bounded example, define

$$g(x) = \begin{cases} x, & 0 \leq x < 1, \\ 0, & x = 1. \end{cases}$$

Its supremum is 1, but no value equals 1; continuity fails at the endpoint. For failure of intermediate values, the step function equal to 0 on $[-1, 0)$ and 1 on $[0, 1]$ omits $1/2$ despite having endpoint values on either side of it.

Finally, the interval hypothesis is essential for the intermediate value conclusion. The function $f(x) = x$ is continuous on $[-2, -1] \cup [1, 2]$, but it has no zero there. The domain has a gap through which an intermediate input would have to pass. Closed bounded domains retain subsequence properties relevant to extrema; they need not retain the interval property relevant to intermediate values.

1.6.5 Uniform continuity

For continuity at one point, the radius δ may depend on that point. The square function illustrates why this dependence can matter:

$$|x^2 - y^2| = |x - y| |x + y|.$$

On a bounded interval, the second factor admits one common bound. On all of $\mathbb{R}$, inputs of very large magnitude may amplify a small input difference.

Definition 1.29

A function $f: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is uniformly continuous (一致连续) on D if for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there exists $\delta > 0$ such that, for all $x, y \in D$,

$$|x - y| < \delta \implies |f(x) - f(y)| < \varepsilon.$$



The same δ must work for every pair of points in the domain. The distinction is a change in quantifier order:

$$\text{continuity on } D : \quad \forall a \in D \, \forall \varepsilon > 0 \, \exists \delta > 0 \, \forall x \in D,$$

$$|x - a| < \delta \implies |f(x) - f(a)| < \varepsilon;$$

$$\text{uniform continuity on } D : \quad \forall \varepsilon > 0 \, \exists \delta > 0 \, \forall x, y \in D,$$

$$|x - y| < \delta \implies |f(x) - f(y)| < \varepsilon.$$

Uniform continuity implies continuity by fixing one point of the pair. Every Lipschitz function is uniformly continuous, since $\delta = \varepsilon/K$ is independent of the base point when $K > 0$. If $K = 0$, any positive δ works.

Example 1.48 Different domains, different control Determine the uniform continuity of x^2 on bounded intervals and on $\mathbb{R}$, of $1/x$ on $(0, 1)$, and of $\sqrt{x}$ on $[0, +\infty)$.

Solution On $[-R, R]$ with $R > 0$, the estimate $|x^2 - y^2| \leq 2R|x - y|$ gives uniform continuity of the square

function. On $\mathbb{R}$, take $x_n = n$ and $y_n = n + 1/n$. Then

$$|x_n - y_n| = \frac{1}{n} \rightarrow 0, \quad |x_n^2 - y_n^2| = 2 + \frac{1}{n^2} > 2.$$

If one radius δ worked for $\varepsilon = 1$, these pairs would violate it for all sufficiently large n . Thus x^2 is not uniformly continuous on $\mathbb{R}$.

For $1/x$ on $(0, 1)$, use $x_n = 1/(n+1)$ and $y_n = 1/(n+2)$ for $n \geq 1$. The input differences tend to 0, but $|1/x_n - 1/y_n| = 1$. The choice $\varepsilon = 1/2$ rules out uniform continuity. For the square root, (1.8) gives the single choice $\delta = \varepsilon^2$ for every pair of nonnegative inputs. Hence $\sqrt{x}$ is uniformly continuous on the unbounded interval $[0, +\infty)$, even though it is unbounded and is not Lipschitz near 0.

Proposition 1.18

A function $f: D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is uniformly continuous on D if and only if for every pair of sequences $(x_n), (y_n)$ in D with $|x_n - y_n| \rightarrow 0$, one has

$$|f(x_n) - f(y_n)| \rightarrow 0.$$

The input sequences need not converge individually.

Proof If f is uniformly continuous, choose δ for a prescribed $\varepsilon > 0$. Eventually $|x_n - y_n| < \delta$, so the output difference is less than ε . Conversely, failure of uniform continuity means that there is $\varepsilon_0 > 0$ such that for every $\delta > 0$ some pair $x, y \in D$ satisfies

$$|x - y| < \delta, \quad |f(x) - f(y)| \geq \varepsilon_0.$$

Choose such a pair (x_n, y_n) for $\delta = 1/n$. These sequences contradict the assumed sequential property. $\square$

Theorem 1.27 (Heine–Cantor theorem)

Every continuous function on a closed bounded interval $[a, b]$ is uniformly continuous there.

Proof Strategy. If no common radius worked, there would be arbitrarily close input pairs whose outputs stay a fixed positive distance apart. Extract a convergent subsequence of the first inputs; closeness makes the paired second inputs converge to the same point. Continuity at that point contradicts the output separation.

Proof Suppose the conclusion fails. By the negation in Proposition 1.18, there exist $\varepsilon_0 > 0$ and $x_n, y_n \in [a, b]$ such that

$$|x_n - y_n| < \frac{1}{n}, \quad |f(x_n) - f(y_n)| \geq \varepsilon_0$$

for every $n \geq 1$. By Bolzano–Weierstrass, a subsequence x_{n_k} converges to some $c \in [a, b]$. The estimate

$$|y_{n_k} - c| \leq |y_{n_k} - x_{n_k}| + |x_{n_k} - c| < \frac{1}{n_k} + |x_{n_k} - c|$$

shows that $y_{n_k} \rightarrow c$ as well. Continuity gives $f(x_{n_k}) \rightarrow f(c)$ and $f(y_{n_k}) \rightarrow f(c)$, hence their difference tends to 0. This contradicts the lower bound ε_0 . $\square$

Heine–Cantor guarantees a common input radius without necessarily producing a convenient formula for it. When a direct estimate is available, it may give more quantitative information. For example, on $[a, b]$ with $0 < a < b$,

$$\left| \frac{1}{x} - \frac{1}{y} \right| = \frac{|x - y|}{xy} \leq \frac{1}{a^2} |x - y|,$$

so $\delta = a^2 \varepsilon$ suffices for the reciprocal function. This choice makes the distance from 0 explicit.

Connection with compactness. The boundedness, extreme-value, and uniform-continuity proofs use the fact that every sequence in $[a, b]$ has a subsequence converging to a point still in $[a, b]$. This is the sequential form of *compactness* (紧致性) in the real line. Later study of compact sets will organize these three arguments into one general framework. Intermediate values use a different feature: an interval contains every point between two of its points. The disconnected-domain example above explains why these two features should be kept distinct.

1.6.6 Methods, pitfalls, and the next stage of calculus

For an existence problem, first build a continuous auxiliary function whose zero expresses the desired conclusion. Choose an interval and verify the endpoint signs explicitly. For uniqueness, add an independent order argument; the intermediate value theorem alone does not provide it. For extrema, specify the full domain and check continuity at included endpoints before invoking the theorem. For uniform continuity, seek an estimate independent of the base point, or use Heine–Cantor after checking that the domain is a closed bounded interval.

The proofs introduce three reusable constructions: nested sign-changing intervals, a sequence chosen from failure of boundedness, and a maximizing sequence chosen from the supremum property. In each construction, the sequence is a tool for converting an assertion about all inputs into a limit argument at one point. The paired-sequence test serves the same purpose when disproving uniform continuity.

Chapter 1 has moved from the order and completeness of $\mathbb{R}$ to functions, sequences, limits, and continuity. The next step studies the limiting ratio of an output change to an input change. Later, uniform control on closed intervals will help compare sums formed from many small subintervals. The local estimates and global theorems developed here supply the foundations for both differentiation and integration.

Exercise 1.6

1. State the intermediate value theorem, the extreme value theorem, and the Heine–Cantor theorem with all hypotheses. For each theorem, identify whether its conclusion concerns existence of a value, attainment of a bound, or control of input errors. Outline the contradiction proof of Heine–Cantor, identifying the separate roles of boundedness, closedness, and continuity.
2. Prove that $x^3 + x - 1 = 0$ has exactly one real root and that this root lies in $(0, 1)$. Use order rather than derivatives for uniqueness.
3. Prove that $e^x = 3 - 2x$ has exactly one solution in $(0, 1)$. State separately the existence and uniqueness arguments.
4. Prove that $x^4 - 3x^2 + 1 = 0$ has at least four distinct real roots by finding four disjoint sign-changing intervals. You need not solve the equation explicitly.

Hint. The polynomial is even. Locate two disjoint sign changes on the positive half-line and then reflect the intervals across the origin.

5. Suppose f is continuous on $[a, b]$ and $f(a) = 2$, $f(b) = 5$. Which of the following must hold: f takes the value 3; f takes the value 0; f is strictly increasing; f has a maximum; $f([a, b]) = [2, 5]$? Prove the necessary conclusions and give counterexamples for the others.
6. Find the supremum, infimum, and any attained extrema of each function on the stated domain:

$$x \text{ on } (0, 1], \quad x^2 \text{ on } [-1, 2], \quad \frac{1}{1+x} \text{ on } [0, +\infty).$$

7. Let $f: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous and satisfy $f(x) \neq 0$ everywhere. Prove that $|f(x)| \geq m > 0$ throughout the interval for some m . Deduce boundedness of $1/f$.

8. If $f, g: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ are continuous and $f(x) < g(x)$ for every x , prove that there exists $\eta > 0$ such that $f(x) + \eta \leq g(x)$ for every x . Give a counterexample on $(0, 1)$.
9. Prove that a continuous function on an interval which never vanishes has the same sign throughout that interval. Identify where the interval hypothesis enters the proof.
10. Let $f: [0, 1] \rightarrow [0, 1]$ be continuous and decreasing, where decreasing may be read as nonincreasing. Prove that f has exactly one fixed point.
11. Apply bisection to $f(x) = x^2 - 2$ on $[1, 2]$ and write down the first three retained half-intervals. How many bisections ensure that the midpoint of the retained interval differs from its contained root by at most 10^{-3} ?
12. Explain why $f(x) = \sin x$ attains a minimum and maximum on $[0, 2\pi]$, and determine its range there. Could the extreme value theorem alone tell you the numerical values of those extrema?
13. Prove uniform continuity of $f(x) = 1/(1+x)$ on $[0, +\infty)$ by an explicit estimate. Explain why Heine–Cantor on one closed bounded interval does not directly give this conclusion on the whole domain.
14. Prove that $\sin(1/x)$ is not uniformly continuous on $(0, 1)$, even though it is bounded there. In contrast, prove uniform continuity of $\sin x$ on $\mathbb{R}$ by using a trigonometric identity to control the output difference.
15. Prove uniform continuity of $x^{1/3}$ on $\mathbb{R}$ and show that it is unbounded there. What does this example say about a possible implication from uniform continuity to boundedness on an arbitrary domain?

| **Hint.** For real u, v , use $u^2 + uv + v^2 \geq (u - v)^2/4$ to compare $|u^3 - v^3|$ with $|u - v|^3$.
16. Suppose f and g are uniformly continuous on the same domain D . Prove that $f + g$ is uniformly continuous. If both functions are bounded, prove that fg is uniformly continuous. Show that the boundedness assumption cannot simply be omitted from the product statement.
17. Let $f: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous, and let (x_n) be a sequence in $[a, b]$ satisfying $f(x_n) \rightarrow \max_{x \in [a, b]} f(x)$. Prove that some subsequence of (x_n) converges to a point where f attains its maximum. Must the whole sequence converge? Give an example.
18. Construct examples showing that each of the following is possible: a bounded continuous function on an open interval that has no maximum; an unbounded function on a closed bounded interval; a continuous function on a disconnected closed bounded domain that omits a value between two attained values. State which hypothesis is absent in each example.

Supplement Exercises

- S1. Let $f: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous and suppose $f(a) = f(b)$. For each positive integer n , prove that there exists $x \in [a, b - (b - a)/n]$ such that

$$f\left(x + \frac{b - a}{n}\right) = f(x).$$

| **Hint.** Consider the continuous difference function and the sum of its values at equally spaced inputs.

- S2. Let $f: [a, b] \rightarrow [a, b]$ satisfy $|f(x) - f(y)| \leq q|x - y|$ for some $0 \leq q < 1$. Prove that f has a unique fixed point c . If $x_{n+1} = f(x_n)$ with $x_0 \in [a, b]$, prove $|x_n - c| \leq q^n |x_0 - c|$ and deduce convergence. Treat $q = 0$ separately if needed.
- S3. Suppose $f: (a, b) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is uniformly continuous, where $a < b$ are finite. Prove that f has a unique continuous extension to $[a, b]$.

| **Hint.** First show that f sends Cauchy sequences to Cauchy sequences; then compare two sequences approaching the same endpoint.

- S4. Conversely, if $f: (a, b) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ extends continuously to $[a, b]$, prove that it is uniformly continuous on (a, b) . Use this criterion to decide uniform continuity of $\sin(1/x)$ and $x \sin(1/x)$ on $(0, 1)$.
- S5. Prove that every uniformly continuous function on a bounded interval is bounded, even when the interval is open.

| **Hint.** Divide the interval into finitely many pieces short enough for the output tolerance 1.

- S6. Suppose $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is continuous and has finite limits as $x \rightarrow +\infty$ and as $x \rightarrow -\infty$. Prove that f is uniformly continuous on $\mathbb{R}$.

Hint. Use tail control together with Heine–Cantor on a central closed interval, taking care of pairs near the boundaries of that interval.

- S7. Prove that a continuous periodic function $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is bounded and uniformly continuous on $\mathbb{R}$.

Hint. If $T > 0$ is a period, use boundedness on $[0, T]$ and uniform continuity on an interval slightly longer than one period.

- S8. Let $f: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous and suppose its maximum is attained at exactly one point c . Prove that every maximizing sequence converges to c . Contrast this with a continuous function whose maximum is attained at more than one point.

- S9. Let $f, g: [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous, with f strictly increasing and g strictly decreasing. Suppose $f(a) < g(a)$ and $f(b) > g(b)$. Prove that their graphs meet at exactly one point. Then give an example with both functions strictly increasing and the same endpoint inequalities for which there are at least three intersections.

- S10. Let $f: [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be continuous. Prove that for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is a continuous function P that is linear on each of finitely many subintervals and satisfies

$$|f(x) - P(x)| < \varepsilon \quad (0 \leq x \leq 1).$$

Hint. Use uniform continuity to choose a partition and let P join the function values at consecutive partition points by line segments.

Chapter 1 Problem-Solving Toolkit

This toolkit summarizes how to choose among the ideas developed in Chapter 1. It is not a list of automatic substitutions: domain, direction of approach, and theorem hypotheses must be settled before a calculation begins. A reliable solution usually has two layers—first identify the structure, then justify the chosen transformation or theorem.

A decision route

- Step 1. Fix the object and domain.** Is the input a sequence index or a real variable? For a function, record the actual domain and whether the approach is two-sided, one-sided, or at infinity.
- Step 2. Try the structurally simplest operation.** Use known finite-limit laws only when their hypotheses hold. If direct substitution produces an indeterminate form, regard that form as a signal to compare rates, not as an answer.
- Step 3. Expose the small or dominant quantity.** Factor, rationalize, normalize by the largest scale, match the argument of a standard limit, or take logarithms for a positive power.
- Step 4. Choose the proof mechanism.** Use a direct ε -argument for quantitative local control, squeeze for domination, monotonicity plus boundedness for recursive sequences, or a sequence criterion to detect incompatible approaches.
- Step 5. Check the logical hinge.** Verify nonzero denominators, eventual signs, transformed domains, punctures in compositions, and every hypothesis of a global continuity theorem.
- Step 6. State exactly what has been proved.** Separate existence from uniqueness, boundedness from attainment, convergence from a merely possible fixed point, and pointwise continuity from uniform continuity.

Sequence patterns

Signal	First move	What must be checked
Rational expression in n	Divide by the highest relevant power of n .	The normalized denominator has a nonzero limit; lower-order terms really vanish.
Difference of comparable roots	Factor a difference of powers; for square roots, multiply by the conjugate.	Root domains and signs, especially when extracting $\sqrt{x^2} = x $ on a tail.
Bounded oscillation times a shrinking factor	Take absolute values and squeeze by a positive majorant.	The oscillatory factor has one bound valid for every sufficiently late index.
Recursive sequence	Find an invariant interval, then prove monotonicity and boundedness.	Solve the fixed-point equation only after convergence has been established; discard roots outside the invariant interval.
Sum or average with a growing number of terms	Split it into a fixed head and a uniformly controlled tail.	A finite-sum limit law cannot be applied directly when the number of summands depends on n .
Several positive growth scales	Normalize by the largest plausible scale and use $\ln n \ll n^\alpha \ll a^n \ll n! \ll n^n$.	The restrictions $\alpha > 0$, $a > 1$, and any cancellation between leading terms.

Proof and disproof templates

- **Direct limit proof.** Work backward from the desired output error to discover a sufficient input restriction, then write the proof forward with the quantifiers in their prescribed order.
- **Negating convergence.** Fix one tolerance $\varepsilon_0 > 0$ and produce bad terms or inputs arbitrarily far out or arbitrarily close to the limiting point. The fixed tolerance is the essential feature.
- **Sequential disproof.** For a sequence, find two subsequences with different limits. For a function, find two admissible input sequences approaching the same point whose output sequences have incompatible limits.
- **Uniform-continuity disproof.** Choose pairs x_n, y_n whose input distance tends to 0 while the output distance remains at least one fixed positive number.
- **Closed-interval theorem.** Write the function, domain, continuity statement, and relevant endpoint or range data before naming the theorem. Then state only the conclusion supplied by that theorem.

Function-limit and continuity patterns

Signal	First move	What must be checked
Algebraic $0/0$ or cancellation	Factor, use an exact identity, or rationalize before applying limit laws.	Cancellation is valid on the punctured domain; a remaining denominator stays away from zero.
Standard small trigonometric, logarithmic, or exponential factors	Match each argument with its denominator and use a proved equivalent in products or quotients.	Equivalent infinitesimals cannot be substituted term by term inside a difference with leading cancellation.
Positive varying power $F(x)^{G(x)}$	Rewrite it as $\exp(G(x) \ln F(x))$.	The base is positive on the relevant domain and the single exponent $G \ln F$ has been evaluated.
Change of variables $t = \phi(x)$	Translate the limit into the variable t and write its exact new approach.	Side reversal, tail-to-zero direction, transformed domain, and the puncture condition for composition.
Competing infinite quantities	Establish eventual signs, normalize, compare, or transform the expression.	Forms such as $\infty - \infty$ and $0 \cdot \infty$ have no arithmetic meaning by themselves.
Suspected failure of a function limit	Compare one-sided limits or construct two admissible input sequences.	One bad sequence disproves a limit; finitely many successful sequences never prove the universal assertion.
Existence of a root or intersection	Build a continuous auxiliary difference and locate a sign change on an interval.	Continuity and the interval are explicit; uniqueness requires a separate order or injectivity argument.
Extrema or uniform control	Check the closed bounded interval hypotheses, then use the appropriate global theorem.	Attainment is stronger than boundedness; a direct estimate may yield sharper uniform information.

Stop signs. Pause before making any of the following conclusions.

- A fixed-point equation supplies possible limits of a recurrence, not convergence.
- The intermediate value theorem supplies existence, not uniqueness.
- Boundedness near a point does not supply a limit, and unboundedness does not supply a signed infinite limit.
- The value $f(a)$ does not affect a punctured limit, but it is essential for continuity at a .
- Equivalent infinitesimals are safe in the stated product and quotient setting, not across arbitrary addition or subtraction.
- A theorem name never replaces verification of its domain and hypotheses.

Before finishing a solution, check the domain once more, record every one-sided direction, identify the theorem or estimate that justifies the last passage to the limit, and make sure the conclusion answers exactly the question asked.

Chapter 2 Basic Concepts of Calculus

Limits describe nearby behaviour; derivatives measure its rate of change. We first turn secant slopes into derivatives, develop rules for combining them, and interpret the result as a local linear model. Higher derivatives then describe how that model changes with its base point. The later part of this chapter will connect instantaneous change with accumulation through integration.

2.1 Derivatives

知识点概要

- Interpret a derivative as an instantaneous rate and a tangent slope.
- Use the difference quotient, including one-sided and endpoint questions.
- Explain why differentiability implies continuity and why the converse fails.
- Compute derivatives from limits and distinguish a derivative from a symmetric quotient.

A limit tells us where values are heading. To measure how fast they change, we must compare a change in output with the change in input that produced it. This comparison connects motion, geometry, and the local behaviour of a function.

2.1.1 Rates and tangents

Example 2.1 From average to instantaneous velocity A particle has position $s(t) = t^2 + 2t$ metres at time $t \geq 0$ seconds. Find its average velocity from time 1 to time $1 + h$, where $h > 0$, and its instantaneous velocity at time 1.

Solution The displacement is $s(1 + h) - s(1) = 4h + h^2$ metres. The average velocity is therefore $4 + h$ metres per second. As $h \rightarrow 0^+$, these averages tend to 4 metres per second. The same limit results from earlier times, using $-1 < h < 0$. We call this common limit the instantaneous velocity at 1. The vanishing time interval is not set equal to zero: we first form a quotient for $h \neq 0$, and then take a limit.

For the graph $y = f(x)$, let $P = (a, f(a))$ and $Q = (a + h, f(a + h))$ with $h \neq 0$. The secant line (割线) through them has slope

$$\frac{f(a + h) - f(a)}{h}.$$

If these slopes approach a finite number m , the limiting line through P has equation $y - f(a) = m(x - a)$. It is the tangent line (切线) at P in the sense used here. A tangent need not meet a curve at only one point; its defining property is this limiting slope.

In **Figure 2.1**, the second point changes while the base point remains fixed. The formula $2 + h \rightarrow 2$, rather than the picture alone, verifies the limiting slope.

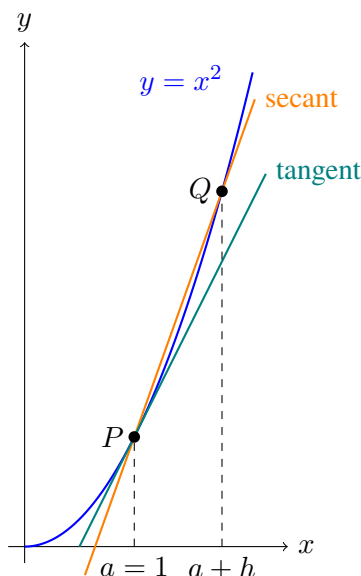


Figure 2.1: For $f(x) = x^2$ at $a = 1$, the secant slope is $2 + h$ and the tangent slope is 2. The displayed secant uses $h = 0.8$.

2.1.2 Derivatives and one-sided derivatives

Definition 2.1

Let f be defined on an open interval containing a . It is differentiable (可导) at a if the finite real limit

$$f'(a) = \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{f(a+h) - f(a)}{h} = \lim_{x \rightarrow a} \frac{f(x) - f(a)}{x - a} \quad (2.1)$$

exists. This number is the derivative (导数) of f at a . On an open interval where this holds at every point, $x \mapsto f'(x)$ is the derivative function (导函数).



The substitution $x = a + h$ explains the equality of the two limits. The quotient uses the actual value $f(a)$, unlike a punctured limit of $f(x)$. Changing that value can destroy differentiability. The number $f'(a)$ and the function f' are different objects. To find $f'(a)$, we fix a throughout the limiting process and vary h . Only after that limit has been taken may we let the base point range over an interval to obtain the function f' . In particular, $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f'(x)$ is a different question from the existence of $f'(a)$: it concerns slopes at nearby points, rather than secants anchored at a . For $y = f(x)$, the notations dy/dx and df/dx also denote the derivative function; at this stage they are derivative symbols, not fractions of finite increments.

A constant has derivative 0, since its difference quotient vanishes. For $f(x) = mx + b$, that quotient equals m for every nonzero increment. These examples explain why a derivative measures slope, rather than the height of the graph.

The limit in (2.1) has the following precise meaning: for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is $\delta > 0$ such that

$$0 < |h| < \delta \implies \left| \frac{f(a+h) - f(a)}{h} - f'(a) \right| < \varepsilon.$$

The same δ must work for all sufficiently small positive and negative increments, not just a chosen sequence. Multiplying by $|h|$ gives the equivalent estimate

$$|f(a+h) - f(a) - f'(a)h| < \varepsilon |h|.$$

Thus a convergent secant slope says more than a small change in height: the error in predicting that change by $f'(a)h$ becomes small even after comparison with the size of the input change. We will organize this observation

into the concept of a differential in Section 2.3.

Example 2.2 Changing one value changes the derivative question Let $F(x) = x^2$ for $x \neq 0$ and $F(0) = 1$. Determine whether $F'(0)$ exists, and compare this with the derivatives at nonzero points.

Solution At a nonzero point a , a sufficiently small neighbourhood avoids 0, so the local formula is simply x^2 . Its difference quotient is $2a + h$, hence $F'(a) = 2a$. At 0, however, the definition uses the assigned value $F(0) = 1$:

$$\frac{F(h) - F(0)}{h} = \frac{h^2 - 1}{h} = h - \frac{1}{h}.$$

This tends to $-\infty$ from the right and $+\infty$ from the left, so no finite derivative exists. The nearby derivatives tend to zero:

$$\lim_{x \rightarrow 0, x \neq 0} F'(x) = 0.$$

This limit cannot supply the missing derivative at 0. The secants through $(0, 1)$ are different from the secants through $(0, 0)$.

Definition 2.2

If f is defined on $[a, a + \delta)$ for some $\delta > 0$, its right derivative (右导数) is the finite limit

$$f'_+(a) = \lim_{h \rightarrow 0^+} \frac{f(a+h) - f(a)}{h},$$

when it exists. The left derivative (左导数) $f'_-(a)$ is defined with $h \rightarrow 0^-$ on a left neighbourhood that includes a .



At an interior point, the two-sided limit criterion gives

$$f'(a) \text{ exists} \iff f'_-(a), f'_+(a) \text{ exist and are equal.}$$

At a boundary point of a closed interval we explicitly use the available one-sided derivative. We do not infer a derivative on an absent side. For example, the right derivative of x at 0 on $[0, +\infty)$ is 1.

Example 2.3 A root and its endpoint Use the definition to differentiate $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$ at $a > 0$. Does it have a finite right derivative at 0?

Idea. The numerator is a difference of roots. Multiplying by the conjugate turns it into the input increment, which can then cancel before taking the limit.

Solution For $0 < |h| < a$,

$$\frac{\sqrt{a+h} - \sqrt{a}}{h} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{a+h} + \sqrt{a}} \rightarrow \frac{1}{2\sqrt{a}}.$$

Continuity of the square root was established in Section 1.5. At 0, the right quotient is $1/\sqrt{h} \rightarrow +\infty$. Thus the finite right derivative does not exist. The unbounded slope is often described geometrically as a vertical tangent, but is not a real derivative.

Example 2.4 A corner and a vertical tangent Determine differentiability at 0 of $|x|$ and $x^{1/3}$.

Solution For $|x|$, the quotient $|h|/h$ equals -1 on the left and 1 on the right. Both one-sided derivatives exist, but they disagree. For the real cube root, $h^{1/3}/h = 1/|h|^{2/3} \rightarrow +\infty$ from either side. Neither function has a finite derivative at 0. The first failure is a disagreement of finite slopes; the second is their unbounded size.

The two graphs in **Figure 2.2** are continuous at the origin. Their difference quotients, rather than continuity alone, distinguish the two failures.

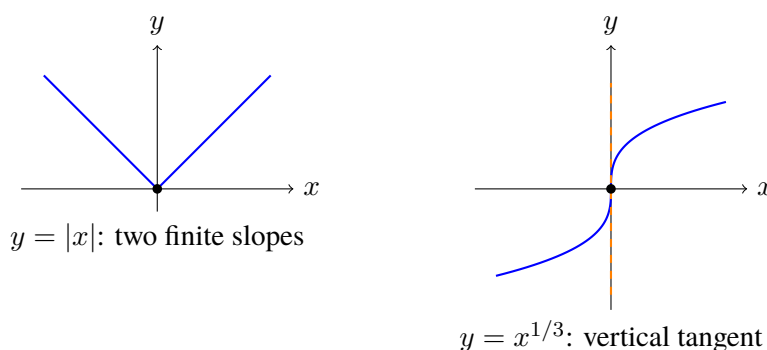


Figure 2.2: A corner and a vertical tangent fail the finite-derivative definition for different reasons. The cube-root curve is plotted parametrically as (t^3, t) .

2.1.3 Differentiability and continuity

Convergence of slopes should prevent a jump in height. The following result identifies the precise estimate behind this expectation.

Proposition 2.1

If f is differentiable at a , then for all sufficiently small h ,

$$f(a+h) - f(a) = h(f'(a) + \eta(h)), \quad \eta(h) \rightarrow 0.$$

In particular, f is continuous at a , and there are $C, \delta > 0$ such that $|f(a+h) - f(a)| \leq C|h|$ for $|h| < \delta$.



Proof Strategy. Continuity asks for a small output difference; differentiability controls that difference divided by h . Multiply the bounded quotient back by the small increment. The estimate is centred at a and does not compare every pair of nearby points.

Proof For $h \neq 0$, set $\eta(h) = [f(a+h) - f(a)]/h - f'(a)$ and set $\eta(0) = 0$. The definition gives $\eta(h) \rightarrow 0$ and the asserted identity, including $h = 0$. Choose δ so that $|\eta(h)| < 1$ for $|h| < \delta$. The triangle inequality then gives

$$|f(a+h) - f(a)| \leq |h| (|f'(a)| + |\eta(h)|) \leq (|f'(a)| + 1) |h|.$$

Take $C = |f'(a)| + 1 > 0$. Given a desired bound $\varepsilon > 0$ on the output change, it suffices to require $|h| < \min(\delta, \varepsilon/C)$. The output change is then less than ε , which is exactly continuity at a . $\square$

Continuity is necessary, but $|x|$ shows it is not sufficient. Nor does the proposition assert that f' is continuous: it assumes a derivative only at one point. The increment representation will also make the chain rule safe when an inner increment vanishes.

The two factors h and $\eta(h)$ play different roles. The first is the input increment; the second is the error in the secant slope. Both tend to zero, so the error $h\eta(h)$ in the predicted output is negligible compared with h itself. For example, h^2 has this property because $h^2/h = h \rightarrow 0$, whereas $|h|$ does not because $|h|/h$ has opposite signs on the two sides. In the notation of Definition 1.24, the proposition says

$$f(a+h) - f(a) = f'(a)h + o(h).$$

The symbol $o(h)$ represents a remainder with the stated limiting property; it is not a number that has been discarded or set equal to zero. If $f'(a) = 0$, the entire output change is $o(h)$, but it can still be nonzero for every $h \neq 0$.

Example 2.5 A tangent can cross its curve Find the tangent to $f(x) = x^3$ at 0, and decide whether the curve stays on one side of it near that point.

Solution The anchored quotient is $h^3/h = h^2 \rightarrow 0$, so $f'(0) = 0$ and the tangent is $y = 0$. For $h > 0$, the curve lies above this line, and for $h < 0$ it lies below it. Nevertheless, its vertical error from the tangent is h^3 , and $|h^3|/|h| = h^2 \rightarrow 0$. Crossing the tangent is fully compatible with the defining slope limit. Also, $f'(0) = 0$ does not say that the function is constant near 0.

Example 2.6 Matching values before slopes Find $A, B \in \mathbb{R}$ for which

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x^2, & x \leq 1, \\ Ax + B, & x > 1 \end{cases}$$

is differentiable at 1.

Strategy. Two pieces must first meet at the same height. Only after that condition holds can their slopes describe a tangent to the glued graph.

Solution Continuity requires $A + B = 1$. Indeed, the actual value and the left limit are both 1, whereas the right limit is $A + B$. For $h < 0$, the quotient is $[(1 + h)^2 - 1]/h = 2 + h \rightarrow 2$. For $h > 0$, it is $[A(1 + h) + B - 1]/h = (A + B - 1)/h + A$. If the constant numerator $A + B - 1$ is nonzero, this latter quotient cannot have a finite limit. Under continuity this is A , so equality of the one-sided derivatives requires $A = 2$ and $B = -1$. Conversely, these values give quotients tending to 2 on both sides and therefore suffice. Matching the derivatives of the separate formulas alone would miss the condition on B .

Example 2.7 Oscillation can survive continuity Set $f(0) = g(0) = 0$ and, for $x \neq 0$, let $f(x) = x^2 \sin(1/x)$ and $g(x) = x \sin(1/x)$. Check continuity and differentiability at 0.

Idea. Both oscillations have amplitudes tending to zero. For differentiability, divide the amplitude by $|x|$ and ask whether the remaining oscillation is still suppressed.

Solution The bounds $|f(x)| \leq x^2$ and $|g(x)| \leq |x|$ give continuity. The quotient for f has absolute value at most $|h|$, so $f'(0) = 0$. The quotient for g is $\sin(1/h)$. Along $h_n = (\pi/2 + 2\pi n)^{-1}$ it equals 1, and along $k_n = (3\pi/2 + 2\pi n)^{-1}$ it equals -1 . Both sequences tend to 0, so $g'(0)$ does not exist.

2.1.4 Computing from the definition

For a positive integer n , the binomial identity gives

$$\frac{(a + h)^n - a^n}{h} = na^{n-1} + \sum_{k=2}^n \binom{n}{k} a^{n-k} h^{k-1} \rightarrow na^{n-1}.$$

For $n = 1$ the sum is empty and the derivative is 1. For $n \geq 2$ the formula also holds at $a = 0$. The constant power $x^0 = 1$ is handled separately.

Example 2.8 Two ways to differentiate sine Prove that $(\sin x)' = \cos x$ for every $x \in \mathbb{R}$, with angles measured in radians.

Idea. The known limit compares $\sin h$ with h . Rewrite a sine difference so that its small argument is h or $h/2$, leaving the base point inside a continuous factor.

Solution Method 1: separate the increments. The addition formula gives

$$\frac{\sin(a + h) - \sin a}{h} = \sin a \frac{\cos h - 1}{h} + \cos a \frac{\sin h}{h}.$$

The second quotient tends to 1. For the first, $\cos h - 1 = -2\sin^2(h/2)$ and $|\sin(h/2)| \leq |h|/2$ imply $|(\cos h - 1)/h| \leq |h|/2 \rightarrow 0$. The limit is $\cos a$.

Solution Method 2: factor the difference. The identity $\sin(a + h) - \sin a = 2 \cos(a + h/2) \sin(h/2)$ gives

$$\frac{\sin(a + h) - \sin a}{h} = \cos(a + h/2) \frac{\sin(h/2)}{h/2} \rightarrow \cos a.$$

Continuity of cosine and the fundamental sine limit justify the two factors.

Both methods use only trigonometric identities and established limits. The first displays the two contributions to the increment; the second is shorter because the difference is already factored. The use of radians is essential for the sine limit to have value 1. Applying the cosine addition formula in the same way gives $(\cos x)' = -\sin x$.

The exponential limits already proved in (1.6) also give, for $b > 0$,

$$\frac{b^{a+h} - b^a}{h} = b^a \frac{b^h - 1}{h} \rightarrow b^a \ln b.$$

In particular $(e^x)' = e^x$, and the case $b = 1$ is constant. This argument does not use differentiation to establish the exponential limit.

2.1.5 Methods and further remarks

Start by identifying the base point, the available sides, and the actual function value. At a regular algebraic point, factor or rationalize the increment before taking a limit. At a joining point, first impose continuity, then compare the two difference quotients. For oscillation, estimate the quotient itself: small function values do not guarantee small slopes. When an increment has been written as $mh + r(h)$, test $r(h)/h$, not just $r(h)$. The former tests the predicted slope; the latter tests only a change in height. To disprove a quotient limit, two explicit sequences with different limiting values suffice.

Example 2.9 What a symmetric measurement misses If $f'(a)$ exists, compute $\lim_{h \rightarrow 0} [f(a + h) - f(a - h)]/(2h)$. Is the converse true?

Solution Split the quotient as

$$\frac{1}{2} \frac{f(a + h) - f(a)}{h} + \frac{1}{2} \frac{f(a - h) - f(a)}{-h}.$$

Each term tends to $f'(a)/2$. The limit is $f'(a)$. The converse fails for $f(x) = |x|$ at 0: the symmetric quotient is identically zero, but the ordinary derivative does not exist. Symmetric sampling can cancel a corner.

Looking Ahead. Using a fresh limit for every expression would be inefficient. The next section derives rules for combining differentiable functions. Later, the mean value theorem will relate derivatives throughout an interval to changes between its endpoints; a derivative at one point alone does not supply that global conclusion.

Exercise 2.1

1. Write the definition of $f'(a)$ in both increment and point forms. Explain which variable is fixed and why the limit must be finite.
2. For $f(x) = 1/x$, use the definition to find $f'(a)$ for $a \neq 0$, including the restriction on the increment.
3. Evaluate $\lim_{h \rightarrow 0} [(2 + h)^5 - 32]/h$ by recognizing a derivative.
4. Find the tangent line to $y = x^3$ at $x = -1$, using the derivative established from the binomial formula.
5. For $f(x) = |x - 2|$, find the two one-sided derivatives at 2 and explain their geometric meaning.
6. A position is $s(t) = 3t^2 - t$ metres for $t \geq 0$ seconds. Find the average velocity on $[1, 1 + h]$ and the instantaneous velocity at 1.

7. Use the definition to differentiate $\cos x$; identify exactly which two limits are needed.
8. If $f'(a) = m$, evaluate $\lim_{h \rightarrow 0} [f(a + 2h) - f(a - 3h)]/h$.
9. Prove from the definition that $f(x) = |x|^{3/2}$ is differentiable at 0, and find its derivative there.
10. On $[0, 1]$, determine the finite one-sided derivatives of $f(x) = \sqrt{x(1-x)}$ at both endpoints.
11. Suppose f is differentiable at a and $f(a) = 0$. Prove that $\lim_{x \rightarrow a} f(x)^2/(x-a) = 0$.
12. A function near 0 satisfies $f(0) = 3$ and $f(h) = 3 - 2h + h\eta(h)$, where $\eta(h) \rightarrow 0$. Prove that $f'(0) = -2$.
13. Explain why $f(h) = 3 - 2h + o(1)$ alone, with $f(0) = 3$, does not imply the conclusion in the preceding problem. Give a continuous counterexample.
14. Find all A, B making $f(x) = e^x$ for $x \leq 0$ and $f(x) = A \sin x + B$ for $x > 0$ differentiable at 0.
15. Set $f(0) = 0$ and $f(x) = x/(1 + e^{1/x})$ for $x \neq 0$. Prove continuity at 0 and determine the one-sided derivatives.
16. Prove or disprove: if $|f(a+h) - f(a)| \leq C|h|$ near 0, then $f'(a)$ exists. Also explain why the reverse implication is valid.

Supplement Exercises

- S1. For $\alpha > 0$, set $f_\alpha(0) = 0$ and $f_\alpha(x) = |x|^\alpha \sin(1/x)$ for $x \neq 0$. Determine exactly when $f'_\alpha(0)$ exists, with proofs at all threshold cases.
- S2. Let D be 1 on $\mathbb{Q}$ and 0 on $\mathbb{R} \setminus \mathbb{Q}$. Prove that $F(x) = x^2 D(x)$ is differentiable at 0 but discontinuous at every nonzero point.
- S3. Suppose f is differentiable at 0 and $f(0) = 0$. Prove that $|f(x)|$ is differentiable at 0 if and only if $f'(0) = 0$.
- S4. Suppose $f(0) = 0$ and $\lim_{h \rightarrow 0} [f(2h) - f(h)]/h = L$. Give a counterexample to $f'(0) = L$ without continuity. Then prove the implication if f is continuous at 0.

Optional Hint. For the second part, telescope $f(x) - f(x/2^n)$ and control each difference by the same estimate at $x/2^k$.
- S5. Let $f'(0) = m$. Prove that $[f(x_n) - f(y_n)]/(x_n - y_n) \rightarrow m$ when $x_n > 0 > y_n$ tend to 0. Is this still guaranteed for two positive sequences? Test $f(x) = x^2 \sin(1/x)$, $f(0) = 0$.
- S6. If f is differentiable at a , prove that $\lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \sup_{|t| \leq 1} |f(a+ht) - f(a) - f'(a)ht|/|h| = 0$. Explain why a supremum is appropriate when continuity away from a has not been assumed.
- S7. For $\beta > 0$, determine differentiability at 0 of $F_\beta(x) = \cos(|x|^\beta)$, including the threshold $\beta = 1/2$.
- S8. Construct two functions continuous at 0 and not differentiable there whose sum is differentiable there, and two such functions whose product is differentiable there. Verify every claim by difference quotients.
- S9. Define $f(x) = x$ for $x \leq 0$, and $f(x) = 1/n$ for $1/(n+1) < x \leq 1/n$, $n \geq 1$. Determine continuity and differentiability at 0 on the domain $(-\infty, 1]$, using bounds uniform on each step.
- S10. Let f be differentiable at 0, with $f(0) = 0$ and $f'(0) = m$. Prove that $\sum_{k=1}^n f(k/n^2) \rightarrow m/2$ without using integrals.

2.2 Differentiation Rules

知识点概要

- Derive the arithmetic rules and apply them with their domain restrictions.
- Differentiate inverse and elementary functions on their correct branches.
- Prove the chain rule without dividing by an increment that might be zero.
- Choose between direct calculation, simplification, and logarithmic differentiation.

A complicated formula is usually assembled from simpler functions. If we understand how differentiation interacts with that assembly, a few basic derivatives will generate many others. The rules in this section are consequences of the definition; their hypotheses remain part of every calculation.

2.2.1 Arithmetic rules

Theorem 2.1

Suppose f, g are differentiable at a and $c, d \in \mathbb{R}$. Then $cf + dg$ and fg are differentiable at a , with

$$(cf + dg)'(a) = cf'(a) + dg'(a), \quad (fg)'(a) = f'(a)g(a) + f(a)g'(a).$$

If also $g(a) \neq 0$, then f/g is defined near a , is differentiable at a , and

$$(f/g)'(a) = \frac{f'(a)g(a) - f(a)g'(a)}{g(a)^2}.$$



The product rule contains two contributions: change the first factor while holding the second fixed, and then change the second. There is no rule that the derivative of a product equals the product of the derivatives. To see the two contributions before taking a limit, write $\Delta f = f(a+h) - f(a)$ and $\Delta g = g(a+h) - g(a)$. Ordinary multiplication gives the exact identity

$$\Delta(fg) = g(a)\Delta f + f(a)\Delta g + \Delta f \Delta g.$$

The last term records the simultaneous change of both factors. By Proposition 2.1, $|\Delta f| \leq C_1|h|$ and $|\Delta g| \leq C_2|h|$ near 0. Consequently $|\Delta f \Delta g/h| \leq C_1C_2|h| \rightarrow 0$. This term is present in the exact increment, but makes no contribution to the limiting first-order rate.

Proof Strategy. Add and subtract $f(a)g(a+h)$ in the product difference. This creates two known difference quotients. For a reciprocal, put the two terms over a common denominator; continuity keeps that denominator nonzero.

Proof For $h \neq 0$, the quotient of $cf + dg$ is

$$c \frac{f(a+h) - f(a)}{h} + d \frac{g(a+h) - g(a)}{h}.$$

The two finite limits exist by hypothesis, and the limit laws give $cf'(a) + dg'(a)$. For the product,

$$\frac{f(a+h)g(a+h) - f(a)g(a)}{h} = \frac{f(a+h) - f(a)}{h} g(a+h) + f(a) \frac{g(a+h) - g(a)}{h}.$$

Since $g(a+h) \rightarrow g(a)$ by Proposition 2.1, the required limit follows. When $g(a) \neq 0$, continuity gives $|g(a+h)| > |g(a)|/2$ for all sufficiently small h . Then

$$\frac{1/g(a+h) - 1/g(a)}{h} = -\frac{[g(a+h) - g(a)]/h}{g(a+h)g(a)} \rightarrow -\frac{g'(a)}{g(a)^2}.$$

Apply the product rule to $f(1/g)$:

$$(f/g)'(a) = \frac{f'(a)}{g(a)} - \frac{f(a)g'(a)}{g(a)^2} = \frac{f'(a)g(a) - f(a)g'(a)}{g(a)^2}.$$

The same continuity estimate ensures that this quotient function is defined on a whole neighbourhood of a , as the definition of its derivative requires. $\square$

Example 2.10 Two changing factors Differentiate $F(x) = x^2 \sin x$ on $\mathbb{R}$.

Solution Both factors are differentiable everywhere by Section 2.1. Thus $F'(x) = 2x \sin x + x^2 \cos x$. The first term records the changing quadratic factor; the second records the changing sine factor. The incorrect expression $2x \cos x$ records neither contribution correctly.

Repeated multiplication now yields the usual polynomial rule. The reciprocal rule extends $(x^n)' = nx^{n-1}$ to negative integers, on $x \neq 0$. It also gives, wherever the denominators do not vanish,

$$(\tan x)' = \frac{1}{\cos^2 x}, \quad (\cot x)' = -\frac{1}{\sin^2 x}, \quad (\sec x)' = \sec x \tan x, \quad (\csc x)' = -\csc x \cot x.$$

For example, $(\tan x)' = (\cos^2 x + \sin^2 x)/\cos^2 x$. The other three follow by the same quotient or reciprocal rule.

2.2.2 The chain rule

For a composition $f(g(x))$, the input first changes g , and that change becomes the input of f . The two rates must therefore be evaluated at different points.

Theorem 2.2 (Chain Rule)

Suppose g is defined near a and differentiable at a . Suppose f is defined on an open interval containing $b = g(a)$ and differentiable at b . Then $f \circ g$ is defined near a , differentiable at a , and

$$(f \circ g)'(a) = f'(g(a))g'(a).$$



The outer derivative is evaluated at $g(a)$, not at a . For example, in $f(u) = \sin u$ and $g(x) = x^2$, the base input a first becomes the intermediate input a^2 . The outer slope is therefore $\cos(a^2)$, and the inner slope is $2a$. Their product $2a \cos(a^2)$ describes output change per unit change of the original input. The conclusion also holds when $g'(a) = 0$. The familiar cancellation suggested by $dy/dx = (dy/du)(du/dx)$ is useful for remembering the order, but does not prove the theorem.

Proof Strategy. Trying to factor the quotient by dividing by $g(a+h) - g(a)$ fails whenever that increment is zero. Instead, extend the outer difference quotient at its missing point by its limiting value. The extended function is continuous there, and its defining identity remains true even for a zero increment.

Proof Define

$$q(v) = \begin{cases} [f(b+v) - f(b)]/v, & v \neq 0, \\ f'(b), & v = 0. \end{cases}$$

Differentiability of f says exactly that q is continuous at 0. Only this continuity at 0 is needed; continuity of f' on an interval is not assumed. For every sufficiently small v , including $v = 0$, one has $f(b+v) - f(b) = vq(v)$. At $v = 0$ the identity is $0 = 0$, so defining $q(0)$ by the derivative introduces no additional restriction. Continuity of g ensures that its nearby values stay in the domain interval of f and that $v(h) = g(a+h) - g(a) \rightarrow 0$. For $h \neq 0$,

$$\frac{f(g(a+h)) - f(g(a))}{h} = q(v(h)) \frac{g(a+h) - g(a)}{h}.$$

The factors tend to $f'(b)$ and $g'(a)$. In particular, $q(v(h)) \rightarrow q(0)$ even if $v(h)$ is zero along infinitely many increments, because q has been defined and is continuous there. Both factors have finite limits, so their product has the asserted limit. No division by $v(h)$ was used. $\square$

Example 2.11 Zero inner increments are allowed Let $g(0) = 0$ and $g(x) = x^2 \sin^2(1/x)$ for $x \neq 0$. Find the derivative of $F(x) = e^{g(x)}$ at 0.

Solution Method 1: use the chain rule. Since $|g(h)/h| \leq |h|$, $g'(0) = 0$. The exponential is differentiable at $g(0) = 0$, so the chain rule gives $F'(0) = e^0 \cdot 0 = 0$. For $h = 1/(n\pi)$, $n \geq 1$, the inner increment is exactly zero. Thus a proof based on cancelling that increment would be invalid for this example, although the chain rule itself applies.

Solution Method 2: estimate the original quotient. The fundamental exponential limit gives $(e^v - 1)/v \rightarrow 1$ as $v \rightarrow 0$. Hence there is $\delta_0 > 0$ such that $|e^v - 1| \leq 2|v|$ whenever $|v| < \delta_0$; at $v = 0$ the inequality also holds. For sufficiently small $h \neq 0$, $0 \leq g(h) \leq h^2 < \delta_0$, and therefore

$$\left| \frac{F(h) - F(0)}{h} \right| \leq 2 \frac{|g(h)|}{|h|} \leq 2|h| \rightarrow 0.$$

Thus $F'(0) = 0$ directly, including increments for which $g(h) = 0$.

The chain rule gives the answer immediately after its hypotheses are checked. The direct estimate explains how the small inner change suppresses the entire output quotient and independently verifies the zero-increment case.

Example 2.12 A zero inner derivative does not replace the hypotheses With inner function $g(x) = x^2$, compare differentiability at 0 of $F(x) = |x^2|$ and $H(x) = \sqrt{x^2}$.

Idea. Both inner changes have size h^2 . Ask what each outer function does to that size before dividing the final output change by h . The outer absolute value preserves the size, whereas a square root enlarges it to $|h|$.

Solution Although $u \mapsto |u|$ is not differentiable at 0, $F(x) = x^2$ on $\mathbb{R}$. Its quotient at 0 is h , so $F'(0) = 0$. On the other hand, $H(x) = |x|$ has quotient $|h|/h$ and is not differentiable at 0. Here the outer square root is defined only for $u \geq 0$ and has no finite right derivative at 0, so it does not satisfy the outer hypotheses of the chain rule either. In both cases $g'(0) = 0$, but the two composites have different outcomes. If a hypothesis fails, the theorem supplies no conclusion; the composite must be examined from its own definition or a valid simplification. An undefined outer derivative cannot be multiplied by 0 as if it were a real number.

For an ordinary nested expression, work from the outside inward. For instance,

$$(\sin(e^{x^2}))' = \cos(e^{x^2}) e^{x^2} 2x.$$

Each derivative has been evaluated at the input of its own layer.

2.2.3 Inverse functions

If a graph is read in the opposite direction, its input and output exchange roles. We expect a nonzero slope to become its reciprocal. Existence of an inverse and its continuity must be supplied before using this expectation.

Theorem 2.3

Let f be continuous and strictly monotone on an open interval I . Let $a \in I$, $b = f(a)$, and suppose f is differentiable at a with $f'(a) \neq 0$. Then the inverse $g = f^{-1}$ is differentiable at b , and

$$g'(b) = \frac{1}{f'(a)} = \frac{1}{f'(g(b))}.$$



Idea. Write a nearby output as $y = f(x)$. The inverse quotient is the reciprocal of the original quotient. Continuity of the inverse is what ensures that $y \rightarrow b$ also means $x \rightarrow a$.

Proof The image $f(I)$ is an interval by the intermediate value theorem. Choose $a_- < a < a_+$ in I . For an increasing f , $f(a_-) < b < f(a_+)$, and every value between these endpoints is attained by continuity. For a decreasing f , the inequalities are reversed, with the same conclusion. In either case, b is an interior point of the inverse's domain $f(I)$. The inverse is continuous by the inverse-continuity theorem of Section 1.5. For $y \neq b$ sufficiently near b , put $x = g(y)$. Injectivity gives $x \neq a$, and continuity gives $x \rightarrow a$. The original quotient $[f(x) - f(a)]/(x - a)$ tends to the nonzero number $f'(a)$. For x sufficiently near a , its absolute value is at least $|f'(a)|/2$, so taking its reciprocal is justified. Therefore

$$\frac{g(y) - g(b)}{y - b} = \frac{x - a}{f(x) - f(a)} \rightarrow \frac{1}{f'(a)}.$$

The nonzero limiting denominator justifies the reciprocal limit. $\square$

The notation f^{-1} means an inverse function, not $1/f$. The nonzero derivative condition cannot be omitted: $f(x) = x^3$ is a continuous strictly increasing bijection of $\mathbb{R}$, but its inverse has no finite derivative at 0.

Example 2.13 An inverse without an explicit formula Let $f(x) = x + x^3$ on $\mathbb{R}$ and $g = f^{-1}$. Prove that the inverse exists and find $g'(2)$.

Solution For $v > u$,

$$f(v) - f(u) = (v - u)(1 + u^2 + uv + v^2) > 0,$$

since $u^2 + uv + v^2 = (u + v/2)^2 + 3v^2/4 \geq 0$. Also $f(x) \rightarrow \pm\infty$ as $x \rightarrow \pm\infty$; continuity and the intermediate value theorem give range $\mathbb{R}$. Since $f(1) = 2$ and $f'(1) = 1 + 3 = 4$, the inverse theorem gives $g'(2) = 1/4$. The number 2 is the input of g and the output of f . Thus we evaluate f' at $g(2) = 1$, rather than at 2. Solving the cubic for a general output would add work without providing information needed for this derivative at one point. This proof of monotonicity uses algebra, not the later derivative-sign theorem.

2.2.4 Elementary derivatives and their domains

The exponential derivative is already known. Applying the inverse theorem to e^x gives

$$(\ln x)' = \frac{1}{x} \quad (x > 0).$$

For $x < 0$, the chain rule applied to $\ln(-x)$ yields $(\ln|x|)' = 1/x$ as well. For a real α and $x > 0$, the definition $x^\alpha = e^{\alpha \ln x}$ gives

$$(x^\alpha)' = \alpha x^{\alpha-1}.$$

For $\alpha = 0$ this is the constant rule. For negative bases, arbitrary real powers are not defined by this formula. Integer powers retain their earlier domains, and real odd roots can be checked on each side using their inverse functions.

On the standard inverse-trigonometric branches,

$$\begin{aligned} (\arcsin x)' &= \frac{1}{\sqrt{1-x^2}}, & (\arccos x)' &= -\frac{1}{\sqrt{1-x^2}} & (-1 < x < 1), \\ (\arctan x)' &= \frac{1}{1+x^2} & & & (x \in \mathbb{R}). \end{aligned}$$

Indeed, if $u = \arcsin x \in (-\pi/2, \pi/2)$, then $\cos u > 0$ and $\cos u = \sqrt{1-x^2}$; the inverse theorem gives the first formula. For $u = \arccos x \in (0, \pi)$, $\sin u > 0$ and $(\cos u)' = -\sin u$, giving the second. For $u = \arctan x \in (-\pi/2, \pi/2)$, $\sec^2 u = 1 + \tan^2 u = 1 + x^2$, giving the third. Continuity and strict monotonicity

on these branches come from the elementary trigonometric functions and their inverses. The endpoint values of $\arcsin$ and $\arccos$ lie outside the derivative formulas. The inverse of $\cot$ restricted to $(0, \pi)$ is denoted by arccot . On this branch, $(\cot u)' = -\csc^2 u = -(1 + \cot^2 u)$, so $(\operatorname{arccot} x)' = -1/(1 + x^2)$ for every real x . For example, $\operatorname{arccot} 0 = \pi/2$ and its derivative there is -1 .

For convenience, the main families are collected below.

Function	Derivative	Domain of the displayed formula
b^x	$b^x \ln b$	$b > 0, x \in \mathbb{R}$
$\log_b x$	$1/(x \ln b)$	$b > 0, b \neq 1, x > 0$
x^α	$\alpha x^{\alpha-1}$	$x > 0, \alpha \in \mathbb{R}$
$\sin x, \cos x$	$\cos x, -\sin x$	$x \in \mathbb{R}$
$\tan x, \sec x$	$\sec^2 x, \sec x \tan x$	$\cos x \neq 0$
$\cot x, \csc x$	$-\csc^2 x, -\csc x \cot x$	$\sin x \neq 0$

The logarithm formula also follows from $\log_b x = \ln x / \ln b$. This table records conclusions with hypotheses; it is not a substitute for checking the domain of a composite expression.

Separating e^x into its odd and even parts produces a pair of functions that differentiate into each other. Their algebraic identity describes the hyperbola $v^2 - u^2 = 1$, just as sine and cosine describe a circle.

Example 2.14 Hyperbolic functions The hyperbolic sine and cosine (双曲正弦与双曲余弦) are $\sinh x = (e^x - e^{-x})/2$ and $\cosh x = (e^x + e^{-x})/2$. Find their derivatives and that of $\tanh x = \sinh x / \cosh x$.

Solution The chain and sum rules give $(\sinh x)' = \cosh x$ and $(\cosh x)' = \sinh x$. Direct expansion gives $\cosh^2 x - \sinh^2 x = 1$, and $\cosh x > 0$. The quotient rule therefore gives $(\tanh x)' = 1/\cosh^2 x$ on $\mathbb{R}$. Unlike the circular functions, differentiating cosine here does not introduce a minus sign. At 0, $\sinh 0 = 0$ and $\cosh 0 = 1$, so these derivatives also describe their simplest local behaviour.

2.2.5 Choosing a representation

Example 2.15 A variable base and exponent Differentiate $y = x^x$ for $x > 0$ in two ways.

Strategy. The ordinary power rule keeps the exponent fixed, and the exponential rule keeps the base fixed. Here neither is fixed. Taking a logarithm turns the two varying roles into the product $x \ln x$.

Solution Method 1: rewrite before differentiating. Since $x^x = e^{x \ln x}$, differentiability follows from already proved rules, and

$$y' = e^{x \ln x} (\ln x + 1) = x^x (\ln x + 1).$$

Solution Method 2: logarithmic differentiation. The positive differentiable function just identified satisfies $\ln y = x \ln x$. Differentiating gives $y'/y = \ln x + 1$, hence the same answer.

Logarithmic differentiation (对数求导法) means differentiating a logarithmic identity and then recovering y' . The first method also establishes differentiability without assuming it in advance. The second is often easier for long products, but positivity or the use of $\ln |y|$ must be justified.

Example 2.16 Logarithms can exclude legitimate points Find the derivative of $y = (x - 1)^2(x + 2)^3$ on all of $\mathbb{R}$, using direct and logarithmic differentiation.

Solution Method 1: product rule. On all of $\mathbb{R}$,

$$y' = 2(x - 1)(x + 2)^3 + 3(x - 1)^2(x + 2)^2 = (x - 1)(x + 2)^2(5x + 1).$$

Solution Method 2: logarithmic differentiation off the zeros. For $x \neq 1, -2$,

$$\ln |y| = 2 \ln |x - 1| + 3 \ln |x + 2|, \quad \frac{y'}{y} = \frac{2}{x - 1} + \frac{3}{x + 2}.$$

Multiplication by y yields the expression above on that domain. At 1, the definition gives $y(1 + h)/h = h(3 + h)^3 \rightarrow 0$. At -2 , it gives $y(-2 + h)/h = (h - 3)^2 h^2 \rightarrow 0$. Thus both excluded points have derivative 0.

The logarithmic route organizes factors efficiently; the direct route automatically includes their zeros. A cancellation in the final formula does not by itself prove differentiability at points excluded earlier.

Example 2.17 The branch matters Determine differentiability of

$$F(x) = \arcsin(2x\sqrt{1 - x^2}), \quad -1 \leq x \leq 1.$$

Find the derivative where it exists, and check both endpoints one-sidedly.

Idea. Write $x = \sin t$ on the principal interval. The inner expression becomes $\sin(2t)$, but $\arcsin(\sin(2t))$ returns a principal value, not always $2t$. The points where $2t$ leaves that interval determine the cases.

Solution Method 1: resolve the branches. With $t = \arcsin x \in [-\pi/2, \pi/2]$ and $c = 1/\sqrt{2}$,

$$F(x) = \begin{cases} -\pi - 2 \arcsin x, & -1 \leq x \leq -c, \\ 2 \arcsin x, & -c \leq x \leq c, \\ \pi - 2 \arcsin x, & c \leq x \leq 1. \end{cases}$$

The identities follow because each displayed angle lies in $[-\pi/2, \pi/2]$ and has sine $\sin(2t)$. More explicitly, if $-\pi/4 \leq t \leq \pi/4$, then $2t$ is already a principal angle. If $\pi/4 \leq t \leq \pi/2$, the angle $\pi - 2t$ lies in $[0, \pi/2]$ and has the same sine. If $-\pi/2 \leq t \leq -\pi/4$, the angle $-\pi - 2t$ lies in $[-\pi/2, 0]$ and also has the same sine. Since sine is injective on the principal interval, these are exactly the returned values. Thus $F' = 2/\sqrt{1 - x^2}$ for $|x| < c$, and $F' = -2/\sqrt{1 - x^2}$ for $c < |x| < 1$. At c the side slopes are $2\sqrt{2}$ and $-2\sqrt{2}$; at $-c$ they are $-2\sqrt{2}$ and $2\sqrt{2}$. The adjacent formulas agree in value at each joining point, and each branch extends differentiably across that point as an individual formula. Their derivatives therefore give the corresponding anchored one-sided quotients. Neither point is differentiable.

Solution Method 2: chain rule on the open pieces. For $-1 < x < 1$ with $|x| \neq c$, put $u = 2x\sqrt{1 - x^2}$. Then

$$u' = \frac{2(1 - 2x^2)}{\sqrt{1 - x^2}}, \quad \sqrt{1 - u^2} = |1 - 2x^2|.$$

The chain rule gives $F' = 2(1 - 2x^2)/[\sqrt{1 - x^2}|1 - 2x^2|]$, the same piecewise answer. At $\pm c$, the outer derivative is unavailable, so the branch calculation is still needed.

For completeness, at $x = 1$ write $x = \cos s$ with $s \rightarrow 0^+$. The branch formula gives $F(x) = 2s$ and $F(1) = 0$, so $[F(x) - F(1)]/(x - 1) = 2s/(\cos s - 1) \rightarrow -\infty$. Indeed, $\cos s - 1 = -2\sin^2(s/2)$, so this quotient equals $-s/\sin^2(s/2)$; since $\sin(s/2)/(s/2) \rightarrow 1$, its magnitude grows like $4/s$. At $x = -1$, write $x = -\cos s$; the quotient is $-2s/(1 - \cos s) \rightarrow -\infty$. Neither endpoint has a finite one-sided derivative. The chain-rule computation is compact inside each branch; the trigonometric representation detects the folds and settles the excluded points.

2.2.6 Methods and further remarks

Inspect the outermost operation before differentiating. Sums suggest linearity, products suggest the product rule, and nesting suggests the chain rule. A variable exponent suggests a logarithm or an exponential representation. For an inverse derivative, first find the corresponding original point.

Keep the original domain visible while simplifying. Check zeros before dividing by a function or taking its logarithm. For inverse trigonometric expressions, record the principal-value interval before cancelling an inverse with a function. The rules give sufficient hypotheses: a composition can be differentiable even when a factor function fails to be differentiable, as $|x^2| = x^2$ shows. Conversely, a zero inner derivative alone supplies no guarantee, as Example 2.12 shows. When a formal calculation produces a nonexistent derivative or a zero denominator, return to an actual function identity, an anchored quotient, or an explicit estimate.

Exercise 2.2

1. Differentiate $3x^5 - 2/x + \sqrt{x}$ on its real domain.
2. Differentiate $(x^2 + 1) \cos x$ and explain the two product-rule terms.
3. Differentiate $(2x + 1)/(x^2 - 1)$, specifying the excluded points.
4. Differentiate $e^{\sin(3x)}$, displaying its three layers.
5. Differentiate $\ln(1 + x^2)$ and $\ln|x^2 - 1|$ on their respective domains.
6. Differentiate $\arctan(2x)$ and $\arccos(x/2)$ wherever the finite derivatives exist.
7. Differentiate 5^{x^2} and $(1 + x)^{\sqrt{2}}$, using the positive-base convention for the latter. If the latter is extended to $x = -1$ by the value 0, determine its right derivative there.
8. Find the derivative of $x^{\sin x}$ for $x > 0$ and explain why neither the fixed-power nor fixed-base rule alone suffices.
9. Differentiate $F(x) = \sqrt{1 + \sqrt{1 + x}}$ for $x > -1$. Check the endpoint -1 directly.
10. Let g be the inverse of $f(x) = x^3 + x + 1$ on $\mathbb{R}$. Justify existence and compute $g'(1)$.
11. Compute $[\sin(\sin(\sin x))]'$ and indicate the evaluation point of every cosine factor.
12. Find the tangent line to $y = \ln x$ parallel to $y = 2x + 1$.
13. Derive the formula for $(\csc x)'$ directly from the reciprocal rule and state its domain.
14. Differentiate $(x + 1)^4/(x^2 + 1)$ by direct and logarithmic methods. Check the point omitted by the logarithm.
15. Decide whether f^2 differentiable at a implies f differentiable there. Give a counterexample and explain what changes if f is continuous near a and $f(a) \neq 0$.
16. Prove that if differentiable f is even on $\mathbb{R}$, then f' is odd; state and prove the corresponding assertion for odd f .
17. Determine every point where $F(x) = |x^2 - 4x|$ is differentiable and compute its derivative there.
18. For $H(x) = \sec x/(1 + \tan x)$, determine its original domain, simplify, and differentiate. Explain whether the simplified formula extends the original domain.

Supplement Exercises

- S1. Suppose f, g are defined near a , f is differentiable at a , and $f(a) \neq 0$. Prove that fg is differentiable at a if and only if g is. Give a counterexample when $f(a) = 0$.
- S2. Suppose f is differentiable at 0, $f(0) = 0$, $f'(0) \neq 0$, and g is continuous at 0, $g(0) = 0$. Prove that differentiability of $f \circ g$ at 0 forces differentiability of g at 0, without assuming that f is monotone near 0.

| **Optional Hint.** Write $f(v) = vq(v)$ with $q(v) \rightarrow f'(0) \neq 0$, including $v = 0$.
- S3. Let $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ satisfy $f(x + y) = f(x)f(y)$ and be differentiable at 0. Prove that $f'(x) = f'(0)f(x)$ for all x , including the possibility $f \equiv 0$.

- S4. Determine and compare derivatives of $\arctan x + \arctan(1/x)$ for $x \neq 0$. Find the value on each half-line by a trigonometric identity, without using the theorem that a zero derivative implies constancy.
- S5. Find $F'(x)$ for $F(x) = (\sin x)^x$ on every interval where $\sin x > 0$. Explain why replacing this domain by all nonzero x is invalid.
- S6. Suppose f is defined near 0 and has a finite right derivative $f'_+(0)$. Prove that $F(x) = f(|x|)$ is differentiable at 0 if and only if $f'_+(0) = 0$. Construct such an f that has no two-sided derivative at 0, and explain why its behaviour for negative inputs does not affect F .
- S7. Suppose f is differentiable at a , $f(a) = 0$, and $f'(a) \neq 0$. Prove that f has no other zero sufficiently near a . Explain why this does not assert monotonicity on a neighbourhood.
- S8. Prove the derivative formula for a product of n differentiable functions, and derive the logarithmic derivative formula when all factors are nonzero.
- S9. For $\alpha > 0$, let $F(x) = x^2$ for $x \leq 0$ and $F(x) = A \ln(1+x) + B + x^\alpha \sin(1/x)$ for $x > 0$. Determine all A, B, α for which F is differentiable at 0. Among those cases, determine exactly when F' is continuous at 0, checking both threshold exponents.
- S10. For a differentiable $f: \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, differentiate $F(x) = f(x)/(1+f(x)^2)$. Show algebraically that $|F'(x)| \leq 1/2$, and identify equality cases without using derivative tests for extrema.

2.3 Differentials and Linear Approximation

知识点概要

- ❑ Compare infinitesimals and control remainders on the scale required by a calculation.
- ❑ Characterize differentiability by a unique linear part of the increment.
- ❑ Distinguish a differential, an actual increment, and their error.
- ❑ Use linear approximation and check its accuracy by a justified estimate.
- ❑ Explain first-differential invariance under a change of variable.
- ❑ Differentiate implicit and parametric relations with existence and branch conditions stated.

The derivative gives a slope, but a slope can also predict an output. Near a known point, how well does the tangent line reproduce the function? This question leads from a quotient limit to a linear approximation, and gives a precise meaning to a differential.

2.3.1 Infinitesimals and comparison of errors

An approximation becomes useful only when we know what its error is small compared with. For a derivative, the relevant comparison is with the input increment, not with the value of the function. We first recall the language from Definition 1.23 and Definition 1.24, now using the approach $h \rightarrow 0$.

A function $\alpha(h)$ is an infinitesimal along this approach when $\alpha(h) \rightarrow 0$. For example, h , h^2 , and $\sin h$ are infinitesimals as $h \rightarrow 0$. The fixed number 10^{-6} is not one: however small it looks, its limit as $h \rightarrow 0$ is still 10^{-6} . An infinitesimal need not be positive, monotone, or nonzero; it is a varying quantity described by a limiting process. The identically zero function is allowed. The approach matters: $1/x$ is an infinitesimal as $x \rightarrow +\infty$, but not as $x \rightarrow 0$.

To compare two functions, first choose a reference scale $\beta(h)$ which is nonzero for all sufficiently small $h \neq 0$. Then the following statements have distinct meanings:

$$\begin{aligned}\alpha = o(\beta) &\iff \alpha(h)/\beta(h) \rightarrow 0, \\ \alpha \sim \beta &\iff \alpha(h)/\beta(h) \rightarrow 1.\end{aligned}$$

If both are infinitesimals, the first is a higher-order comparison and the second is equivalence. Our convention for *same order* is $\alpha/\beta \rightarrow c$ with $0 < |c| < \infty$. Thus $3h$ and h have the same order, but are not equivalent; $-h$ is also of the same order as h , with a different sign. The phrase “higher order” means smaller relative size, not a larger value. The order need not be an integer: for $h \rightarrow 0^+$, $h^{3/2}$ is smaller than h but larger than h^2 in this relative sense.

We will also use a bound that does not require a quotient limit. The notation $\alpha(h) = O(\beta(h))$ means that there are constants $C, \delta > 0$ such that

$$0 < |h| < \delta \implies |\alpha(h)| \leq C |\beta(h)|.$$

This is called big-O notation (大 O 记号); it asserts bounded relative size, not equivalence and not necessarily the same order in the convention above. The corresponding little-o condition can be written

$$\text{for every } \varepsilon > 0 \text{ there is } \delta > 0 : 0 < |h| < \delta \implies |\alpha(h)| \leq \varepsilon |\beta(h)|.$$

The distinction is between one fixed bound C and an arbitrarily small bound ε . Thus $o(\beta)$ implies $O(\beta)$, but not conversely. Here $o(1)$ means convergence to zero, while $O(1)$ means boundedness near the limiting point.

Example 2.18 All errors vanish, but on different scales As $h \rightarrow 0$, compare the five errors below with the input increment h . Which are $o(h)$, and which are only known to be $O(h)$?

Solution For a two-sided comparison it is convenient to use absolute values:

Error $r(h)$	$ r(h) / h $	Conclusion
h^2	$ h \rightarrow 0$	$o(h)$
$ h ^{3/2}$	$\sqrt{ h } \rightarrow 0$	$o(h)$
$ h $	1	$O(h)$, not $o(h)$
$h \sin(1/h)$	$ \sin(1/h) \leq 1$	$O(h)$, not $o(h)$
$\sqrt{ h }$	$1/\sqrt{ h } \rightarrow +\infty$	not $O(h)$

For the oscillating row, along $h_n = (\pi/2 + 2\pi n)^{-1}$ the relative magnitude is 1, so it does not tend to zero. Along $k_n = (n\pi)^{-1}$ it is 0, so a bound alone does not even supply a quotient limit. All five errors tend to zero, but only the first two disappear relative to the input scale.

Here $r(h) = o(h)$ and $r(h) = o(|h|)$ are equivalent statements, since both say $|r(h)| / |h| \rightarrow 0$. By contrast, $h \sim |h|$ is false for a two-sided approach, because equivalence retains signs.

Working with remainders. To use a symbol such as $o(h)$ safely, temporarily give its hidden remainder a name and write it as $h\eta(h)$ with $\eta(h) \rightarrow 0$. This turns a formal-looking calculation into an identity with ordinary functions whose limits can be checked.

For $h \neq 0$, $r = o(h)$ is equivalent to $r(h) = h\eta(h)$ with $\eta(h) = r(h)/h \rightarrow 0$. Set $r(0) = \eta(0) = 0$ if an identity at zero is needed. For example, if $r_i = h\eta_i$ and $\eta_i \rightarrow 0$, then

$$r_1 + r_2 = h(\eta_1 + \eta_2) = o(h), \quad cr_1 = h(c\eta_1) = o(h) \quad (c \in \mathbb{R}).$$

If $u = O(h)$ and $v = O(h)$, their bounds give $|uv| \leq C_1 C_2 h^2$, so $uv = O(h^2) = o(h)$. These statements concern a fixed finite number of terms; they do not justify an interchange with an infinite sum. Two occurrences of $o(h)$ can denote different remainders. Their difference is still $o(h)$, but cannot generally be set equal to zero.

An equivalent form of $\alpha \sim \beta$ is $\alpha = \beta + o(\beta)$, obtained by subtracting 1 from α/β . This form displays the information retained by the approximation. Products and quotients can often use equivalent factors, with the nonzero conditions in Proposition 1.15. In a sum or difference, however, leading terms may cancel; then the original error scale may be too coarse.

Example 2.19 Choose the precision before replacing terms Evaluate, using current limit tools,

$$\lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{\sin(2h) + \ln(1 + 3h)}{\sqrt{1+h} - 1}, \quad \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{\tan h - \sin h}{h^3}.$$

Strategy. In the first numerator the linear terms add to a nonzero multiple of h , so first-order remainders are sufficient. In the second numerator both terms have the same leading part h , which cancels. We need an identity exposing the remaining scale, rather than deleting those two equal-looking leading terms.

Solution *First limit, Method 1: retain a named error scale.* The fundamental limits give

$$\sin(2h) = 2h + o(h), \quad \ln(1 + 3h) = 3h + o(h), \quad \sqrt{1+h} - 1 = \frac{1}{2}h + o(h).$$

For sufficiently small h , both $1 + 3h$ and $1 + h$ are positive. Adding the first two expansions and dividing numerator and denominator by $h \neq 0$ gives

$$\frac{5 + o(1)}{1/2 + o(1)} \rightarrow 10.$$

The denominator tends to $1/2$, so it stays nonzero near the limiting point.

Solution First limit, Method 2: expose the basic quotients. Rationalizing the denominator gives

$$\frac{\sin(2h) + \ln(1+3h)}{\sqrt{1+h} - 1} = \left(2 \frac{\sin(2h)}{2h} + 3 \frac{\ln(1+3h)}{3h} \right) (\sqrt{1+h} + 1).$$

The parenthesis tends to $2 + 3 = 5$ and the last factor tends to 2, again giving 10. This route shows every quotient explicitly; the remainder route is more convenient for combining several known first-order models.

Solution Second limit: resolve the cancellation first. Near 0, $\cos h \neq 0$ and

$$\tan h - \sin h = \frac{\sin h(1 - \cos h)}{\cos h}.$$

Therefore

$$\frac{\tan h - \sin h}{h^3} = \frac{\sin h}{h} \frac{1 - \cos h}{h^2} \frac{1}{\cos h} \rightarrow 1 \cdot \frac{1}{2} \cdot 1 = \frac{1}{2}.$$

The middle limit follows from $1 - \cos h = 2 \sin^2(h/2)$ and the sine limit. The weaker statements $\tan h = h + o(h)$ and $\sin h = h + o(h)$ would give only a difference $o(h)$, which says nothing decisive after division by h^3 .

2.3.2 The linear part of an increment

The previous comparisons explain why an approximation criterion must specify a scale. We want to predict an output from its known value at a base point and one constant rate of change. Merely asking for an error that tends to zero does not determine that rate.

Example 2.20 Which line is selected by the error condition? For $f(x) = 3 + 2x + x^2$, compare the candidate lines $L_B(x) = 3 + Bx$, $B \in \mathbb{R}$, near $a = 0$. Which have error tending to zero, and which have error $o(h)$ at $x = h$?

Solution Every candidate passes through $(0, 3)$, and

$$f(h) - L_B(h) = (2 - B)h + h^2 \rightarrow 0$$

for every fixed B . Thus the unscaled error cannot select one line. For $h \neq 0$, however,

$$\frac{f(h) - L_B(h)}{h} = 2 - B + h \rightarrow 2 - B.$$

The error is $o(h)$ exactly when $B = 2$. The line L_2 matches the first-order change, while a different slope leaves an error of the same scale as the input. The choice is asymptotic at the fixed centre, not a claim of best approximation over an arbitrary interval.

This suggests the definition: separate the actual increment into a linear prediction and a remainder that is negligible compared with the input increment.

Definition 2.3

Let f be defined near a . We say that f admits a differential (可微) at a if there is $A \in \mathbb{R}$ such that

$$f(a+h) - f(a) = Ah + r(h), \quad r(h) = o(h) \quad (h \rightarrow 0).$$

The map $h \mapsto Ah$ is its differential (微分) at a , written $df_a(h)$.



The differential is a linear function of the input increment, with the base point held fixed. The remainder is negligible relative to that input increment. The coefficient A is allowed to be zero. At a fixed point, linearity means additivity and compatibility with multiplication by a real number:

$$df_a(h+k) = df_a(h) + df_a(k), \quad df_a(\lambda h) = \lambda df_a(h).$$

Indeed, these are just $A(h+k) = Ah + Ak$ and $A\lambda h = \lambda Ah$. The actual increment $f(a+h) - f(a)$ need not satisfy these identities. The map $h \mapsto Ah$ can be evaluated for any real h ; its role as a reliable approximation

concerns sufficiently small increments for which $a + h$ is in the domain. The remainder condition means that for every prescribed relative tolerance $\varepsilon > 0$, the error is at most $\varepsilon |h|$ for all sufficiently small h . The coefficient A is fixed before h varies; allowing a new A for each increment would merely reproduce secant slopes and would not define one linear model. In English, both this property and existence of the derivative are called differentiability; the theorem below proves their equivalence in one variable.

Theorem 2.4

A function has a derivative at a if and only if it admits a differential there. In that case the coefficient is unique and

$$df_a(h) = f'(a)h.$$

Consequently, the unique affine function through $(a, f(a))$ whose error is $o(x - a)$ is

$$L_a(x) = f(a) + f'(a)(x - a).$$



Proof Strategy. To identify a linear coefficient, divide the approximation error by the input increment. The remainder disappears and leaves the coefficient as a limit. Two different slopes would leave a nonzero constant in this normalized error, so uniqueness should follow from the same operation.

Proof Suppose first that $f'(a)$ exists. Define the actual error of its candidate linear model by

$$r(h) = f(a + h) - f(a) - f'(a)h, \quad r(0) = 0.$$

For $h \neq 0$, $r(h)/h$ is exactly the difference quotient minus $f'(a)$, so it tends to 0. This proves existence of the differential with $A = f'(a)$, including when that derivative is zero.

Conversely, suppose an increment representation $f(a + h) - f(a) = Ah + r(h)$ holds with $r(h) = o(h)$. Division by nonzero h gives

$$\frac{f(a + h) - f(a)}{h} = A + \frac{r(h)}{h} \rightarrow A.$$

This is precisely the derivative definition, so $f'(a) = A$.

To see uniqueness directly in the error language, suppose $Ah + r_A(h) = Bh + r_B(h)$ with both remainders $o(h)$. Then

$$|A - B| \leq \frac{|r_A(h)|}{|h|} + \frac{|r_B(h)|}{|h|}.$$

If $A \neq B$, take h small enough that each term on the right is less than $|A - B|/3$. The resulting inequality is impossible; hence $A = B$. An affine function through $(a, f(a))$ has the form $f(a) + B(x - a)$. Its error is $o(x - a)$ precisely when the same argument gives $B = f'(a)$. $\square$

The function L_a is called the linearization (线性化) at a , although it is generally affine rather than linear in x . Its change $L_a(a + h) - L_a(a) = f'(a)h$ is linear in h . In classical notation, take $dx = h$ and write $dy = f'(a)dx$. If the base point varies, the formula is written $dy = f'(x)dx$. This notation records two inputs: the point x and the proposed increment dx . For instance, with $f(x) = x^2$, $df_1(0.01) = 0.02$ but $df_3(0.01) = 0.06$. Changing the base point changes the linear map; changing the increment evaluates the same map at a new input. The independent variable has differential $dx = h$ because the identity function $x \mapsto x$ has derivative 1. We choose this differential to equal the actual input increment Δx . This does not force the dependent differential dy to equal Δy . Here dx is an ordinary real increment, not an additional kind of number; statements about infinitesimals refer to the process in which such increments tend to zero. For $dx \neq 0$, the ratio of these differentials equals $f'(x)$, but the ratio of actual finite increments need not do so.

Example 2.21 Exact change versus linear change For $f(x) = x^3$ at $a = 2$, calculate $\Delta f = f(2+h) - f(2)$, $df_2(h)$, and the error.

Solution Expansion gives

$$\Delta f = 12h + 6h^2 + h^3, \quad df_2(h) = 12h, \quad \Delta f - df_2(h) = 6h^2 + h^3.$$

For $h \neq 0$, the normalized error is

$$\frac{\Delta f - df_2(h)}{h} = 6h + h^2 \rightarrow 0.$$

The coefficient 12 stays fixed while h varies; neither the term $6h^2$ nor the term h^3 is part of the differential. For $h = 0.1$, the actual change is 1.261 and the differential is 1.2. The approximation error is 0.061, not zero. At $h = -0.1$, the actual change is -1.141 , the differential is -1.2 , and their difference is 0.059. Both directions use the same linear map $h \mapsto 12h$.

Example 2.22 A zero differential is a valid differential Compare $f(x) = x^2$ and $g(x) = |x|$ at 0 as candidates for a linear approximation.

Solution For f , the choice $A = 0$ leaves remainder $h^2 = o(h)$, so $df_0 = 0$. This zero map predicts no first-order change; the actual change is still $h^2 > 0$ for $h \neq 0$. Its absolute error tends to zero and its error relative to $|h|$ tends to zero, but its error relative to the actual nonzero change is $h^2/h^2 = 1$. Thus differentiability need not make the linear prediction relatively accurate as an estimate of the output change when the derivative vanishes. Dividing the error by this zero differential would make no sense; the definition divides by the input increment instead. For g , an identity $|h| = Ah + o(h)$ would force $A = 1$ from positive h and $A = -1$ from negative h . More explicitly, for $h > 0$ the normalized error is $1 - A$; for $h < 0$ it is $-1 - A$. Both would have to tend to zero with the same A . No single linear map works on both sides.

When $f'(a) \neq 0$, the situation is different:

$$\frac{f(a+h) - f(a)}{f'(a)h} = 1 + \frac{r(h)/h}{f'(a)} \rightarrow 1.$$

Then the differential is an equivalent infinitesimal to the actual change, which is nonzero for sufficiently small $h \neq 0$. At a zero derivative, the universally valid statement is instead $\Delta f = o(h)$; one must not write $\Delta f \sim 0$. Also, $o(h)$ need not be $O(h^2)$: the error $|h|^{3/2}$ is $o(h)$, but its ratio to h^2 is $1/\sqrt{|h|}$ and is unbounded. Differentiability controls a first-order scale without promising a quadratic error bound.

In **Figure 2.3**, both changes start from the same height $f(a)$. The differential ends on the tangent line, while the actual change ends on the curve. The vertical gap is the approximation error. For this parabola, $\Delta f = 2h + h^2$, $df = 2h$, and $r(h)/h = h \rightarrow 0$. The positive increment in the figure is chosen large enough to make the gap visible; the limit concerns both signs of shrinking h .

There is another useful geometric reading of the same estimate. Use a positive scale t and write $x = a + tz$, where $|z| \leq 1$ describes a fixed viewing window. After subtracting the base height and dividing both coordinate scales by t , the rescaled graph has height

$$\frac{f(a + tz) - f(a)}{t} = f'(a)z + \frac{r(tz)}{t}.$$

Given $\varepsilon > 0$, if t is sufficiently small then $|r(tz)| \leq \varepsilon |tz|$ throughout this window, including $z = 0$. Thus $|r(tz)|/t \leq \varepsilon |z| \leq \varepsilon$. The rescaled graph approaches the line of slope $f'(a)$ over the whole fixed window.

The formulas in **Figure 2.4** verify the picture exactly: the parabola's deviation from $2z$ is at most t , while $|tz|/t = |z|$ never becomes one line. Making a graph look small without keeping track of both scales would not establish differentiability.

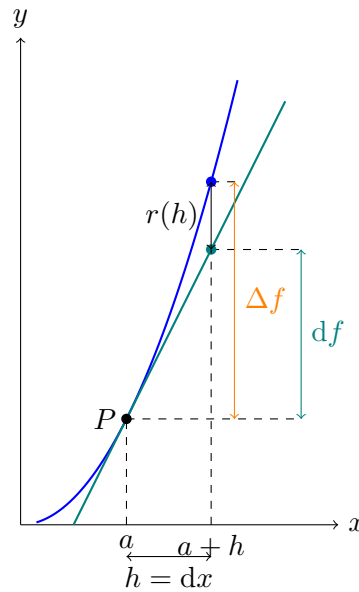


Figure 2.3: For $f(x) = x^2$ at $a = 1$, the same increment $h = 0.8$ gives actual change $2h + h^2$ and tangent change $2h$. Their difference is $r(h) = h^2$.

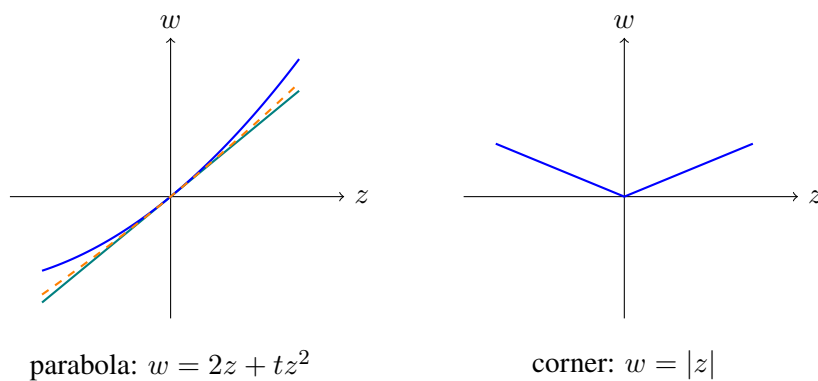


Figure 2.4: Rescaling both axes. Left: $f(x) = x^2$, $a = 1$, with $t = 0.6$ (blue), $t = 0.15$ (orange), and the limiting line $w = 2z$ (teal). Right: for $f(x) = |x|$ at 0, every positive scale gives the same corner.

2.3.3 Differential rules and change of variable

Multiplying the derivative rules by dx gives

$$\begin{aligned}d(u + v) &= du + dv, \\d(uv) &= u dv + v du, \\d(u/v) &= \frac{v du - u dv}{v^2} \quad (v \neq 0).\end{aligned}$$

Here u, v are differentiable functions of the same independent variable, and all values are taken at the same base point. These are identities between linear changes, not exact formulas for finite increments. For example, $\Delta(uv) = u\Delta v + v\Delta u + \Delta u\Delta v$ also contains a product of increments.

Proposition 2.2

Suppose $u = g(x)$ is differentiable at x and $y = f(u)$ is differentiable at $u = g(x)$. Then

$$dy = f'(u) du, \quad du = g'(x) dx.$$

Thus the first formula has the same form whether u is the independent variable or itself depends differentially on x .

Proof Method 1: use the derivative chain rule. The chain rule gives $dy = f'(g(x))g'(x)dx = f'(u)du$. The identity includes $g'(x) = 0$ and uses no division by du . $\square$

A second proof through the error terms. The two successive models have remainders measured against different inputs. To compose them, express the outer error in terms of the inner increment, then compare that increment with the original h . The inner increment is $O(h)$, which is exactly the bound needed to transfer the outer error to the original scale.

Proof Method 2: compose the linear models directly. Fix an original base point a , put $b = g(a)$, and write $B = g'(a)$ and $A = f'(b)$. For small h let $v = g(a + h) - g(a)$. By the differential characterizations,

$$v = Bh + h\eta(h), \quad f(b + v) - f(b) = Av + v\theta(v),$$

where $\eta(h) \rightarrow 0$ and $\theta(v) \rightarrow 0$. Set $\eta(0) = \theta(0) = 0$; both identities then include zero increments. The first identity implies $v \rightarrow 0$ and $v = O(h)$. Substitution into the second gives the exact identity

$$f(g(a + h)) - f(g(a)) = ABh + h(A\eta(h) + B\theta(v) + \eta(h)\theta(v)).$$

All three terms in parentheses tend to zero, including along increments for which $v = 0$. Thus the composite has differential $h \mapsto ABh$. This is $A du$ with $du = Bh$, which proves the claimed invariance. $\square$

The first proof is shorter once the chain rule is available. The second proves the same rule from remainders and explains why composing first-order models is legitimate; it uses the already proved derivative/differential equivalence, not the chain rule itself.

This is the invariance of the first differential (一阶微分的形式不变性). The intermediate differential means the linearized change $g'(x)dx$, not the exact change $g(x + dx) - g(x)$.

Example 2.23 An intermediate differential is not its exact increment Let $y = \sin u$ and $u = x^2$. For an input increment $h = dx$, compare Δu , du and dy at $x = 1$ and at $x = 0$. Verify dy both directly and through u .

Solution Method 1: retain both stages. At $x = 1$, the intermediate base value is $u = 1$, and

$$\Delta u = (1 + h)^2 - 1 = 2h + h^2, \quad du = 2h, \quad dy = \cos(1) du = 2 \cos(1)h.$$

The actual final change is $\Delta y = \sin(1 + 2h + h^2) - \sin 1$. The outer differentiability expansion yields

$$\Delta y - dy = \cos(1)h^2 + (2h + h^2)\theta(2h + h^2) = o(h),$$

because $\theta(v) \rightarrow 0$ and $(2h + h^2)/h$ stays bounded. The term $\cos(1)h^2$ explains what would be added if one replaced du by Δu in the differential formula.

At $x = 0$, $\Delta u = h^2$, but $du = 0$ and $dy = 0$. The actual change is $\sin(h^2)$, and $|\sin(h^2)|/|h| \leq |h| \rightarrow 0$. Thus the zero differential is correct, although the intermediate and final actual changes need not vanish.

Solution Method 2: use the composite directly. The derivative of $y = \sin(x^2)$ is $2x \cos(x^2)$, so $dy = 2x \cos(x^2)h$. Evaluation at $x = 1$ and $x = 0$ gives the same two answers. The direct route is short; the staged route distinguishes the two error sources and the roles of h , Δu and du .

The next section will explain why second differentials require more care under nonlinear substitution.

2.3.4 Approximation and error

The linear approximation (线性近似) $f(a + h) \approx f(a) + f'(a)h$ has error $o(h)$ as $h \rightarrow 0$. It does not by itself specify how small the error is at a particular nonzero h . A numerical guarantee needs a further estimate.

Example 2.24 A root approximation with a proved error bound Approximate $\sqrt{4.04}$ using the centre $a = 4$. Prove the sign and a numerical upper bound for the error without Taylor's theorem.

Strategy. The nearby perfect square gives an easy value and derivative. To certify the approximation, compare the proposed answer with the root by a conjugate identity; this exposes a squared small increment.

Solution Method 1: construct the linear model. For $f(x) = \sqrt{x}$, $f(4) = 2$ and $f'(4) = 1/4$. With $h = 0.04$, the linear model gives $L_4(4.04) = 2 + 0.04/4 = 2.01$. Differentiability justifies the asymptotic approximation, but not yet a numerical tolerance.

Solution Method 2: certify by exact algebra. For $h > -4$ let $s = \sqrt{4 + h}$. Since $s - 2 = h/(s + 2)$,

$$2 + \frac{h}{4} - s = \frac{h}{4} - \frac{h}{s + 2} = \frac{h(s - 2)}{4(s + 2)} = \frac{h^2}{4(s + 2)^2}.$$

The error is nonnegative. For $h = 0.04$ one has $s > 2$, so

$$0 < 2.01 - \sqrt{4.04} < \frac{0.04^2}{64} = 0.000025.$$

The differential selects the model and applies to many functions. The exact algebra supplies information specific to this root: the error's sign and a rigorous bound at the chosen increment. The general theory of quantitative remainder bounds will be developed later.

Relative changes require a nonzero reference value. If $f(a) \neq 0$, then

$$\frac{\Delta f}{f(a)} = \frac{f'(a)}{f(a)}h + o(h).$$

For $a > 0$ and $f(x) = x^\alpha$, this predicts a relative output change of approximately $\alpha h/a$. Here we divided by the fixed, nonzero reference value $f(a)$, not by the change Δf or the differential. If $f(a) = 0$, this relative change is undefined even though the absolute linear approximation can still be valid. The sign records the direction of change; an absolute error estimate discards it.

Example 2.25 Propagation of a radius change A sphere has radius $r = 10$ cm, which increases by 0.02 cm. Estimate the change in its volume $V = 4\pi r^3/3$ and its relative change. Compare with the exact polynomial calculation.

Solution Method 1: differentials. Here $dr = 0.02$ cm, so $dV = 4\pi r^2 dr = 8\pi$ cm³ and $dV/V = 3dr/r = 0.006 = 0.6\%$.

Solution Method 2: the exact relative increment. Write $\epsilon = \Delta r/r = 0.002$. Then

$$\frac{\Delta V}{V} = (1 + \epsilon)^3 - 1 = 3\epsilon + 3\epsilon^2 + \epsilon^3 = 0.006012008.$$

The linear estimate underestimates the relative change by 0.000012008. Multiplying by $V = 4000\pi/3$ gives the exact volume error.

The differential isolates the leading sensitivity, while the polynomial identity measures the neglected terms. If 0.02 cm were a bound on measurement error of unknown sign, the first-order magnitude estimate would still be 0.6%, but a guaranteed bound would also include the higher terms.

2.3.5 Implicit and parametric relations

An equation involving x and y may describe a curve without displaying y as a function of x . An implicit function (隐函数) on an interval is a function $y = y(x)$ satisfying that equation throughout the interval. The equation can have several branches or fail to define such a function. Differentiating the equation computes a derivative of a differentiable branch; it does not establish that the branch exists.

Example 2.26 Two routes to a circle's tangent Find the tangent line to $x^2 + y^2 = 4$ at $(1, \sqrt{3})$, and justify the branch used.

Solution Method 1: the explicit branch. Near $x = 1$, the upper branch is $y = \sqrt{4 - x^2}$. The radicand is positive, so the rules already proved show that it is differentiable. Its derivative is $-x/\sqrt{4 - x^2}$, giving slope $-1/\sqrt{3}$. The tangent is $y - \sqrt{3} = -(x - 1)/\sqrt{3}$.

Solution Method 2: differentiate the relation. For the differentiable branch just verified, the identity gives $2x + 2yy' = 0$. Since $y = \sqrt{3} \neq 0$ at the point, $y' = -x/y = -1/\sqrt{3}$. The same tangent can be written $x + \sqrt{3}y = 4$.

The explicit method supplies existence and the chosen sign. The implicit method avoids carrying the radical through the calculation. At $(2, 0)$ the division by y fails; that failure calls for a separate geometric or parametric analysis, not an infinite real value for y' .

A parametric curve (参数曲线) is described by two coordinate functions $x = X(t)$, $y = Y(t)$ of a parameter t . To view it locally as a graph over x , suppose X is continuous and strictly monotone near t_0 , differentiable there at t_0 , and $X'(t_0) \neq 0$. If Y is differentiable at t_0 , the inverse and chain rules give

$$\left. \frac{dy}{dx} \right|_{x=X(t_0)} = \frac{Y'(t_0)}{X'(t_0)}.$$

These assumptions provide a local inverse for X . A nonzero derivative at just one point, without a local invertibility hypothesis, is not being used as a substitute for them.

Example 2.27 A parameter is not the horizontal coordinate For $X(t) = t^2$, $Y(t) = t^3$, $t > 0$, find the slope and the tangent at $t = 2$ in two ways.

Solution Method 1: retain the parameter. The map X is strictly increasing for $t > 0$, and $X' = 2t \neq 0$. Hence $dy/dx = 3t^2/(2t) = 3t/2$. At $t = 2$ the point is $(4, 8)$ and the slope is 3, giving $y - 8 = 3(x - 4)$.

Solution Method 2: eliminate the parameter. The positive branch gives $t = \sqrt{x}$, so $y = x^{3/2}$ for $x > 0$. Differentiation yields $(3/2)\sqrt{x}$, the same slope.

Elimination is especially transparent here because the inverse is simple. The parameter formula remains useful when elimination would produce a complicated equation. At $t = 0$, the ratio would be 0/0; it cannot determine the endpoint slope without a separate limit.

2.3.6 Methods and further remarks

For an approximation, choose a centre where both the function value and the derivative are known, and record the actual increment from that centre. For an infinitesimal calculation, specify the approach and the nonzero reference scale before comparing terms. Use named remainders to combine approximations, and check whether the leading terms cancel before dividing by a smaller scale. Keep three quantities distinct: the actual change, the linear prediction, and their difference. To prove differentiability, estimate the remainder relative to the input increment. To guarantee a numerical tolerance, provide an explicit bound instead of relying on the symbol $\approx$.

For implicit and parametric calculations, first identify the branch and the independent variable. Check every denominator before using a derivative ratio. First-differential invariance follows from composition of linear changes; it does not assert that finite increments obey the same exact identities.

Looking Ahead. If a linear model is not accurate enough, a natural next question is how its slope changes. This leads to second and higher derivatives. Turning those derivatives into polynomial approximations with general error bounds will require the later Taylor theory.

Exercise 2.3

1. State precisely what $r(h) = o(h)$ means and check whether h^2 , $|h|$, and $|h|^{3/2}$ satisfy it.
2. Find dy for $y = \ln(1 + x^2)$, specifying the role of x and dx .
3. Find the linearization of $\sin x$ at $a = \pi/6$.
4. For $f(x) = x^2$ at $a = 3$ and $h = -0.1$, compute Δf , df , and the exact error.
5. Give first-order approximations near $h = 0$ for e^h , $\ln(1 + h)$, and $(1 + h)^\alpha$, $\alpha \in \mathbb{R}$.
6. Find the differential and linearization at $a = 0$ of $f(x) = 1/(1 + x)$.
7. Prove that $1/(1 + h) - (1 - h) = h^2/(1 + h)$ for $h > -1$. Use it to bound the error when $|h| \leq 0.1$.
8. Approximate $\sqrt[3]{27.03}$ by linearization at 27. State what accuracy information has and has not been established.
9. For $y = \ln u$, $u = 1 + x^2$, compute dy in two ways and check $x = 0$.
10. A square's side length changes from 5 cm to $5 + \delta$ cm, $|\delta| \leq 0.01$. Estimate the relative area change and give a rigorous bound for the difference from that estimate.
11. Find the tangent to the upper branch of $x^2 + 4y^2 = 8$ at $(2, 1)$ by explicit and implicit differentiation.
12. For $x = e^t$, $y = t^2$, find dy/dx and the tangent at $t = 0$; verify by eliminating t .
13. If $f'(a) \neq 0$, prove that $f(a+h) - f(a) \sim f'(a)h$. Explain why the hypothesis cannot simply be dropped.
14. Prove that the differential of f at a point, if it exists, is the unique linear map with remainder $o(h)$, without appealing to uniqueness of limits as a named theorem.
15. Suppose $f(h) = c + Ah + h\eta(h)$ with $\eta(h) \rightarrow 0$ and $f(0) = c$. Determine for which constants B the line $c + Bh$ has error $o(h)$; decide whether the error must be $O(h^2)$.
16. For $x = t^3$, $y = t^2$, $t \in \mathbb{R}$, determine whether y is a function of x and whether it has a finite derivative at $x = 0$. Explain why the parameter ratio cannot be used there.
17. Evaluate $\lim_{h \rightarrow 0} [\sin(3h) - 3 \sin h]/h^3$ using a trigonometric identity and the fundamental sine limit. Explain precisely why replacing both sine terms by their first-order equivalents cannot determine this limit.
18. Let f be differentiable at a . Prove that $df_a(h + k) = df_a(h) + df_a(k)$. Give a polynomial example

showing that the actual increments based at a need not satisfy this equality. For any fixed $s, t \in \mathbb{R}$, prove that

$$f(a + (s + t)h) - f(a + sh) - f(a + th) + f(a) = o(h) \quad (h \rightarrow 0),$$

including $s = 0, t = 0$ and $s + t = 0$.

Supplement Exercises

- S1.** Let $a \neq 0$ and let f be differentiable at a with $b = f(a) \neq 0$. Prove that the ratio of relative output change to relative input change tends to $K_f = af'(a)/b$. If f has a differentiable local inverse g at b and $f'(a) \neq 0$, prove that the corresponding factor $K_g = bg'(b)/a$ equals $1/K_f$. Check the factors for $f(x) = x^3$ at $a = 2$, and explain why the assumptions about zero values matter.
- S2.** Construct a function differentiable at 0 whose linearization error is not $O(|h|^{1+\epsilon})$ for any $\epsilon > 0$. State the bound being disproved and verify both differentiability and its failure for every exponent.
- Optional Hint.** On $0 < |x| < e^{-1}$, try $f(x) = x/\ln|x|$ and set $f(0) = 0$. To disprove each bound, test $h_n = e^{-n}$ and use a binomial lower bound for $(e^\epsilon)^n$.
- S3.** Suppose f is defined near a . Prove that there is a line $A + B(x - a)$ with error $o(x - a)$ as $x \rightarrow a, x \neq a$, if and only if assigning $f(a) = A$ makes the resulting function differentiable at a with derivative B . Explain the role of the original value at a .
- S4.** For $a > 0$ and $a + h > 0$, derive an exact formula for $\sqrt{a + h} - \sqrt{a} - h/(2\sqrt{a})$. Use it to prove a uniform error bound $C_a h^2$ when $|h| \leq a/2$, and specify C_a .
- S5.** Suppose $f(a + h) = f(a) + Ah + o(h)$ and $g(a + h) = g(a) + Bh + o(h)$. Prove the product rule using these expansions, including why the product of the increments is negligible relative to h .
- S6.** Let $f'(0) = 0, f(0) = 0$, and g be any bounded function near 0. Define $H(0) = 0$ and $H(x) = f(x)g(x)$ for $x \neq 0$. Prove that H admits a zero differential at 0, without assuming continuity of g .
- S7.** Suppose F has a differentiable local inverse G near $b = F(a)$, and $F'(a) \neq 0$. Starting from the chain rule, explain why a small output perturbation k gives $G(b + k) = a + k/F'(a) + o(k)$. Compare this with the forward model.
- S8.** The positive branch of $xy + y^2 = 2$ near $(1, 1)$ is explicitly $y = (-x + \sqrt{x^2 + 8})/2$. Compute the linearization at 1 both explicitly and implicitly. Verify that the branch is differentiable before using the equation.
- S9.** For $x = t^2, y = t^4, t \in \mathbb{R}$, show that the image is a single graph $y = x^2$ on $x \geq 0$, even though $t \mapsto x$ is not injective near 0. Determine its right derivative at 0 and explain the failure of the formal $0/0$ ratio.
- S10.** Suppose f is differentiable near $a, f(a) = 0, f'(a) \neq 0$, and f' is continuous at a . The tangent at a nearby point x meets the horizontal axis at $N(x) = x - f(x)/f'(x)$. Prove that this expression is defined for all sufficiently near x and that $[N(x) - a]/(x - a) \rightarrow 0$ as $x \rightarrow a, x \neq a$. Interpret this as an improvement from one tangent correction; no convergence claim about repeated corrections is requested.

2.4 Higher Derivatives and Higher Differentials

知识点概要

- Distinguish repeated derivatives from continuous derivatives.
- Compute implicit and parametric second derivatives.
- Prove derivative patterns and apply Leibniz's formula.
- Define higher differentials and track substitution terms.

The slope of a graph generally changes as the base point moves. For a moving particle, the derivative of position is velocity, and the derivative of velocity is acceleration. We therefore apply differentiation to the derivative function itself. This requires more than information about a single tangent.

2.4.1 Repeated differentiation and regularity

Definition 2.4

If f' is defined on a neighbourhood of a and is differentiable at a , the second derivative (二阶导数) is

$$f''(a) = (f')'(a) = \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{f'(a+h) - f'(a)}{h}.$$

Recursively, for $n \geq 2$, the n th derivative (高阶导数) is $f^{(n)} = (f^{(n-1)})'$ wherever this derivative is defined. We use $f^{(0)} = f$ and $f^{(1)} = f'$.



The notation $f^{(n)}$ means repeated differentiation, not the power f^n . At a point, existence of $f''(a)$ presupposes first derivatives at all nearby points; existence of $f'(a)$ alone does not. The numerator of its defining quotient is a change in *slope*, not a change in the original height. We again fix a and compare that change with the input increment h . By applying the first-order increment representation to the function f' , we obtain

$$f'(a+h) - f'(a) = f''(a)h + o(h).$$

This is a first-order model for the *derivative function*. It does not yet assert a second-order remainder formula for f ; that is a different statement requiring its own proof. The Leibniz notation is d^2y/dx^2 .

For $s(t) = t^3$, one obtains velocity $s'(t) = 3t^2$ and acceleration $s''(t) = 6t$. If position is measured in metres and time in seconds, their units are metres per second and metres per second squared. For an affine function the second derivative is zero, expressing its constant slope.

On an open interval I , the notation $C^k(I)$ means the functions whose derivatives through order k exist and are continuous. Here $C^0(I)$ means continuous functions, and $C^\infty(I)$ means that this holds for every nonnegative integer k . Existence of a highest derivative does not automatically include its continuity. If derivatives through order k exist throughout an open interval, every derivative of order less than k is continuous there, since it is itself differentiable. The additional requirement in C^k concerns continuity of the highest derivative as well. In particular, the implications $C^2 \implies C^1 \implies C^0$ follow from the definitions, while the converse implications need not hold.

Example 2.28 Two derivatives, but not three For $f(x) = |x|^3$, find f' and f'' , and decide whether $f'''(0)$ exists.

Solution For $x > 0$, $f = x^3$; for $x < 0$, $f = -x^3$. At 0, the quotient $|h|^3/h$ tends to zero. For $h > 0$ it equals h^2 , and for $h < 0$ it equals $-h^2$; both tend to zero. Thus $f'(x) = 3x|x|$ on $\mathbb{R}$. This single formula combines $3x^2$ on the positive half-line, $-3x^2$ on the negative half-line, and the separately computed value 0 at the origin.

At 0, $[f'(h) - f'(0)]/h = 3|h| \rightarrow 0$. Away from 0, differentiation gives $f''(x) = 6|x|$, and this formula also holds at 0. The quotient for $f'''(0)$ is $6|h|/h$, whose side limits are -6 and 6 . Therefore $f \in C^2(\mathbb{R})$ but $f'''(0)$ does not exist. Membership in C^2 also includes the continuity checks: f , $3x|x|$ and $6|x|$ are all continuous on $\mathbb{R}$. We have not obtained the value of a new derivative at 0 by substituting into a formula proved only for $x \neq 0$; each order at the joining point was computed by its own difference quotient.

Example 2.29 A derivative need not be continuous Revisit $f(0) = 0$, $f(x) = x^2 \sin(1/x)$ for $x \neq 0$. Compute f' and decide whether $f''(0)$ exists.

Solution Example 2.7 established $f'(0) = 0$ directly. For $x \neq 0$, the rules give $f'(x) = 2x \sin(1/x) - \cos(1/x)$. Along $x_n = 1/(2\pi n)$ its value is -1 , so f' is not continuous at 0. Since differentiability would imply continuity, f' cannot be differentiable at 0: $f''(0)$ does not exist. This separates differentiability on $\mathbb{R}$ from membership in $C^1(\mathbb{R})$.

2.4.2 Patterns and Leibniz's formula

Repeated computation is useful for discovering a pattern, but a few correct derivatives do not prove the formula for all orders. The following formulas are proved by differentiating the claimed expression once and checking the initial case:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{d^n}{dx^n} e^{ax} &= a^n e^{ax}, \\ \frac{d^n}{dx^n} \sin(ax + b) &= a^n \sin(ax + b + n\pi/2), \\ \frac{d^n}{dx^n} (x - c)^{-1} &= (-1)^n n! (x - c)^{-n-1}.\end{aligned}$$

The first two hold for $n \geq 1$ and all real parameters; if $a = 0$, the functions are constant. The last holds for $n \geq 0$ and $x \neq c$. For example, differentiating its order- n expression multiplies by $-n - 1$, yielding $(-1)^{n+1}(n+1)!(x-c)^{-n-2}$, exactly the next case. The base case $n = 0$ is the original function. For the sine formula, differentiation advances the phase by $\pi/2$ and contributes another factor a ; its first case is the chain rule. The exponential formula is verified in the same way.

More generally, repeated use of the power rule on $x > 0$ gives

$$\frac{d^n}{dx^n} x^\alpha = \alpha(\alpha-1) \cdots (\alpha-n+1) x^{\alpha-n} \quad (n \geq 1).$$

When α is a nonnegative integer, derivatives above its degree are zero; this polynomial statement holds on all of $\mathbb{R}$, including 0. For $n \geq 1$ and $x > 0$, $(\ln x)^{(n)} = (-1)^{n-1}(n-1)!/x^n$, starting with the first derivative and then using the reciprocal-power pattern.

Theorem 2.5 (Leibniz's Formula)

Let f, g have derivatives through order n on an open interval I , where $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Then

$$(fg)^{(n)}(x) = \sum_{k=0}^n \binom{n}{k} f^{(k)}(x) g^{(n-k)}(x), \quad x \in I.$$



Each of the n differentiations acts on either the first factor or the second. The coefficient counts the ways of choosing which k differentiations act on f . For $n = 2$, the formula is $f''g + 2f'g' + fg''$.

Proof Strategy. After one more differentiation, a term contributes once by differentiating its f factor and once by differentiating its g factor. Terms with the same final orders then combine by Pascal's identity. This explains the binomial coefficients instead of asking us to memorize them.

Proof The case $n = 0$ is $fg = fg$. Assume the order- n identity holds for functions with n derivatives, and take f, g with $n + 1$ derivatives. Differentiate the finite sum using the product rule:

$$(fg)^{(n+1)} = \sum_{k=0}^n \binom{n}{k} f^{(k+1)} g^{(n-k)} + \sum_{k=0}^n \binom{n}{k} f^{(k)} g^{(n+1-k)}.$$

The extreme terms are $f^{(n+1)}g$ and $fg^{(n+1)}$. To see the indexing explicitly, set $j = k + 1$ in the first sum and $j = k$ in the second. They become

$$\sum_{j=1}^{n+1} \binom{n}{j-1} f^{(j)} g^{(n+1-j)} \quad \text{and} \quad \sum_{j=0}^n \binom{n}{j} f^{(j)} g^{(n+1-j)}.$$

The $j = n + 1$ term appears only in the first sum, and the $j = 0$ term only in the second; both coefficients are 1. For $1 \leq j \leq n$, the coefficient of $f^{(j)} g^{(n+1-j)}$ is $\binom{n}{j-1} + \binom{n}{j} = \binom{n+1}{j}$. This gives the order- $n + 1$ identity and completes the induction. Continuity of the highest derivatives is not required. $\square$

Example 2.30 A product whose higher derivatives truncate Find $(x^2 e^x)^{(n)}$ for every $n \geq 0$.

Strategy. Only the first three derivative orders of the polynomial factor can contribute. Alternatively, differentiation preserves the form e^x times a quadratic, so we can track just that quadratic.

Solution Method 1: Leibniz's formula. For $n \geq 2$, only $k = 0, 1, 2$ survive, giving

$$\binom{n}{0} x^2 e^x + \binom{n}{1} (2x) e^x + \binom{n}{2} (2) e^x.$$

The last coefficient is $2\binom{n}{2} = n(n-1)$, so

$$(x^2 e^x)^{(n)} = e^x (x^2 + 2nx + n(n-1)).$$

Direct checking shows the same expression for $n = 0, 1$. Indeed, these cases give $x^2 e^x$ and $e^x(x^2 + 2x)$, respectively. Treating them separately avoids referring to polynomial derivative orders that are absent from their shorter Leibniz sums.

Solution Method 2: an invariant form and induction. At $n = 0$ the formula is correct. If the order- n polynomial is $P_n = x^2 + 2nx + n(n-1)$, differentiating $e^x P_n$ gives $e^x (P_n + P'_n)$. But $P_n + P'_n = x^2 + 2(n+1)x + n(n+1) = P_{n+1}$. Thus the expression holds for all n .

Leibniz is direct when one factor eventually vanishes under differentiation. The second method reveals a family of forms preserved by the operation, and can be useful even before a general product formula is recognized.

Example 2.31 Simplify before repeating a quotient rule Find the n th derivative of $R(x) = 1/(1-x^2)$ for $x \neq \pm 1$ and $n \geq 0$.

Solution The decomposition $R(x) = \frac{1}{2}[(1-x)^{-1} + (1+x)^{-1}]$ reduces the problem to two reciprocal linear factors. The power and chain rules give

$$R^{(n)}(x) = \frac{n!}{2} \left(\frac{1}{(1-x)^{n+1}} + \frac{(-1)^n}{(1+x)^{n+1}} \right).$$

The original poles remain excluded. Repeated quotient differentiation would be valid but would obscure this simple pattern.

Example 2.32 Find values without finding the whole derivative For $y = \arctan x$, determine $y^{(n)}(0)$ for every $n \geq 1$ without using a power series.

Idea. An explicit formula for every derivative at every point is more than the problem asks. The elementary relation $(1+x^2)y' = 1$ closes under differentiation because the polynomial factor has only two nonzero higher derivative orders. At 0 the relation becomes a short recurrence.

Solution The formula $y' = 1/(1+x^2)$ shows by repeated rules that y has derivatives of all orders on $\mathbb{R}$. Differentiating once gives $(1+x^2)y'' + 2xy' = 0$, so $y''(0) = 0$. For $n \geq 2$, apply Leibniz to the order- n derivative of $(1+x^2)y' = 1$:

$$(1+x^2)y^{(n+1)} + 2nx y^{(n)} + n(n-1)y^{(n-1)} = 0.$$

At 0 this yields $y^{(n+1)}(0) = -n(n-1)y^{(n-1)}(0)$. Starting from $y'(0) = 1$ and $y''(0) = 0$, induction gives the first few values

$$y'''(0) = -2, \quad y^{(4)}(0) = 0, \quad y^{(5)}(0) = 24, \quad y^{(6)}(0) = 0.$$

The recurrence changes the derivative order by two, so the odd and even orders form separate chains. The even chain starts at zero and remains zero. For the odd chain, if $y^{(2m-1)}(0) = (-1)^{m-1}(2m-2)!$ for $m \geq 1$, the recurrence with $n = 2m$ gives

$$y^{(2m+1)}(0) = -(2m)(2m-1)(-1)^{m-1}(2m-2)! = (-1)^m(2m)!.$$

Together with the initial value $y'(0) = 1$, this proves

$$y^{(2m)}(0) = 0 \quad (m \geq 1), \quad y^{(2m+1)}(0) = (-1)^m(2m)! \quad (m \geq 0).$$

The recurrence establishes the result without a Taylor expansion.

2.4.3 Implicit and parametric second derivatives

Differentiating an implicit identity again requires differentiating every occurrence of the dependent function. For a parametric curve, the second derivative with respect to x is obtained by applying $(1/X'(t))d/dt$ to the first derivative. Indeed, if a quantity along the curve is written $Q(t)$, then as a function of x it is $Q(t(x))$. The inverse and chain rules give $dQ/dx = Q'(t)/X'(t)$. For the second derivative we apply this to the whole first-derivative expression $Q(t) = Y'(t)/X'(t)$, rather than to Y alone. Under a local invertibility assumption on X , and with twice differentiable coordinates and $X' \neq 0$, this gives

$$\frac{d^2y}{dx^2} = \frac{1}{X'} \frac{d}{dt} \left(\frac{Y'}{X'} \right) = \frac{Y''X' - Y'X''}{(X')^3}.$$

It is generally not Y''/X'' . The quotient rule in the intermediate step gives

$$\frac{d}{dt} \left(\frac{Y'}{X'} \right) = \frac{Y''X' - Y'X''}{(X')^2};$$

the additional division by X' changes the denominator to $(X')^3$. If X' is nonzero throughout the local parameter interval, the inverse rule applies at every point there and justifies this second use of the chain rule.

Example 2.33 Second derivatives from two descriptions Find y'' for the upper circle branch $y = \sqrt{4-x^2}$, $-2 < x < 2$, and for $x = t^2$, $y = t^3$, $t > 0$. Check each answer by its alternative description.

Solution Circle: implicit calculation. The branch is twice differentiable by the elementary rules and its positive radicand. Differentiating $x^2+y^2 = 4$ twice gives $2+2(y')^2+2yy'' = 0$. The first differentiation is $2x+2yy' = 0$. In the second, y and y' both depend on x , so $(yy')' = (y')^2 + yy''$ by the product rule. Since $y' = -x/y$ and $y > 0$,

$$y'' = -\frac{1+(x/y)^2}{y} = -\frac{4}{y^3}.$$

Circle: explicit check. Differentiating $-x(4-x^2)^{-1/2}$ gives $-(4-x^2)^{-1/2} - x^2(4-x^2)^{-3/2} = -4/(4-x^2)^{3/2}$, the same answer.

Solution Parameter calculation. The first derivative is $3t/2$. Differentiating it with respect to t and dividing by $2t$ gives $y'' = 3/(4t)$. The intermediate derivative $3/2$ is the rate of change of the slope per unit t ; division by

$2t = dx/dt$ converts it to change of slope per unit x . **Elimination check.** Since $y = x^{3/2}$ for $x > 0$, the second derivative is $3/(4\sqrt{x}) = 3/(4t)$. The condition $t > 0$ both selects the branch and makes the division valid.

The implicit description retains the geometry of the constraint. Elimination is an efficient check when a simple explicit branch is available. The parameter calculation keeps track of the variable with respect to which the derivative is being taken.

2.4.4 Higher differentials

For a function $y = f(x)$ of an independent variable x , the first differential is $f'(x)dx$. To repeat the operation, we hold the increment dx constant while differentiating the coefficient with respect to x . One can make this convention concrete by choosing a real increment h once and writing $dx = h$. The function of the base point is then $x \mapsto f'(x)h$. Its differential for that same fixed increment is

$$(f'(x)h)'h = f''(x)h^2.$$

Thus the second differential measures the first-order change of the first-differential coefficient as the base point moves, with the chosen input increment held fixed.

Definition 2.5

For an independent variable x and an n -times differentiable function f , the n th differential (高阶微分) is

$$d^n y = f^{(n)}(x)(dx)^n.$$

It is obtained recursively by applying d to the preceding expression, keeping dx fixed.



For example, $y = x^3$ gives $dy = 3x^2 dx$, $d^2 y = 6x(dx)^2$, and $d^3 y = 6(dx)^3$. In this convention $d^2 x = 0$, whereas $(dx)^2$ need not be zero. The former differentiates $dx = h$, which is held constant; the latter is the ordinary square h^2 of that chosen increment. Neither is the finite second difference of a function.

Example 2.34 Three different second-order objects For $f(x) = x^3$ at the base point $a = 1$, with $dx = h$, compute $d^2 y$, $(dy)^2$ and the forward second difference

$$\Delta_h^2 f(1) = f(1 + 2h) - 2f(1 + h) + f(1).$$

Explain what each operation does.

Solution Since $f'(1) = 3$ and $f''(1) = 6$, the differentials give

$$dy = 3h, \quad d^2 y = 6h^2, \quad (dy)^2 = 9h^2.$$

The notation $d^2 y$ means applying the differential operation twice with its fixed-increment convention; squaring dy instead squares the first derivative's coefficient as well. For the finite difference, evaluate the original function at three points:

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta_h^2 f(1) &= (1 + 6h + 12h^2 + 8h^3) - 2(1 + 3h + 3h^2 + h^3) + 1 \\ &= 6h^2 + 6h^3. \end{aligned}$$

It differs from $d^2 y$ by $6h^3$, although after division by h^2 it tends to the same value 6 as $h \rightarrow 0$. This conclusion was obtained from the exact cubic identity, not from an assumed general finite-difference theorem. Likewise, the exact first increment is $3h + 3h^2 + h^3$: its quadratic term is $\frac{1}{2}d^2 y$, not $d^2 y$. General polynomial approximation formulas and their remainder conditions will be established later.

Suppose now that $y = f(u)$, $u = g(x)$, with both functions twice differentiable on the relevant open

intervals and x independent. Differentiate $dy = f'(u)du$ once more:

$$d^2y = f''(u)(du)^2 + f'(u)d^2u, \quad d^2u = g''(x)(dx)^2. \quad (2.2)$$

Indeed, first differentiate $f(g(x))$ to get $f'(g(x))g'(x)$. Differentiating this product once more gives

$$(f \circ g)''(x) = \underbrace{f''(g(x))g'(x)}_{\text{derivative of } f'(g(x))} g'(x) + f'(g(x))g''(x).$$

Multiplication by $(dx)^2$, together with $(du)^2 = (g'(x))^2(dx)^2$ and $d^2u = g''(x)(dx)^2$, proves (2.2). Unlike the independent increment dx , the coefficient of $du = g'(x)dx$ varies with x . The extra term is why the simple first-differential invariance does not extend unchanged to order two. For an affine substitution $g(x) = ax + b$, $g'' = 0$ and that particular extra term vanishes.

Example 2.35 The missing second-order term Take $y = u^2$, $u = x^2$. Compute d^2y directly in x , and then by the substitution formula.

Solution Method 1: direct differentiation. Since $y = x^4$, $d^2y = 12x^2(dx)^2$.

Solution Method 2: preserve both terms. Here $du = 2x dx$ and $d^2u = 2(dx)^2$. Thus

$$d^2y = 2(du)^2 + 2u d^2u = 8x^2(dx)^2 + 4x^2(dx)^2.$$

This agrees with the direct answer. Keeping only $2(du)^2$ loses the changing rate of u itself. For example, at $x = 1$ the incomplete expression would be $8(dx)^2$, while the correct value is $12(dx)^2$. At $x = 0$ both happen to vanish, so testing only that point would fail to reveal the omitted term.

The direct method is a useful check. The two-term expression explains structurally where the additional contribution comes from.

2.4.5 Methods and further remarks

For high-order calculations, inspect the expression before differentiating repeatedly. A polynomial factor suggests a truncated Leibniz sum. A rational expression with simple linear factors suggests decomposition. A stable family such as an exponential times a polynomial suggests induction within that family. If only values at one point are requested, a low-order differential identity may yield a recurrence more efficiently than a global formula.

At a special point, use the recursive definition to compute each new derivative. Do not substitute that point into a formula proved only off the point. For parameter derivatives, write the operator $(1/X')d/dt$ explicitly. For higher differentials, identify which variable is independent before treating an increment as constant. Distinguish differentiation of a quantity from squaring it, and distinguish both operations from evaluating the original function at several separated points. An estimate such as $r(h) = o(h)$ describes function values on a specified scale; it does not permit differentiating the remainder without additional hypotheses and a new argument.

Looking Ahead. Higher derivatives provide coefficients for more accurate local models. A formula involving those coefficients does not yet come with a remainder estimate. Taylor's theorem will later explain when the corresponding polynomial approximates the function and how its error is controlled.

Exercise 2.4

1. For $f(x) = x^5 - 2x^2 + 1$, find f'' , $f^{(5)}$, and $f^{(6)}$.
2. Find the 2026th derivative of $\sin x$ and the n th derivative of $\cos(3x)$ for $n \geq 1$.
3. Prove by induction that $(e^{-2x})^{(n)} = (-2)^n e^{-2x}$ for $n \geq 0$.

4. Find $(1/(2-x))^{(n)}$ for $x \neq 2$ and $n \geq 0$; check the sign at the first two orders.
5. Find d^2y and d^3y for $y = \ln x$, $x > 0$, with x independent.
6. A particle has position $s(t) = t^4 - 2t^2$ metres. Find velocity and acceleration, including their units.
7. Find $(x \sin x)^{(n)}$ for $n \geq 1$ and explain why the Leibniz sum has only two terms.
8. Find $(1/(x^2 - 4))^{(n)}$ for $x \neq \pm 2$, $n \geq 0$, by decomposition into linear factors.
9. For $x = t^3$, $y = t^2$, $t > 0$, compute d^2y/dx^2 in two ways.
10. If a twice differentiable branch satisfies $y^2 + xy = 2$, derive a formula for y'' where $2y + x \neq 0$. Evaluate it at $(1, 1)$.
11. For $y = \sin u$, $u = x^2$, compute d^2y using both terms in (2.2).
12. Show that $f(x) = x|x|$ is C^1 on $\mathbb{R}$ but has no second derivative at 0.
13. Let $y = e^x \cos x$. Verify that $y'' - 2y' + 2y = 0$ and use it to give a recurrence for $y^{(n)}(0)$.
14. Find A, B, C so that $f(x) = Ax^2 + Bx + C$ for $x \leq 0$ and $f(x) = e^x + \sin x$ for $x > 0$ is C^2 on $\mathbb{R}$.
15. Prove that existence of $f''(a)$ implies continuity of f' at a . Give an example showing that continuity of f' at a does not imply existence of $f''(a)$.
16. For $f(x) = x|x|$, compute $[f(h) - 2f(0) + f(-h)]/h^2$ and compare with existence of $f''(0)$. Explain why the symmetric second quotient cannot define the ordinary second derivative.

Supplement Exercises

- S1. For $m \in \mathbb{N}_{>0}$, find the largest k such that $f(x) = |x|^{2m+1}$ belongs to $C^k(\mathbb{R})$. Prove the endpoint order by the recursive definition.
- S2. Set $f(0) = 0$, $f(x) = x^4 \sin(1/x)$ for $x \neq 0$. Find $f''(0)$ and determine whether f'' is continuous there.
- S3. Find $(x^m e^{ax})^{(n)}$ for $m, n \in \mathbb{N}$ and $a \in \mathbb{R}$. State a formula that also covers $a = 0$ without an undefined power 0^0 .
- S4. Derive the third derivative of $f(g(x))$ assuming both functions are three times differentiable. Interpret the three groups of terms and check with $f(u) = u^2$, $g(x) = x^2$.
- S5. Suppose f is twice differentiable and has a twice differentiable inverse g near $b = f(a)$, with $f'(a) \neq 0$. Derive $g''(b)$ in terms of $f'(a)$ and $f''(a)$.
- S6. For $y = (\arcsin x)^2$ on $(-1, 1)$, prove $(1 - x^2)y'' - xy' = 2$ by direct differentiation, without dividing by y' at 0. Use Leibniz's formula to compute all derivatives at 0.
- S7. Let P be a polynomial of degree at most m . Prove $(P(x)e^x)^{(n)} = e^x \sum_{k=0}^{\min(m,n)} \binom{n}{k} P^{(k)}(x)$. Explain what this says about the dependence on n for fixed x .
- S8. For a three-times differentiable parametrization with a local inverse for X and $X' \neq 0$ on the interval, derive d^3y/dx^3 by applying $(1/X')d/dt$ to the second-derivative formula.
- S9. Let $y = f(u)$, $u = ax + b$, where a, b are constants and f has n derivatives. Prove $d^n y = f^{(n)}(u)(du)^n$ for independent x and $n \geq 1$, including $a = 0$. Explain why a nonlinear substitution generally needs extra terms.
- S10. Set $f(0) = 0$ and $f(x) = x^3 \sin(1/x)$ for $x \neq 0$. Determine whether $f''(0)$ exists. Compare with the approximation $f(h) = o(h^2)$ and explain why a small function remainder alone does not license differentiating that remainder twice.